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Educational Research and Innovation

Everybody Cares About Using Education Research Sometimes

Perspectives of Knowledge Intermediaries



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PERSPECTIVES OF KNOWLEDGE INTERMEDIARIES

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BETTER POLICIES FOR BETTER LIVES

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Foreword

Education research plays a critical role in shaping effective policies and practices that empower individuals and societies to thrive in an ever-evolving world. The Centre for Educational Research and Innovation (CERI) remains committed to supporting countries with timely research insights and forward-thinking approaches, helping them design education systems that are both robust and future-ready. Central to CERI's mission is the acknowledgment of education research as a key pillar for achieving quality education. The Strengthening the Impact of Education Research project has been a vital part of this mission, providing countries with evidence-based insights to enhance the use of research in policy making and practice.

This report, *Everybody Cares About Using Education Research in Policy and Practice Sometimes*, marks the third and final publication of the project. The first report, *Who Cares About Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?*, mapped the overarching landscape of actors and mechanisms that support research use. The second report, *Who Really Cares About Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?*, explored how to develop a culture of research engagement, offering tools and processes to help countries foster this culture. Building on these foundational studies, this final publication shifts its focus to the field, examining how a diverse range of organisations engage in knowledge mobilisation to bridge the gap between education research, policy and practice.

Drawing on data from the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education, this report sheds light on the perspectives and activities of 288 knowledge intermediaries from 34 countries, organisations that enable policy makers' and practitioners' engagement with research to support their practices and decision making. These include formal intermediaries, research institutes, inspectorates, consultancies and teacher unions. It explores the ways in which these organisations support the engagement of policy makers and practitioners with research, characterising their knowledge mobilisation activities and examining their perceived effectiveness and impact. Through this, the report offers a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of the international landscape of knowledge mobilisation in education.

Everybody Cares About Using Education Research in Policy and Practice Sometimes represents a culmination of the Strengthening the Impact of Education Research project's work. It offers valuable guidance for countries looking to improve their use of research to inform policies and practices, ultimately strengthening their education systems. We hope this report inspires meaningful action and dialogue among policy makers, practitioners, researchers and other education stakeholders committed to advancing the use of evidence in education.

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Executive Summary

Exploring new data from the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (henceforth, the intermediaries' survey), this report delves into the experiences, perspectives and activities of a diverse range of 288 educational organisations in 34 countries, including formal knowledge intermediaries, research institutes, inspectorates and consultancies. By exploring how these organisations facilitate the use of education research in policy and practice, this report aims to paint a comprehensive picture of knowledge mobilisation on the ground. The report follows the first two publications of the OECD's *Strengthening the Impact of Education Research* project, which presented the perspectives of policy makers, using data from the project's 2021 policy survey.

All respondent organisations engage in a variety of knowledge mobilisation activities, yet some gaps remain

Although there are more and more formal knowledge intermediaries in education – and they cover an increasingly wide geographical area – it is not just formal intermediaries that play a role in knowledge mobilisation. Research institutions and consulting firms are particularly active, but initial teacher education providers, inspectorates and teacher unions also care about mobilising evidence. However, there is space to further develop knowledge mobilisation as a professional discipline in education. The intermediaries' survey data show that very few organisations develop the skills and capacity of intermediaries to effectively broker knowledge. An important activity to build the knowledge base on knowledge mobilisation would be to generate self- and peer-reflection on knowledge mobilisation initiatives across intermediaries. However, while some of these actors have substantive experience and engage in innovative practices, knowledge exchange to facilitate substantial learning across intermediaries is still limited. More efforts are needed for a better understanding of what works, what is generalisable and how to apply effective initiatives across contexts. Key partners, such as initial teacher education institutions and professional development providers, should work collaboratively to build the skills teachers and school leaders need to access relevant evidence and thoughtfully engage with it to improve teaching and school practices.

Education research is increasingly synthesised and made accessible

Many organisations report that they disseminate research evidence in user-friendly formats, such as briefs. This is a crucial aspect of knowledge mobilisation, but it is not how research achieves impact. One way to enhance the impact of such user-friendly formats is to bring them together in an evidence repository. Such repositories ideally have transparent inclusion criteria, standards and an easily navigable interface for time-poor practitioners and policy makers. Among the intermediaries' survey respondents, 99 organisations claimed to curate and maintain an evidence repository. There are several well-established repositories in OECD countries and new ones are emerging, but policy makers and practitioners are still unsure where they can find evidence tailored for their specific needs. Despite initially being seen as a way to organise and make accessible vast swathes of research, this activity needs to be co-ordinated and aligned,

otherwise there is a risk of information overload. A lack of co-ordination may also result in duplication of efforts and inefficient use of resources, while allowing important knowledge gaps to remain.

At present, funding structures for both research generation and mobilisation do not appropriately reflect the time, effort and money needed to actually use research. Much knowledge mobilisation is funded through research funding, which often favours simple dissemination and communication approaches that frequently have very limited impact, rather than more ambitious partnership work that is more likely to support quality engagement with the evidence base.

There are several barriers preventing research on knowledge mobilisation itself being synthesised into user-friendly formats

The growing body of knowledge and experience on knowledge mobilisation itself has not been synthesised and made widely accessible. There are also still knowledge gaps, notably on the effectiveness of various knowledge mobilisation activities. A key reason for this is the limited evaluation of current knowledge mobilisation initiatives; evaluation is often sporadic and limited to simple metrics, such as counting citations or event participants. Funding structures rarely incentivise the synthesis of research on effective knowledge mobilisation into a coherent and cumulative evidence base that intermediaries can draw on. A lack of foundational knowledge of "what works" in knowledge mobilisation makes it difficult for new intermediaries to develop robust strategies and work plans.

Formal intermediaries are well-placed to be role models in many systems, and can support capacity building and evaluative thinking

Independent formal intermediaries can act as critical counterparts in supporting the systemic efforts of policy organisations, e.g. the mapping of actors and their activities, and the co-ordination of knowledge mobilisation activities (locally or more broadly). Formal intermediary organisations could also play an important leading role in improved knowledge exchange by designing and implementing capacity building for their own staff and other intermediary actors to develop brokerage skills. These organisations should also be role models in developing evaluative thinking around knowledge mobilisation. This can involve systematically reflecting on and, to the extent possible, evaluating and measuring the impact of their own activities, as well as supporting or conducting rigorous evaluations of other organisations' activities.

Improved co-ordination can maximise the benefits of knowledge mobilisation

Ministries and intermediaries often have differing perspectives on the key barriers preventing more effective research use in their systems, which stems in part from the different spaces they respectively occupy in the landscape but also suggests a need for better communication and co-ordination. Policy makers should foster collaborative environments where feedback from intermediaries is actively sought and integrated in policy work.

The rich and diverse landscape of knowledge mobilisation showcased in this report is a promising indication that many education systems are increasingly striving to be evidence-informed. A key challenge is to ensure that such activity is effective and avoids duplication. This necessitates more co-ordination effort at the system-level, including ensuring overview of actors and an up-to-date understanding of the role of different intermediary organisations, their interests and their capacity. Such a mapping, capacity assessment and reflection on roles could be the basis for co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at different levels. Overall, such system-level co-ordination could be mandated to formal intermediaries or to central agencies, such as ministries, who can support intermediary organisations and networks through grants aimed at promoting their co-ordination, collaboration and peer learning.

1 Between research, policy and practice: A survey of knowledge mobilisation

Nóra Révai, OECD

This introductory chapter provides an overview of the rationale and aims of this report. It presents the OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education, which serves as the empirical basis for the report. The chapter first outlines the motivation for conducting the survey and states the key research questions. It then describes the target group and respondents of the survey. The content of the survey is presented, along with conceptual and practical challenges of its development. The chapter concludes by outlining the structure of the report and providing a guide for the readers.

Introduction

“Science is much more than a body of knowledge. It is a way of thinking. […] Science invites us to let the facts in, even when they don't conform to our preconceptions. […] This kind of thinking… is an essential tool for a democracy in an age of change” (Sagan, 1990[1]). Engaging with evidence involves stepping out of one’s comfort zone, critically reflecting on one’s actions, and being prepared to confront prior assumptions with an open mind. The push for education systems to embrace evidence has been around for more than a quarter of a century. Yet, despite countries' significant investments over the past decades, basing decisions on sound evidence seems to be a persistent problem for policy makers and practitioners.

Since the late 1990s, the OECD Centre for Educational Research and Innovation (CERI) has been supporting countries in overcoming this challenge (see e.g. (OECD, 2003[2]; 2007[3]; Köster, Shewbridge and Krämer, 2020[4]; Shewbridge and Köster, 2021[5])). Over the past two decades, the educational landscape has seen an expansion of actors, including brokerage agencies, What Works centres, government researchers, and research champions in schools and ministries, all aiming to enhance research impact (OECD, 2022[6]). In 2021, CERI launched the Strengthening the Impact of Education Research project to better understand “what works in what works”. This initiative began by mapping countries' mechanisms of and barriers to facilitating research use and identifying the diverse actors involved. The findings were presented in two reports. The first one – *Who Cares About Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?* (OECD, 2022[6]) – focused on mapping the landscape of actors, mechanisms and barriers. The second one – *Who Really Cares About Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?* (OECD, 2023[7]) – continued this discussion, outlining ways in which educational organisations and systems can cultivate a culture of evidence use. The data painted a rich and diversified landscape of actors playing various roles in facilitating the use of education research (Hill, 2022[8]). The reports also portrayed a number of promising structures and processes for bridging the research-policy and research-practice gaps, as well as for generating a culture of research use locally. However, major barriers to bridging these gaps remain for education systems.

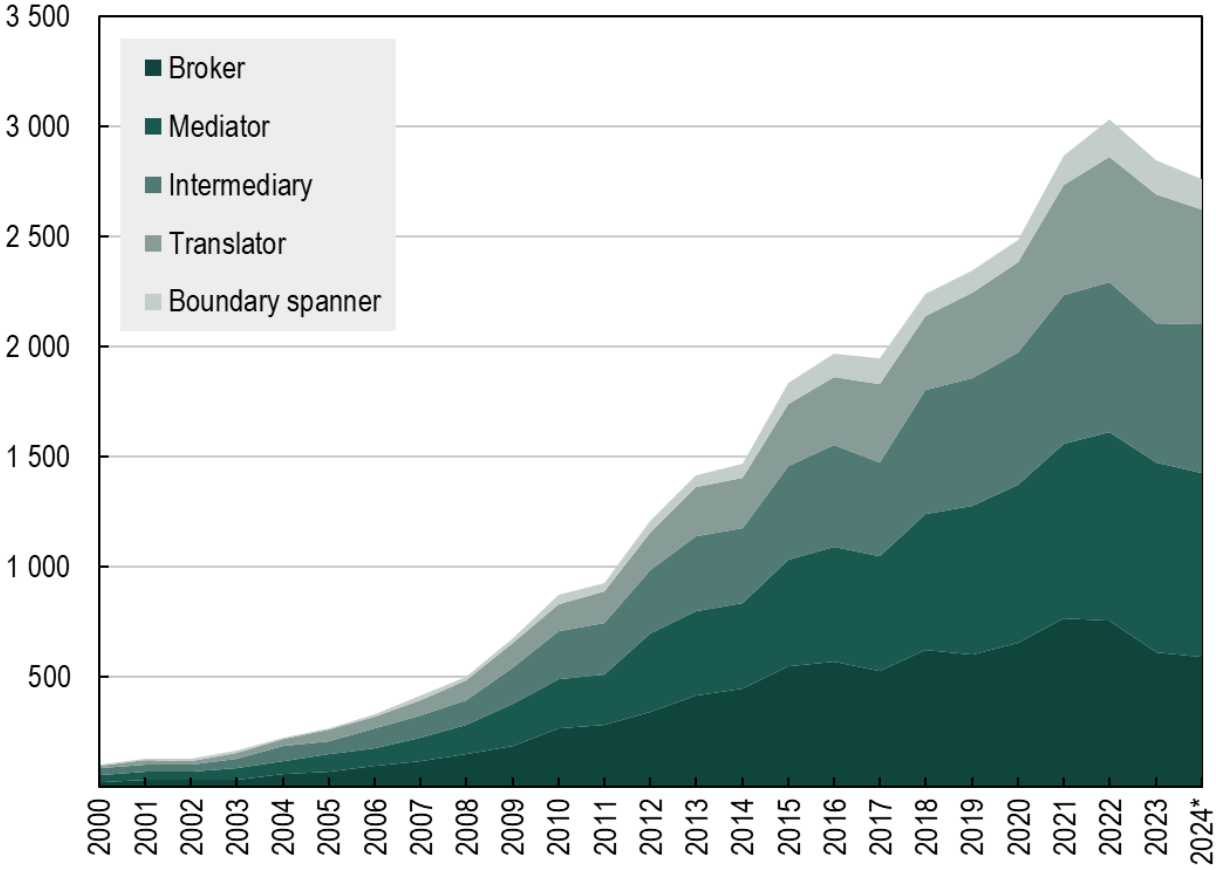
These two previous reports drew on the 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey (henceforth the policy survey), which collected data from 37 ministries of education in 29 countries. The resulting data captured the perspectives of policy makers, which are fundamental to identifying developments and gaps in the field from the systems’ viewpoint but are insufficient to gain a valid picture of all of the actors and mechanisms that facilitate evidence use. This report shifts the focus to the field. Through new data from the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (henceforth, the intermediaries’ survey), it delves into the experiences and activities of a diverse range of educational organisations, including formal knowledge intermediaries, research institutes, inspectorates and consultancies. By exploring how these organisations facilitate the use of education research in policy and practice, it aims to paint a comprehensive picture of knowledge mobilisation at the ground level.

This chapter begins by discussing the motivation for conducting the survey. It then presents key considerations of the survey design: who the respondents are and what the survey contained. Finally, the chapter provides guidance for the readers on how to engage with the report and reflect on its analyses.

Why a survey on knowledge mobilisation?

There is a growing body of evidence on knowledge mobilisation, indicated in the literature by a multiplicity of terms and concepts (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[9]). A wide cross-sector search of studies related to knowledge mobilisation in Google Scholar shows a clear increase in the use of terms describing actors who support knowledge mobilisation such as “broker”, “mediator”, “intermediary”, “translator” and “boundary spanner” since 2000 (see Figure 1.1).

Figure 1.1. Number of studies on knowledge mobilisation by term and year (2000-2024)



Note: 2024 data is until 31 October. Data were collected through a Google Scholar search, using the following code for the term "broker": "research" AND "knowledge" AND "broker|brokers" AND ("research|knowledge mobilisation|mobilization" OR "knowledge translation|mediation" OR "knowledge-to-action" OR "evidence-based|evidence-informed policy|practice"). For the other terms, the used codes were equivalent.
Source: Based on Torres and Steponavičius (2022[9]), "More than just a go-between: The role of intermediaries in knowledge mobilisation", *OECD Education Working Papers*, No. 285, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/aa29cfd3-en, updated in 2024.

StatLink https://stat.link/1o34ws

Despite the increase shown in the graph, at least three important research gaps remain (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[9]). First, for a long time, research focused primarily on individuals acting as intermediaries, rather than organisations across different sectors. While organisations are inseparable from the individuals who operate within them (Belkhodja et al., 2007[10]), a unique focus on the latter may overlook the impact of an organisation's characteristics, such as its size, structures and processes (MacKillop, Quarmby and Downe, 2020[11]). In recent years, studies on organisations as intermediaries have started to emerge (Shewchuk and Farley-Ripple, 2022[12]; Oliver et al., 2022[13]). Second, research that studied organisations has predominantly explored formal intermediaries, i.e. those that explicitly identify as intermediaries. Results from the policy survey showed that less than half of respondent systems have formal brokerage agencies (with a primary mandate to facilitate research mobilisation and use) (OECD, 2022[6]). However, many other organisations, such as universities, teacher education institutions and school networks, play important roles in mobilising research knowledge, regardless of whether this is part of their formal mission. Disregarding implicit intermediaries will inevitably fail to give an accurate

picture of knowledge mobilisation efforts in a system. Third, research on intermediaries often primarily explores Anglo-Saxon initiatives and actors. Yet, intermediaries and their work can differ markedly across different education systems.

Importantly, very little is known about the effectiveness of intermediary efforts (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[9]; Boaz, Oliver and Hopkins, 2022[14]; Oliver et al., 2022[13]). Yet, to improve mechanisms and make investments more efficient, countries across the OECD need to know what works in this field – and likewise, if certain efforts do not work, why that is. This knowledge can inform investment, improvements and scaling.

In response to the aforementioned gaps, the OECD conducted the Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education from July to December 2023 to explore the following questions:

- How can knowledge mobilisation activities be characterised across different organisations?
- What do we know about the effectiveness and impact of knowledge mobilisation activities?

Who answered the survey?

Following the motivations laid out in the previous section, this survey focuses on organisations (including departments of bigger organisations) that can play a role in enabling practitioners' and policy makers' engagement with research to support their practices and decision making. Target organisations include formal intermediaries that are expected to focus strongly on knowledge mobilisation; and other, more traditional educational actors, whose primary function is not knowledge mobilisation per se (see Table 1.1).

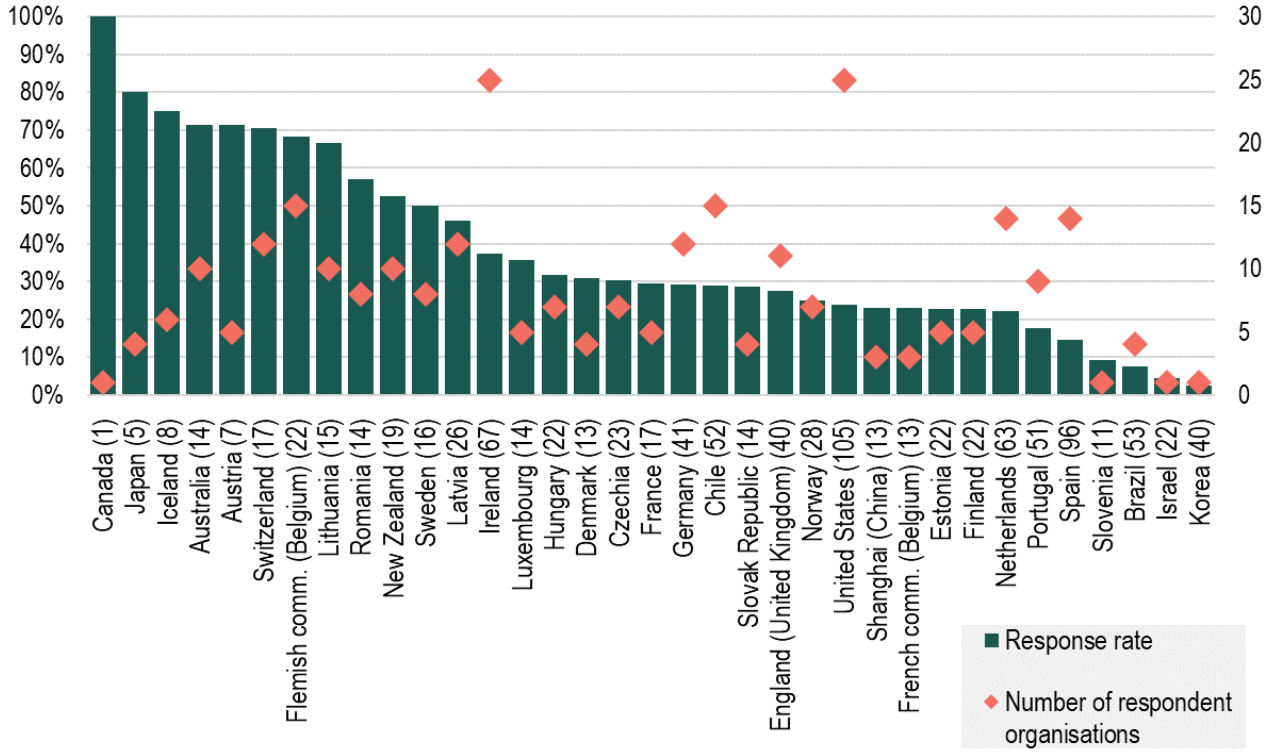
Table 1.1. Target organisations and instructions for sampling

Type of target organisation	Definition	Guidance on sampling
Formal intermediary organisations	Organisations with an explicit mandate to facilitate research use in education policy or practice. E.g. What Works centres, brokerage agencies, public knowledge / research centres, government-affiliated knowledge centres.	If there are many, select the major formal intermediaries. If there are different types (e.g. focusing on different types of knowledge mobilisation activities), try to ensure a balanced coverage of types.
Policy intermediaries embedded in the public administration	Units/departments within a ministry of education or an executive agency with an explicit mandate to facilitate research use in policy. E.g. Knowledge, analytical and research mobilisation units in ministries and in executive agencies.	Only include if there is a formal structure – team, unit or department – in your ministry and/or executive agency at the national or regional level that is specifically dedicated to knowledge mobilisation activities.
Research institutions	Education research institutes/centres: e.g. Faculties of Education. Brokerage units within research organisations such as policy engagement units.	Major Faculties of Education and Policy Engagement Units that have a strong focus on education in your country. In federal systems and big countries, try to ensure a balanced geographical coverage.
Initial teacher education institutions (ITE)	Organisations providing initial teacher training for teacher candidates preparing to work in primary and secondary schools.	Public institutions. Providers of traditional teacher training (exclude alternative routes into teaching). In federal systems and big countries, select the ones that train the most teachers trying to ensure geographical coverage (e.g. Initial teacher education (ITE) institutions training the most teachers per state/province).

Type of target organisation	Definition	Guidance on sampling
Inspectorates and quality assurance services	School inspectorates, agencies that ensure school quality.	Major public bodies that monitor and govern school quality.
Education consultancies	Organisations regularly advising education authorities, schools or other education-related bodies with educational planning, research, project development.	Only major education consultancies that: - Advise high-level bodies such as the ministry, regional authorities, central agency or inspectorate - Cover a large number of clients (e.g. major school networks, rather than just a few individual schools).
Funding organisations	Organisations that fund education research or research mobilisation activities.	Major organisations that give substantive funding to knowledge mobilisation activities and/or education research.
Teacher and school leader unions	Organisations that advance the collective interests of teachers and school leaders.	The largest teacher and school leader unions in terms of membership.

In defining the target organisations, certain decisions had to be made for reasons of feasibility, and thus the list of target organisations is not comprehensive. For instance, professional development providers of educational practitioners would be a relevant type of organisation. They were excluded because, in many countries, this field is highly fragmented with hundreds or thousands of such providers with varying profiles. In these countries, it would have been difficult to select a few representative ones. Research and professional networks also have knowledge mobilisation functions in some countries. To be able to capture organisational features, it was decided to focus on formal organisations only and exclude networks.

Figure 1.2. Number of respondent organisations and response rate per country



Note: In parentheses following country names is the number of organisations targeted (sample size). The left axis shows the response rate, the right axis indicates the number of respondent organisations.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

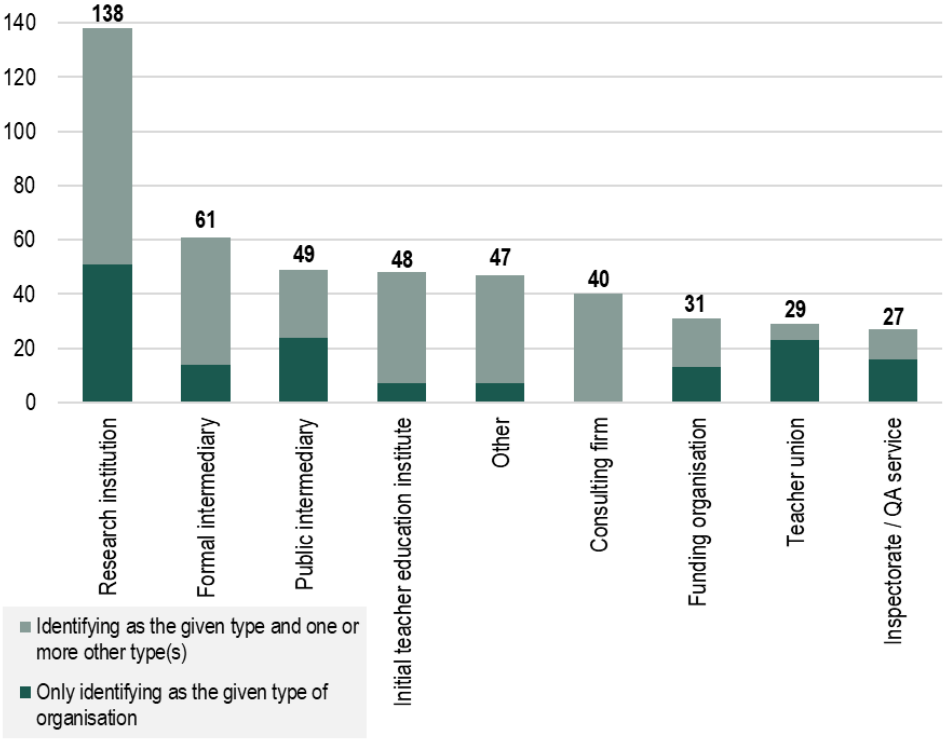
StatLink https://stat.link/q8txl2

To construct the samples, the OECD team asked official country representatives in the CERI Governing Board to help identify relevant organisations, following the guidelines in Table 1.1. In addition, desk research was conducted to identify key organisations, and the broader professional network of the project was mobilised to support sampling. International country comparison is not possible because of the small samples and/or low response rates in many countries (see Figure 1.2).

The types of organisations sampled are not completely distinct. For instance, in most countries, research institutions and initial teacher education (ITE) institutions are within the same organisation or they may even be the same faculty. Therefore, respondents could identify as several types of organisations by selecting all that apply to them.

Altogether, 288 organisations from 34 countries responded to the survey. Research institutes are the most represented type of organisation, which likely reflects the relatively higher number of universities than other types of organisations in most countries (Figure 1.3). Inspectorates and quality assurance agencies are the least common type in the dataset, probably because many countries only have one or two such organisations. Figure 1.4 shows that the most common combination is indeed research and ITE institutes, and that over 30 organisations chose at least three of the given types. In addition, 47 respondents also selected the "Other"[1] category, seven of which did not identify as another type of organisation simultaneously. Various types of organisations (and configurations) were relatively evenly distributed in all countries with a reasonable number of respondents (Figure 1.5).

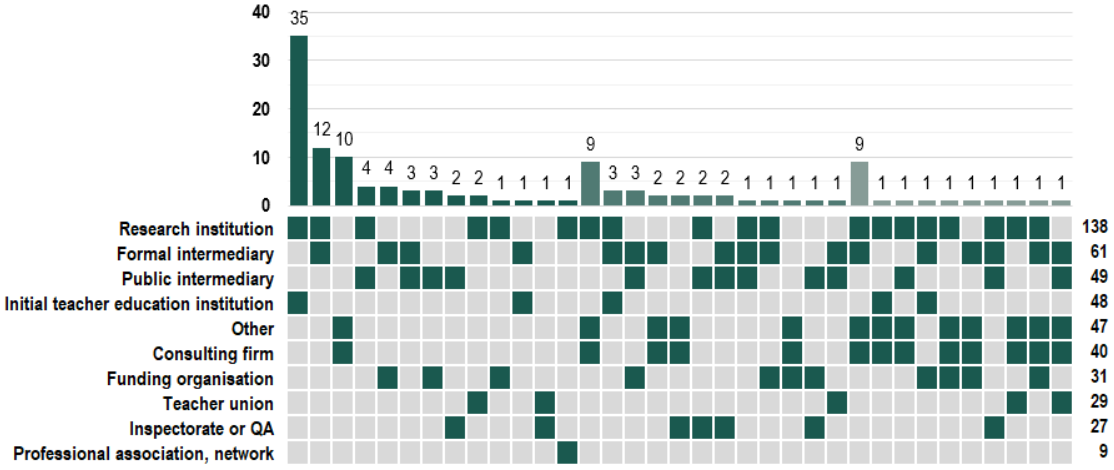
Figure 1.3. Configurations of types of organisations among respondents: Number of respondents per type of organisation



Note: The number indicated above the bars is the number of organisations that identified as the given type altogether (i.e. the sum of the orange and blue bars).
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/mrqvac

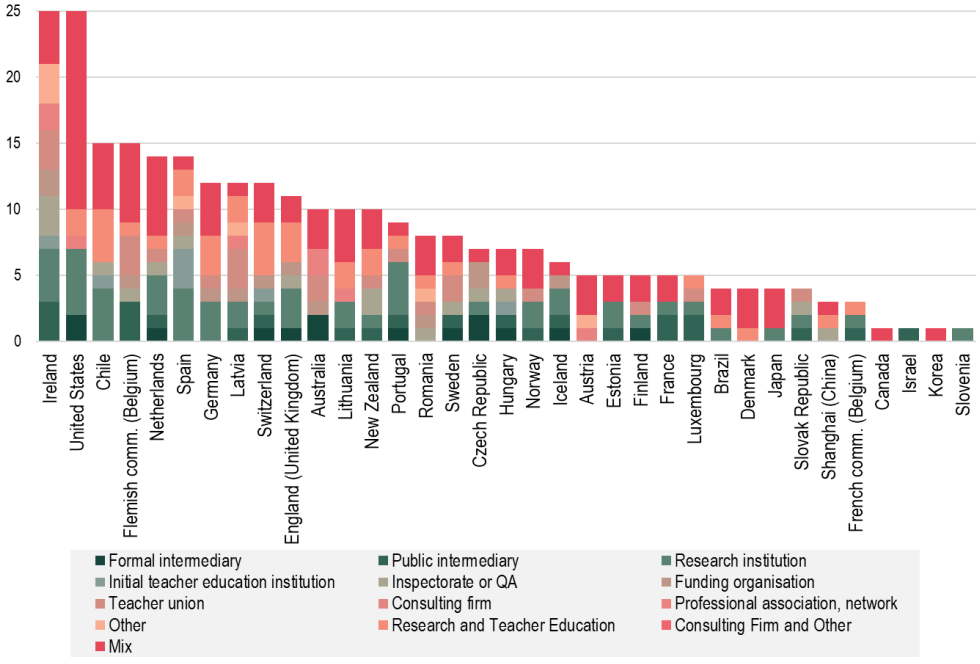
Figure 1.4. Configurations of types of organisations among respondents: Number of intersections



Note: The data show the number of respondents that identified as the types of organisations indicated by dark green dots underneath the bars. The data is arranged in descending order of the size of intersection in terms of the number of types of organisations indicated and the number of respondents.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/mlp2eb

Figure 1.5 Configurations of types of organisations among respondents: Types of organisations per country



Notes: The data show the number of respondents that identified *only* as the given type of organisation per country. In addition, it includes the two most common overlaps: 1) research and initial teacher education institutes but nothing else; 2) consulting firms and any other type of organisation. The category "Mix" includes all other combinations.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/eb9azi

Overall, apart from research institutes, the number of different types of organisations is not very high. This implies that organisation-type-specific analyses need to be interpreted with caution and should certainly not be considered as representative. Similarly, country-level analysis is only conducted on a few occasions for countries with at least 10 respondents. Analyses should be considered with caution, as the organisations do not represent the entire field of knowledge mobilisation actors in any of the countries.

What does the survey encompass?

Overview

The survey focuses on knowledge mobilisation, which is used broadly to refer to any *intentional efforts to increase or improve the use of research evidence in education policy and/or practice*. This includes generating policy- or practice-relevant research evidence, making research accessible, enabling different actors to engage with it and supporting organisational and system-level conditions for better research engagement. It maps the activities of respondent organisations, their perceptions of the effectiveness of these activities, the extent and the ways in which they evaluate them. Importantly, the survey included a set of questions that were taken from the project's previous policy survey to allow for comparison between ministries' and intermediary organisations' perspectives on the mechanisms that facilitate the use of research, the appropriateness of resources and barriers to research use. In addition, the survey captures some basic organisational characteristics (see Table 1.2).

Table 1.2. Survey content

Section	Content areas
Organisational characteristics	Type of organisation, funding sources, scope, context, organisational culture with respect to research use[1]
Knowledge mobilisation activities and their perceived effectiveness	• Research generation • Research dissemination and advocacy • Relationships and network building • Training and capacity building of individuals • Organisational development and capacity building • Research use and implementation support • System development, evaluation and scale-up
Evaluation and impact	• Reach/access • Relationships • Competencies of individual actors • Culture, infrastructure and leadership of organisations • Behavioural change in research use and practice • Education and society • Evidence system (regional or national level)
Perceptions on research production, mobilisation and use Mirror questions from the Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey carried out in 2021	• Satisfaction with research use • Perception of research use • Mechanisms • Barriers
Organisation-specific questions	Perceptions of knowledge mobilisation activities; incentives; sources used in knowledge mobilisation activities

Note: Questions on the organisational culture of research use were adapted from the survey developed in the Q Project of Monash University in Australia (Rickinson et al., 2022[15]).

Conceptual framework for knowledge mobilisation

The survey builds on the conceptual model adapted from Best and Holmes (2010[16]), which has since been used widely in knowledge mobilisation research (Hopkins et al., 2021[17]; Boaz et al., 2019[18]), including in OECD work underlying this chapter (OECD, 2022[6]; OECD, 2023[7]). In this model, linear approaches refer to traditional research dissemination or transfer, i.e. making research accessible and communicating it in user-friendly forms. Relational approaches emphasise bringing the research and practitioner or policy communities together, creating partnerships and building capacity for research use. Finally, systems approaches recognise that actors' behaviours are influenced by a range of systemic factors, such as available resources, incentives and mechanisms.

Figure 1.6. Linear, relational and systems approaches to knowledge mobilisation, revisited



Source: Adapted from OECD (2023[7]) *Who Really Cares about Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?: Developing a Culture of Research Engagement*, Educational Research and Innovation, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/bc641427-en; and Boaz (2021[19]) *Push or pull: What does harnessing the use of reserch involve and imply?*, Presentation given at the OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research project meeting on 27 April 2021.

Figure 1.6 represents the embedded nature of the three approaches, highlighting the key elements of each approach included in the survey. It reflects the historic evolution of thinking about knowledge mobilisation – an early focus on linear approaches, a subsequent recognition of the importance of relationships, and finally an understanding that a systems perspective is necessary for high-quality knowledge mobilisation (Boaz et al., 2019[18]; OECD, 2022[6]; Burns and Köster, 2016[20]). The three approaches are not mutually exclusive. Rather, many initiatives contain elements from two or even all three approaches. For example, the England case study in Chapter 3 discusses a systemic mapping of the different actors involved in knowledge mobilisation – an initiative that inherently carries the features of both relational (actors are at its core) and systems approaches.

Conceptual and practical challenges in the development of the survey

Turning a conceptual framework of a complex notion – knowledge mobilisation – into a survey requires practical decisions and some trade-offs. These points must be noted for the interpretation of the analyses presented in this report.

Conceptualising knowledge mobilisation

Numerous terms are used to describe concepts related to knowledge mobilisation in academic literature, and there is no universally agreed definition of any of them, nor on what knowledge mobilisation encompasses.

First, *what is knowledge*? In policy- and practice-related decisions, several knowledge sources need to be combined, including different actors' contextual and professional knowledge, their values and the political agenda or school programme (OECD, 2023[7]). These decisions involve actors from different communities interacting, considering all these knowledge sources alongside research evidence. However, the focus of the survey is on knowledge coming from research rather than other sources. The report understands research to be a form of systematic investigation of educational and learning processes with a view to increasing or revising current knowledge. Some of the case studies featured in the report help bring out the nuances and complexities of mobilising research evidence in combination with other sources of knowledge.

Second, *what is mobilisation*? Certain conceptual frameworks distinguish between research production, mediation and use (Torres, 2022[21]; Gough et al., 2011[22]), while more recent frameworks refer to research production, engagement and decision making (Gough, Thomas and Oliver, 2019[23]; Gough, Maidment and Sharples, 2018[24]). Knowledge mobilisation has sometimes been used as an equivalent of mediation or engagement, sometimes referring to the entirety of the frameworks. The boundaries between conducting, mediating (or mobilising) and using research have become increasingly blurred. For instance, it is difficult to tease apart production, mediation and use when research is co-produced with a strong involvement of users (e.g. practitioners) in the research process itself. The two previous OECD reports (OECD, 2022[6]; OECD, 2023[7]) discussed several such examples and called for a closer connection between research production and use. Therefore, the survey considered the generation of research evidence as part of knowledge mobilisation, even though much of academic research is still conducted largely isolated from policy or practice, not necessarily considering its impact beyond the academic community (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[9]).

Distinguishing knowledge mobilisation and research use is equally complicated. Implementing a research-informed intervention in a school or designing policies through thoughtful engagement with research evidence are, of course, examples of knowledge mobilisation from the perspective of the school or ministry/authority. As the survey aimed more at understanding intermediary roles, i.e. activities that support such engagement, these forms of direct research engagement were not captured. This distinction is however not always clear, particularly when it comes to co-designing practices and policies in the form of research-practice or research-policy partnerships or through implementation support by any type of intermediary. Thus, forms of research use (implementation) appear in the survey somewhat indirectly under partnerships and co-design activities.

Selecting terms that mean the same to all

Many other concepts are similarly difficult to define, including research, policy, practice and intermediary. In addition, different countries tend to use different terms. No single term can appropriately reflect the complexities described above, and an international survey also needs to consider language barriers and difficulties of translation. For instance, while the two previous reports favoured the term research *engagement* rather than *use* (to avoid the simplistic notion that research findings are directly and easily applicable in education practice or policy), the survey uses these terms interchangeably. The rationale for this simplification was to keep the survey accessible (research use is a more immediately understandable concept) and easier to translate to other languages.

While the survey included a glossary to support respondents in interpreting the terms, this cannot exclude the possibility of ambiguity in interpretation. Where appropriate, the analysis in this report will draw the reader's attention to these.

Transforming the framework into a set of activities

The two previous reports (OECD, 2022[6]; 2023[7]) and the academic literature more generally emphasise that knowledge mobilisation and research engagement reflect complex processes. This complexity had to be translated into questions that can be explored through a survey. To this end, 21 knowledge mobilisation activities were identified based on a review of the literature and previous surveys on this theme (see Chapter 3). To avoid the impression that research use and knowledge mobilisation are simple processes that can be broken down into a small set of clearly distinct activities, the report features several case studies that demonstrate how various activities play out in a more complex initiative.

The survey also aimed to capture linear, relational and systems approaches. While some activities can be more clearly categorised as falling under one specific approach, many may fall into several categories at the same time. Portraying systems approaches as single activities may seem particularly paradoxical given that a systems perspective is precisely about understanding how the various elements of a system are connected and affect one another. Nevertheless, it is possible to capture systems approaches as activities targeting system development at two levels. First, considering an organisation as a system, through support activities that aim to improve knowledge mobilisation targeting various elements of the organisational system (such as its leadership, culture, processes and infrastructure). Second, considering the wider education system, through a set of activities targeting knowledge mobilisation at the local, regional or national level. Going beyond individual activities, a systems approach to knowledge mobilisation can also be seen as a strategy that considers all of the different activities and actors.

Keeping respondents focused on knowledge mobilisation rather than their broad functions

The fact that the survey targeted a range of organisations, most of which are not formal knowledge intermediaries, means that many respondents are not used to thinking about themselves and their activities specifically in terms of knowledge mobilisation. Therefore, some organisations may have responded to some questions with their broader mandate in mind, rather than with respect to their knowledge mobilisation activities. This could be the case, for instance, for questions relating to evaluation. As Chapter 6 highlights, a significant proportion of organisations reported that they measure the impact of their knowledge mobilisation activities on student outcomes. This is surprising and unlikely given the complexity of measuring such impact and the very little presence of such knowledge in the international literature. In light of this challenge, all chapters in this publication call for cautious interpretations and refrain from drawing far-reaching implications.

The above complexities imply that the survey is naturally limited in terms of its scope and perhaps conceptual clarity. Nevertheless, this survey is first of its kind in bringing together the perspectives of a wide range of educational organisations going beyond formal knowledge intermediaries. To the best of the authors' knowledge, it provides the most comprehensive overview of self-reported data focused exclusively on knowledge mobilisation in education to date. Therefore, the authors believe that the data will provide useful food for thought to improve knowledge mobilisation. See Box 1.1 for more information on the survey development and qualitative data.

Box 1.1. Survey development and qualitative data

Survey development

The survey was designed based on an extensive review of the relevant literature (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[9]) and a review of existing surveys in the field. It also considered lessons learnt from the Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey. The development process included iterative rounds of reviews by experts, and piloting through interviews and testing.

The final survey consisted of mandatory and optional questions, some of which were shared across all types of organisations (core questions), while some were specific to certain types of organisations. These included questions with given answer options (single choice, multiple choice and Likert scale) and a few open-ended questions. The data from these latter were coded thematically using an inductive and exploratory approach. The purpose of the coding was to better interpret quantitative data and identify potentially effective knowledge mobilisation practices or novel approaches to feature as illustrative examples and case studies.

Case studies

To complement survey data and develop in-depth case studies of knowledge mobilisation practices (see Table 1.3), semi-structured group and individual interviews were organised with selected organisations that had responded to the survey (in April-June 2024). The selection built strongly on the survey question that asked respondents to describe one or more knowledge mobilisation activities that they perceive as effective or innovative. The criteria included:

- **Diversity in representation** in terms of organisation type and country/region.
- **Unique or innovative approach to knowledge mobilisation** the activity described, goes beyond linear dissemination mechanisms. For example, it can focus on partnership building (e.g. between research-policy), co-design (e.g. between research-practice or research-policy) or combine multiple approaches, including a systems perspective.
- **Evaluation/impact:** There are some indicators of evaluation of the knowledge mobilisation activities.

From an initial longlist of 26 organisations, the team selected nine organisations for group interviews, seven of which accepted to be interviewed.

The aim and structure of the report

This report aims to support countries in reflecting on and improving their research mobilisation. To do so, it provides insights into the international landscape of knowledge mobilisation activities across different organisations in education, as well as their perceived effectiveness and impact.

Much of the literature underlying the report has been presented in the project's previous publications (OECD, 2022[6]; 2023[7]; Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[9]; Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[25]) . Therefore, this report does not include an extensive review of the literature in every chapter. Instead, Chapter 2 provides an analysis of recent studies on knowledge mobilisation in education policy making to give the reader a sense of the increasing body of evidence on this subject. It also offers comparison with other sectors, such as health, environment and criminal justice – as cross-sectoral learning in this field has been emphasised by many stakeholders (OECD, 2022[6]). This is followed by four chapters that analyse the survey described in this introduction. They provide insights into knowledge mobilisation activities carried

out by the surveyed organisations, their perceptions of mechanisms and barriers to facilitate the use of research, funding and other resources involved in their initiatives, as well as their evaluation practices. As a conclusion, the last chapter highlights recent developments and remaining challenges in this field and discusses the next steps. The seven chapters are briefly presented in Table 1.3.

Table 1.3. Structure of the report

Chapter	Content	Case studies
Chapter 1	The current chapter presents the rationale for this work and the questions explored in this report.	None
Chapter 2	Presents findings from a systematic review of knowledge mobilisation research conducted by Kathryn Oliver and colleagues.	None
Chapter 3	Presents a comprehensive heatmap of knowledge mobilisation activities across different types of organisations.	**Netherlands**: Multiple actors **United Kingdom**: Research institute and formal intermediary
Chapter 4	Examines the differing perspectives of ministries of education and knowledge intermediaries regarding the mechanisms that facilitate the use of research and barriers to research use.	**Japan**: Teacher training institute **United States**: Multiple actors
Chapter 5	Explores the funding landscape from the perspective of knowledge intermediaries and funding organisations in education.	**Latvia**: Ministry of Education **Chile**: Formal intermediary
Chapter 6	Examines the extent and ways in which intermediaries evaluate knowledge mobilisation activities. It also reports on the perceived impact of such activities.	**England (United Kingdom):** Formal intermediary. **Germany**: Research and training institute
Chapter 7	Presents recent developments and remaining challenges in the field, and discusses the next steps.	None

Readers' guide to engaging with the data and report

The report is intended to be useful for policy makers in ministries of education and local authorities, and all educational actors that aim to play a role in facilitating the use of research evidence in education policy and practice. These include individuals not just from the surveyed types of intermediary organisations, but also those who did not have a chance to answer this survey (e.g. professional development providers, research and professional associations and networks, and perhaps even schools).

The analytical chapters (3-6) follow a similar structure:

- Key messages
- Introduction to describe the scope of the chapter
- Analysis of three to four data charts that present and interpret the findings. They also include insights from key experts (expert quotes) and examples based on qualitative data.
- Case studies illustrating an aspect of knowledge mobilisation relevant for the chapter. Some case studies draw on practices of one organisation, some provide a broader landscape of several organisations within a country. Most of the case studies included in the chapters draw substantively on follow-up interviews conducted with select respondent organisations.
- Questions for reflection that invite the readers to think about the situation in their own context, what the challenges are and how could they be addressed based on the analysis presented.

The authors invite the readers to engage with the analysis in a critical and thoughtful way – just as the literature describes quality engagement with research (Rickinson et al., 2022[15]). Thoughtful engagement involves comparing, contrasting and combining the findings from the analyses with other sources of knowledge and information. Readers are encouraged to:

- Reflect on the analyses based on their perceptions and knowledge of their own country context, their professional and organisational background, as well as their values and opinions.
- Examine their pre-existing knowledge, assumptions and values and assess if those are in line with the presented findings. If they differ, they can ask themselves:
  - What might be missing from the data or distorting the picture? What might be misleading in the analysis?
  - What might be misleading in my own perceptions of reality? What might be missing from my own knowledge and experience?

The expert quotes illustrate this engagement. They are the result of a meeting the OECD team organised in June 2024 with individuals who work in major knowledge intermediary organisations, have been researching knowledge mobilisation for decades, or have worked on aspects of knowledge mobilisation in policy or practice-oriented organisations. These experts were shown the data presented in this report and were asked to react based on their own knowledge and experience. These pieces are therefore "expert opinions" reflecting the ideas of a few people who have substantive knowledge and experience in the field of knowledge mobilisation.

The analyses and indeed the survey questions themselves can be used as a self-reflection tool that may shape ministries', agencies' as well as intermediary organisations' thinking about their functions, activities, relationships and impact. We wish you a thoughtful engagement with the analyses.

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Note

[1] Qualitative specifications of the "other" category were coded subsequently. 15 respondents were recoded in an already existing category after verification through desk research. Nine organisations were re-categorised as professional associations or networks. These were not originally intended target organisations, but presumably the country representatives that provided the samples considered them to play a major role in knowledge mobilisation. These respondents are not considered in analyses that present data per type of organisation (e.g. the heatmap in Chapter 3), but their responses are taken into account in data not broken down by type of organisation.

2 Factors shaping evidence use in education policy: Findings from a systematic review

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This chapter examines a subset of 85 education papers drawn from an external systematic review of barriers to and facilitators of the use of evidence by policy makers. It also presents the latest trends in research on factors shaping evidence use in education policy. It analyses the main trends in the education subset, draws comparisons with trends in other knowledge domains, and situates these findings within broader OECD research on knowledge mobilisation in education.

Key messages

This chapter represents an analysis of a subset of 85 education papers included in an external systematic review of barriers to and facilitators of the use of evidence by policymakers. It highlights several key trends in research on knowledge mobilisation in education.

- Much research on knowledge mobilisation emerges from just a few Anglo-Saxon countries and contexts, highlighting that more research on knowledge mobilisation from non-Anglo-Saxon contexts is urgently needed. It is also important to better understand how research from Anglo-Saxon contexts can be applied to other contexts, and what aspects of these studies are generalisable. In tangent, international research collaborations could be a way to redress this balance.
- Drawing from lessons learned from other sectors is one way to address long-standing challenges in knowledge mobilisation. Some of the challenges in knowledge mobilisation are remarkably similar across knowledge domains. Some knowledge domains have advanced further in implementing certain types of mechanisms or interventions in knowledge mobilisation. Cross-sectoral learning therefore remains a highly valuable activity for knowledge mobilisation.
- Many studies provide descriptions of knowledge mobilisation initiatives; however, comparatively few of these studies in education also examine their effectiveness. This suggests that more targeted efforts to ensure learning "what works" in these initiatives would be beneficial. This would, in turn, ensure new initiatives are developed based on lessons learned in past initiatives, while building understanding of and consensus on what quality use of evidence in policy processes looks like.
- While systematic reviews can be of great value when compared to individual evidence pieces, there is little to indicate from this data that education policy makers indeed make substantive use of them. As evidence characteristics remain the main factor influencing use of evidence in policy, further research can explore how different types of evidence can be better incorporated into policy.

Introduction

The expectation that education systems should strive to be evidence-informed is now widespread. Interventions designed to make policies more evidence-informed have emerged predominantly in the healthcare sector (Biesta, 2007[1]) – as a result, studies of these interventions, and systematic reviews of these studies, were often by default limited to health policy. However, this is changing. The growth in these interventions has led to increased "research on research use" in policy and practice, which is now much more commonplace across policy and knowledge domains – including not only education but also conservation and environment, city and regional planning, and public administration in general (among other domains). In the education sector, this is partly the result of a strong push towards using evidence by stakeholders in many systems and regions, and yet the impact of research on education policy is still found to be limited (Pellegrini and Vivanet, 2020[2]).

In education, this growth in knowledge mobilisation initiatives takes place against a backdrop of ongoing challenges concerning the existing evidence base in this field. There remain concerns about the quality of qualitative research in this field (too often considered to be of low quality), while others criticise the strong priority given to numerical or statistical data over other types of evidence when designing policies (Gorard, See and Siddiqui, 2020[3]; Burkhardt and Schoenfeld, 2003[4]; Aldridge et al., 2018[5]; Wainwright et al.,

2020[6]; Wrigley, 2018[7]). Overall, a lack of replications of previous studies imply that education research is failing to build a cumulative knowledge base (Van Damme, 2024[8]). The question of how narrowly we should define the types of evidence that are suitable to inform education policy also continues to be the subject of much debate. It has been suggested that this should extend beyond the rigorous qualitative or quantitative enquiry that is often suggested as the minimum evidence standard within the education research (academic) community (Bainbridge, Troppe and Bartley, 2022[9]). And, increasingly, there is recognition that research evidence will not fundamentally inform policy or practice in education and other domains without integration with other sources of knowledge, e.g. professional knowledge (Rickinson et al., 2022[10]; Nutley et al., 2019[11]). Research knowledge does not enter a void but rather competes for space with other types of knowledge, and other inputs to decisions. This recognition has led to a decisive shift in discourse where the generally agreed ambition is to make policy "evidence-informed" rather than "evidence-based" (Nutley et al., 2019[11]).

Drawing on a wider systematic review, conducted in 2024, of studies that examine factors influencing the use of evidence in policy (see Box 2.1), this chapter contributes to these debates by presenting findings from an analysis of a subset of 85 empirical, mostly peer-reviewed education studies published between 2012 and 2022 (see complete list of studies included in the subset in Annex 2.B).

Box 2.1. Systematic reviews: Factors influencing evidence use in policy

2014 systematic review

Oliver et al. (2014[12]) conducted an initial systematic review of factors influencing evidence use in policy in 2014 across multiple knowledge domains. In this review, 145 studies were included, with over half published between 2010 and 2014.

2024 systematic review

In 2024, an updated review was conducted in which 2 199 studies identified across multiple knowledge domains were included (for a detailed methodology, see Annex 2.A). As the authors note, the goal of the 2024 review was to determine how research activity in this area has changed since 2014 (Oliver et al., forthcoming[13]). The significantly larger number of studies included in the 2024 review points to a significant boom in published, peer-reviewed research on the topic of evidence-informed policy.

Analysis of education subset

The subset of studies examined in this chapter is taken from the 2024 review (see (EPPI, 2024[14])). The 85 papers analysed were all coded as belonging to the education knowledge domain.

The chapter follows a three-pronged approach:

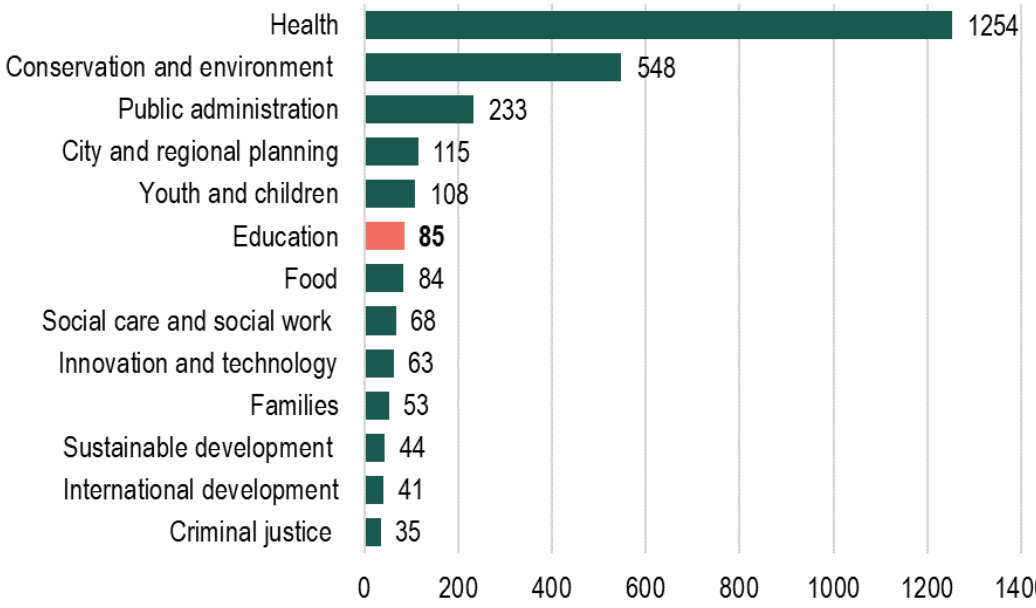
- It analyses the main trends in the subset of 85 education papers.
- It draws comparisons with other knowledge domain subsets.
- It draws comparisons with OECD research conducted since 2021 on the topic of evidence use in education policy.

The chapter describes the main characteristics of the education subset, including geographical focus, study design, methodological focus and study focus. It then details what factors were found to influence evidence use in the studies. Finally, it explores specific knowledge mobilisation interventions that are described and sometimes evaluated in the studies. Examples of studies from the education subset are included where these have been chosen for interest and representativeness.

Main characteristics of the education subset

The subset of education papers represents 3.8% of the total studies included in the 2024 systematic review. Around one-third were simultaneously coded as other knowledge domains (n = 30), and public administration was the knowledge domain most often coded together with education (n = 15). Education is the sixth-largest knowledge domain in the review (see Figure 2.1.). The vast majority of included studies were coded as health (n = 1254). The following sections detail the main characteristics of the subset and the implications for future work on knowledge mobilisation and supporting research.

Figure 2.1. Studies included in the systematic review, coded by knowledge domain



Note: Data show the number of times studies were coded as a given knowledge domain.
Source: EPPI (2024[14]), *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

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Geographical focus

Research in the Global North and Anglo-Saxon countries dominates the field

A large majority of education papers describe research in North America, Europe and/or Oceania (82% of assigned region codes). Within Europe, education studies examining evidence use in the UK context hugely dominated (n = 17), followed by Norway and the Netherlands (n = 4 each). In North America, 30 education studies reported findings in the US context and 9 in Canada. This confirms an ongoing phenomenon in knowledge mobilisation research: that English-language research conducted in this field is very much dominated by Anglo-Saxon countries, with a selection of these often coded across the main review (42% of country codes assigned to studies across all knowledge domains were the United Kingdom, Canada, the United States, Australia or New Zealand). While this is partly explained by the focus on English-language studies in the systematic review, this indicates that transferring knowledge on knowledge

mobilisation from Anglo-Saxon to other cultural or national contexts will remain an important avenue to explore for the foreseeable future. At the same time, there is a risk of generating an increasingly-narrow evidence base if studies generated on knowledge mobilisation are limited to a few cultural contexts. More research on knowledge mobilisation in non-Anglo contexts is urgently needed, while international research collaborations could also help to redress this balance.

Methodological focus

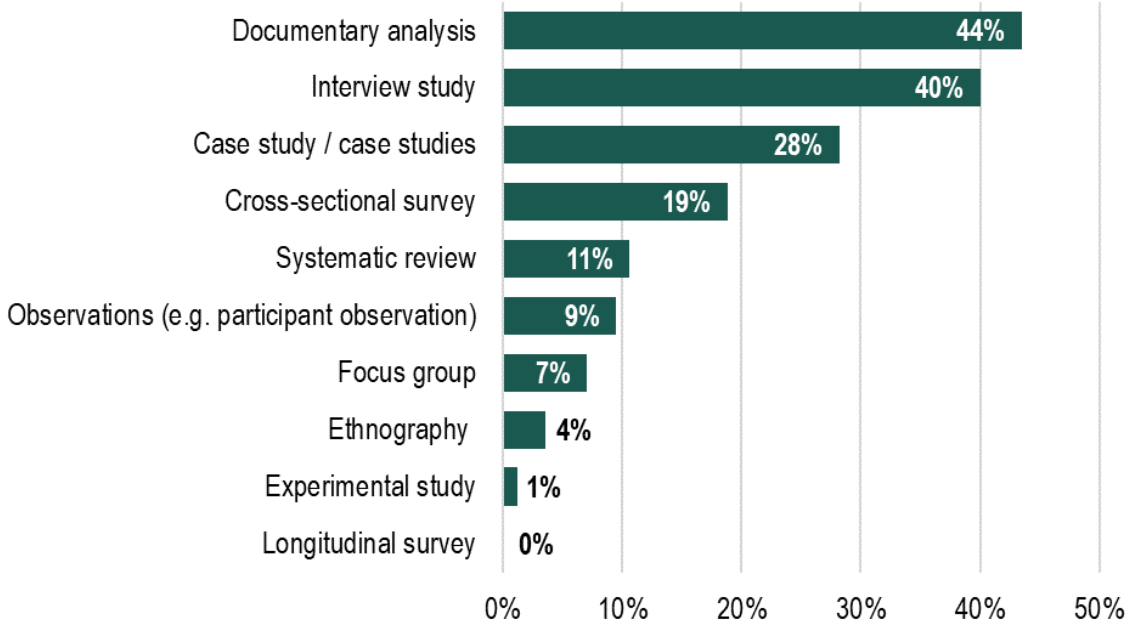
Mixed-methods research is limited, and there is a tendency towards documentary analysis

The most common methodological approach in the education subset was documentary analysis, followed by interviews (Figure 2.2). The popularity of documentary analysis (for example, the analysis of policy documents) can be partly explained by the relatively lower cost of this type of data collection and analysis. A notably higher percentage of studies in the education subset are systematic reviews when compared with any other knowledge domain.

The majority of education studies used one approach in their methodological design (n = 52) (e.g. just documentary analysis). However, 18% of the subset used three or more approaches. Documentary analysis was most often combined with interviews (n = 17), or a case study approach (papers reporting focusing on a single setting, n = 9).

Studies that have not been triangulated through diverse data collection methods may be limited in their reliability (how replicable the study is) and validity (how accurately the study measures what it sets out to measure). Given the concerns that have been voiced about the overall quality and rigour of educational research in general (Van Damme, 2024[8]), one possibility for ensuring more robustness in education research would be the more widespread use of mixed-methods research design.

Figure 2.2. Methodological design of education subset: Study design

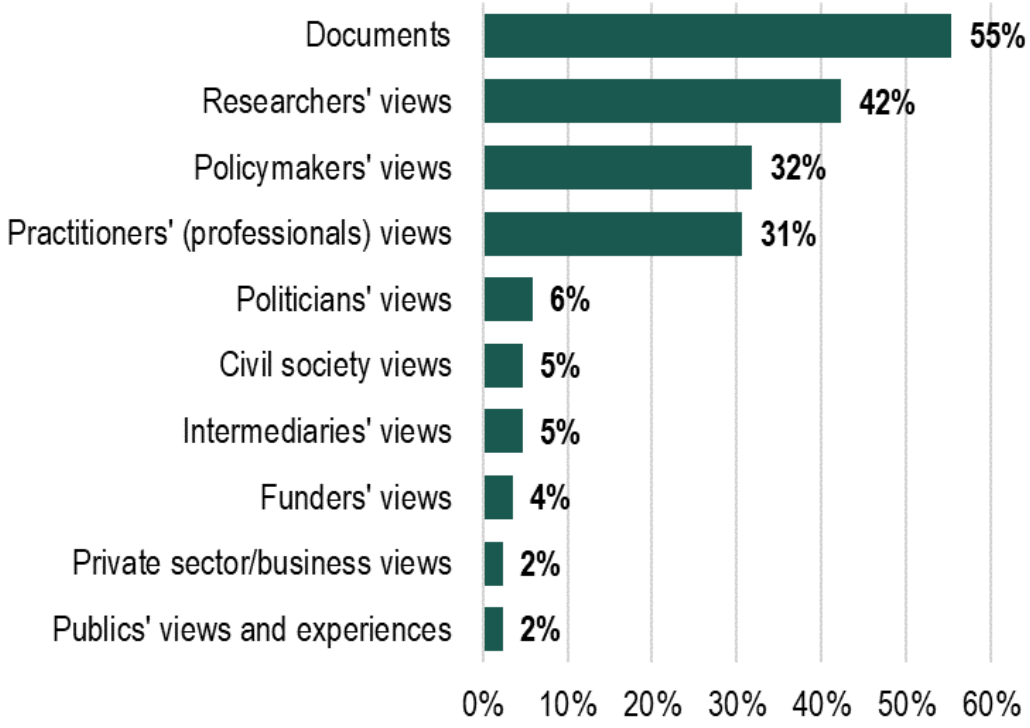


Source: EPPI (2024[14]) *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

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The review coded the type of data and views and experiences collected in the studies.

Figure 2.3. Source of data collection of education subset



Note: "Case study" refers to papers which reported focusing on a single setting.
Source: EPPI (2024[14]) *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

StatLink https://stat.link/m5d7hk

Education studies were slightly more likely to draw on documents compared to other knowledge domains. Education papers were less likely to collect data from the private sector than papers in other knowledge domains. The most common type of data collected in the main dataset was policy makers' views or experiences (in 52% of studies), while researchers' views and experiences were, similarly to the education subset, also frequently collected (in 46% of studies in the main dataset).

The focus on collecting information and data from policy and research communities is understandable when considering that the systematic review focused on explaining the gaps that persist between these two communities. At the same time, it suggests that researchers across knowledge domains tend to collect data from within their own communities. In some examples within the education subset, findings on the policy impact of research are based on researchers' perceptions rather than policy makers' perceptions (see, for example, Cherney et al. (2013[15]) and O'Connor (2022[16])) where the authors acknowledge this limitation). Another implication of an overrepresentation of researchers' views is a possible distorted picture of knowledge mobilisation that emphasises a "research push" approach. While there is a diverse landscape of actors participating in research mobilisation, these data collection trends suggest that it is still research producers (researchers) and users (policy makers) whose views and experiences are mostly considered. Yet, the reality of knowledge mobilisation is much more complex (OECD, 2022[17]). Future research could

therefore benefit from including a greater diversity of views and insights, in particular from under-represented stakeholders such as parents, pupils and intermediaries.

Scope of policy making

National policy making dominates, but evidence use is also researched at the local and regional levels

Over half (51%) of the studies in the education subset reported on factors influencing evidence use at the level of national policy. Yet almost one-quarter (24%) reported on local policy making, and one-fifth (21%) reported on regional-level policy making, showing that these levels of policy are also being substantively researched. This broadly reflects the trend in the main dataset where 46% of studies reported on evidence use in national policy, 23% on local policy, and 28% on regional policy. The availability of evidence on knowledge mobilisation at local and regional levels of policy provide a knowledge base to tap into. This is especially important for decentralised education systems, which often have a lot of involvement from local authorities or regional administrations, and where student outcomes are heavily influenced by local conditions and factors.

Study focus

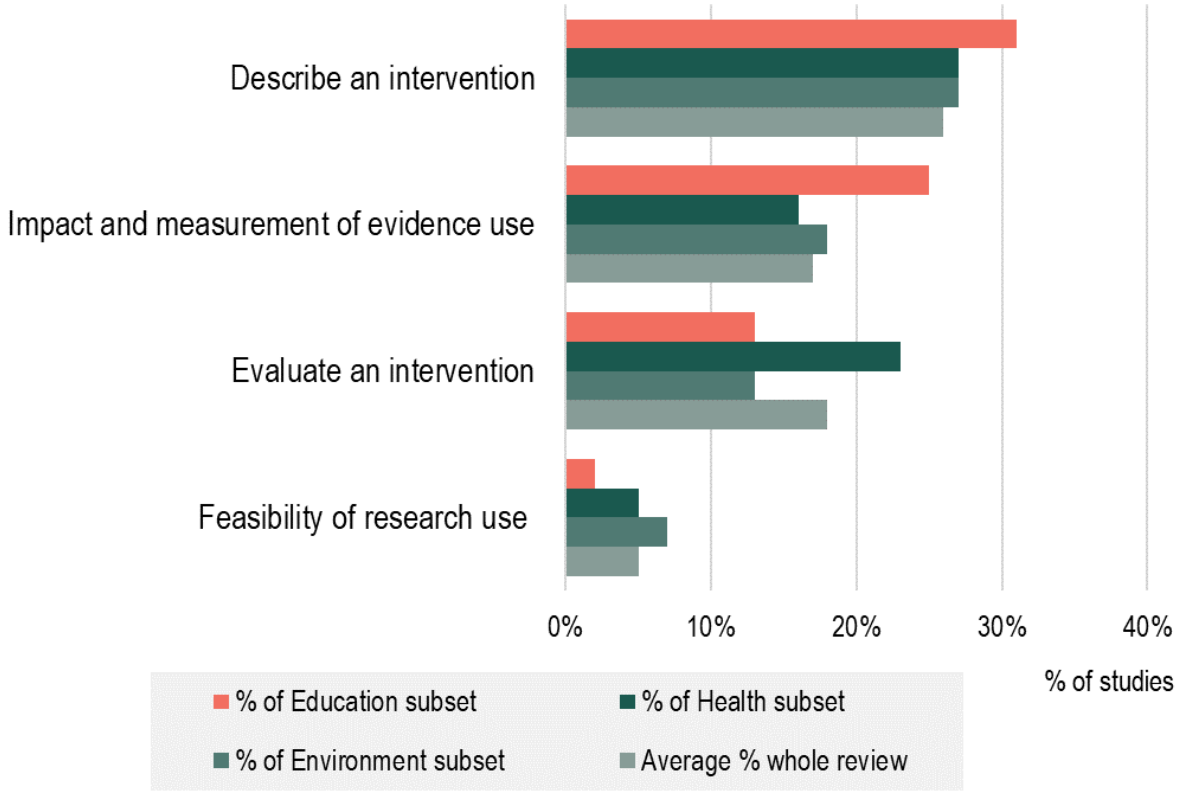
Descriptive studies of knowledge mobilisation interventions are far more common than evaluations

Most of the papers in the education subset focused their analysis on the mobilisation (n = 36) or the use of evidence (n = 37) (Box 2.2). A minority focused on the production of research evidence (n = 12). The review also coded other aspects of the focus of studies (see Figure 2.4).

Box 2.2. Study focus terms applied in the systematic review

- **Evidence production** was used to describe studies which primarily focused on research activities, research production or the outputs of (often) collaborative research endeavours.
- **Mobilisation of evidence** was used to describe studies which primarily focused on how knowledge was translated, made more accessible, or otherwise made more available to decision makers.
- **Evidence use** was used only for studies that examined how decision-making settings or processes were influenced by evidence; for example, looking at how teaching practices changed in response to evidence provision.

Figure 2.4. Focus of the studies, by knowledge domain subset



Note: The data show the focus of included studies in three different knowledge domain subsets: education (n = 85); health (n = 1 254); and conservation and environment (n = 548); and the average for all studies included in the review.
Source: EPPI (2024[14]), *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

StatLink https://stat.link/mrnk43

Of the 26 studies describing evidence use interventions in education captured in Figure 2.4, 9 focused on evaluations. The methods adopted in these studies vary, and include two systematic reviews of studies evaluating the impact of research on policy, and effective mechanisms to ensure uptake of research evidence in policy (Ashcraft, Quinn and Brownson, 2020[18]; Gorard, See and Siddiqui, 2020[3]), as well as a qualitative case study approach drawing on documentary research to examine the impact of strategies implemented in a Canadian knowledge mobilisation network (Campbell et al., 2017[19]). Overall, the gap between descriptive accounts and reporting on evaluation findings is larger in education than in other domains. Van Damme's (2022[20]) pyramid of evidence framework classifies descriptive research as valuable when seeking to identify characteristics and trends – it can lead to conceptualisation and some generalisation. However, its primary value is as a "stepping stone" towards other research approaches. A better balance between description and evaluation would allow for an improved understanding of not only the "what" but the "how" of knowledge mobilisation interventions. Evaluating knowledge mobilisation is far from being a systematic practice in many organisations in the education landscape across countries and is often not readily acknowledged as being a valuable activity. A lack of funding for conducting evaluations is also a commonly reported barrier that could explain this gap (see Chapter 6).

Studies that measure the use of evidence can provide valuable insight into the quality of research use in policy communities. Education papers that measured the use of evidence (n = 21) include the study by O'Connor (2022[16]), which draws on survey data in Ireland and develops a research use scale ranging from simple awareness of research to the use of research in policy design, implementation and evaluation. The author concludes that there is a poor uptake of educational research among Irish policy makers. Similarly, Cherney et al. (2013, p. 255[15]) refer to a "ladder of [research] utilisation" and draw on survey data to examine levels of social science research impact among Australian policy makers, where they conclude that a combination of linear and relational mechanisms to mobilise research findings has a significant positive bearing on research use.

Few studies examine the feasibility of research use

Ensuring evidence uptake in policy requires organisational structures, governance and a regulatory environment that is conducive to its uptake (Slade, Philip and Morris, 2018[21]; Mouthaan and Révai, 2023[22]). Analytical, operational and political skills and competencies are necessary at individual, organisational and systemic levels in order to perform policy functions effectively (Wu, Ramesh and Howlett, 2015[23]). Studies examining the feasibility of research use tend to take a more holistic view of state capacity to integrate research evidence into policy, and can provide valuable insights into capacity gaps. For example, Ion, Marin and Proteasa (2018[24]) signal the issue of weak administrative capacity for the development of evidence-informed education policies in former communist states, where they recommend that governments prioritise the use of systematic review and evaluation of policy programmes. The low number of education studies examining feasibility of research use suggests that this perspective is missing.

Types of evidence used to inform education policy processes

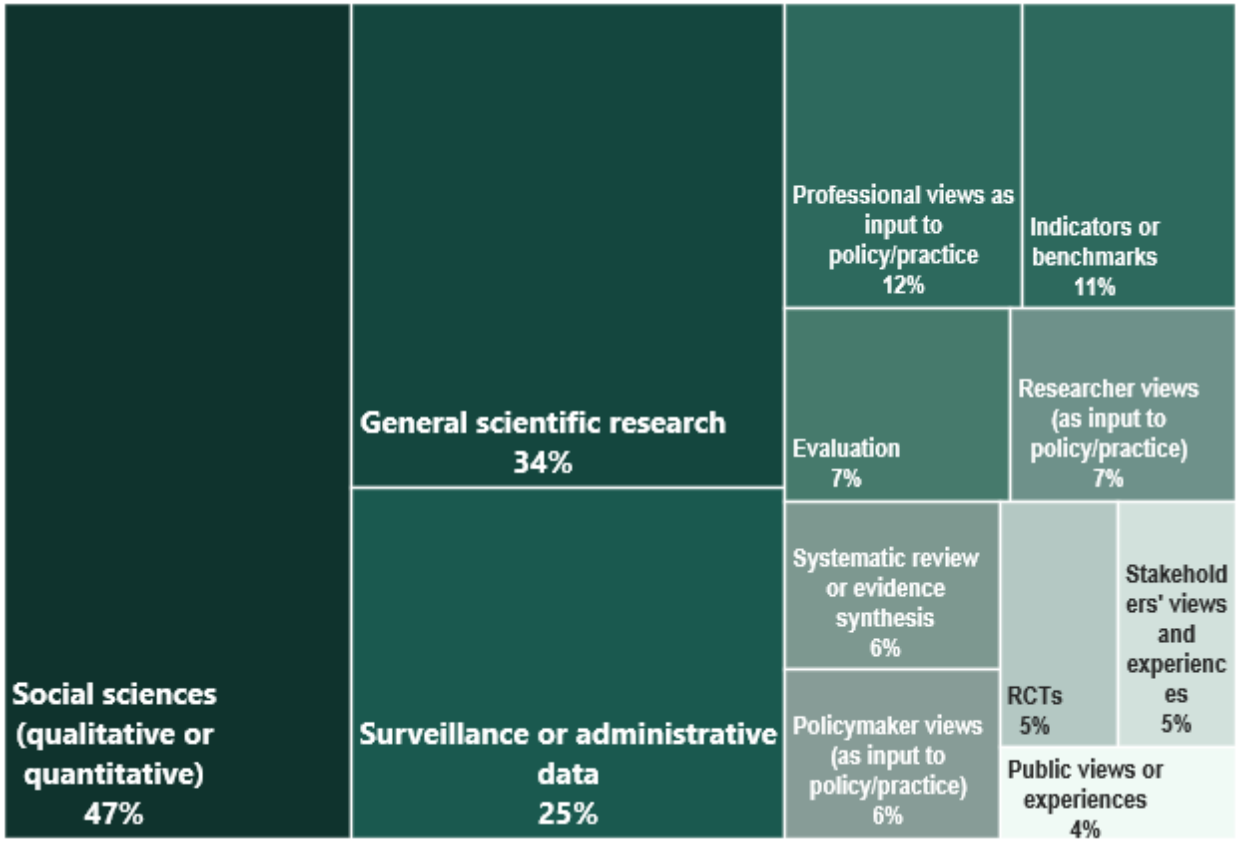
As noted in the introduction, there is significant debate around the types of evidence that can be suitable to influence policy. The review aimed to capture the different types of evidence that were reported as being used in education policy processes (see Figure 2.5). This gives a picture of where there are still gaps: in the types of evidence available to inform education policy decision making; and in our understanding of how policy makers are using different types of evidence.

Science focus

Research is concentrated on studying the use of general social science and scientific research

Around half of the education subset examined policy makers' or practitioners' use of general social sciences research (47%); 34% explored the use of general scientific research (used to denote studies which did not specify a particular kind of evidence). Social sciences research was a broad code applied when studies referred to academic social research, whether quantitative or qualitative (e.g. (Cherney et al., 2012[25])) or for example research reports presenting evaluation findings (e.g. (Forbes, 2022[26])). One-quarter examined the use of surveillance or administrative data, which includes quantitative data such as on student achievement (see, for example, the study by Daly et al. (2014[27])).

Figure 2.5. The types of evidence used in the education policy subset



Note: Data show the relative frequency of studies in the education subset that examined the uptake of different types of evidence in policy or practice. The categories of evidence represented reflect categories of at least 4% of the education subset or higher.
Source: EPPI (2024[14]), *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

StatLink https://stat.link/6ew5cq

A relatively low percentage of papers found or examined professional views as input to policy (12%). This suggests that professional knowledge such as from teachers or education administrators has not been the focus of much study in this research; likely because such views or knowledge are not viewed as a form of evidence. In comparison, around one-quarter of studies in the main review explored professional expertise as input to policy making (EPPI, 2024[14]). The low percentage of studies examining use of evaluation data as a form of evidence as input into education policy may be a reflection of there often being little evaluation data to draw on (see Chapter 6).

Evidence syntheses

Evidence syntheses are a valuable source to inform policy, but few studies explore their use

Similarly, synthesised evidence – such as from systematic reviews or meta-analyses – was explored as input to policy only infrequently; and two such studies are systematic reviews themselves. This is a far smaller proportion than the 114 studies in health (of which 17 are systematic reviews) that examined synthesised evidence as input to policy. Education is not the only knowledge domain in which the use of

synthesised evidence in policy is either low, or an under-researched phenomenon. In economics, criminal justice, city and regional planning and other knowledge domains, there were no studies reporting or exploring the use of systematic review evidence or evidence synthesis in policy. In comparison, in international development, 15% of studies reported on the use of synthesised evidence. The challenge for knowledge domains where use of systematic review evidence is low is two-fold: more systematic synthesis of research is needed, and more research on the *use of* such synthesised evidence in policy is needed.

One important aspect that may explain these differences between knowledge domains is the availability of synthesised evidence overall; in education, a lack of evidence syntheses is still a major barrier and remains an important issue to address (Mouthaan and Steponavičius, 2023[28]; OECD, 2023[29]). A consequence for policy may be that using individual studies instead of systematic reviews or other forms of synthesised evidence can be less reliable in terms of deriving implications or recommendations. The OECD 2021 policy survey[1] found that among 37 respondent education systems, less than two in three systems synthesise and disseminate research findings through user-friendly tools to policy makers or practitioners (OECD, 2022[17]). Evidence synthesis is much more routine in the health sector, which produces 26 times more syntheses than the education sector (Education.org, 2021[30]). A growing number of intermediaries are addressing this challenge by contributing to evidence synthesis, including the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF), whose Teaching and Learning Toolkit has been adapted to different regional contexts (Mouthaan and Steponavičius, 2023, p. 44[28]); the Norwegian Knowledge Centre; and DIPF | Leibniz Institute for Research and Information in Education, among others. While some research on the use of such syntheses exists (e.g. (Higgins, 2020[31]) on the use of the EEF toolkit), this has been published outside of peer-reviewed journals and does not appear in this review. Moreover, the effects of recent efforts to improve evidence synthesis and uptake of synthesised evidence may not yet be fully observable. Further research would be useful to understand how (or if) policy and practice communities indeed make use of synthesised evidence.

Randomised control trials

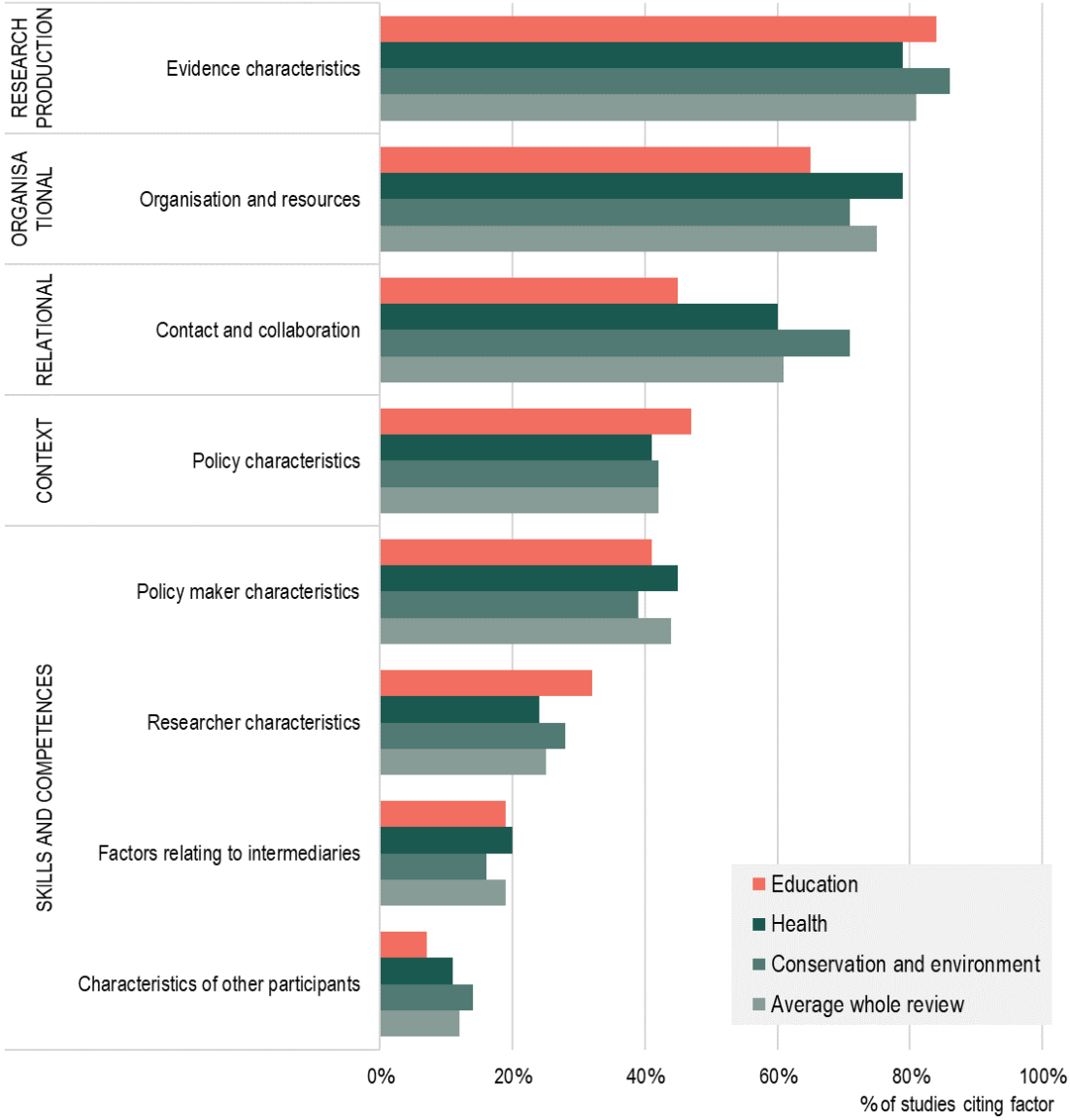
Little is known about the use of randomised control trials (RCTs) in education policy making

In education and in the dataset as a whole, relatively few studies examined the use of evidence from RCTs as input to policy (n = 26 in the main dataset). RCTs have a significant cost implication and their use in education has been controversial. Its critics emphasise that it is not always an appropriate or useful form of investigation (McKnight and Morgan, 2019[32]) and there are challenges in measuring what works in classroom contexts where human agency is at the heart of interventions, unlike in medicine trials (Wrigley and McCusker, 2019[33]; Parra and Edwards, 2024[34]). For instance, the EEF's commitment to a "what works" agenda is seen by some as a reductionist approach that reduces appetite for innovation by encouraging only the adoption of "proven" approaches (see Greany in (Pino-Yancovic et al., 2023[35])). Certain findings on the impact of RCT evidence have reinforced negative views. The EEF itself showed in an impact study that the uptake of Teaching Assistants' support to disadvantaged students have not improved their educational attainment (see EEF (2021[36]), and the EEF case study in Chapter 6)). On the other hand, proponents stress that RCTs can help to identify effective pedagogical interventions and create a pool of key approaches that can improve student learning. In this sense, RCTs allow for rigorous testing of the effectiveness of new pedagogical approaches. The EEF, for example, has a pipeline model that supports schools in developing innovative solutions to address their context-specific problems and in testing these (EEF, 2024[37]). To move from beliefs about experimental designs to evidence on their usefulness, it would be important to invest in better understanding how and to what extent data from RCTs is being used in education policy, how this type of evidence is perceived by policy makers in terms of its breadth of applicability and relevance, and its impact on educational outcomes.

Factors affecting use of evidence

The majority of studies across the main 2024 dataset found evidence characteristics and organisation and resources to play a role in determining evidence use (negatively or positively) (see Figure 2.6). Overall, the picture is very similar across the knowledge domains, which – perhaps unsurprisingly – suggests that a lot of knowledge and know-how on evidence use is transferable across sectors. In many cases, factors influencing evidence use are deeply connected to each other. The following sub-sections explore the findings on factors affecting use of evidence and some of their important ties.

Figure 2.6. Factors found to influence evidence use, comparison of selected knowledge domains



Note: The data show the factors found to influence evidence use in three different knowledge domain subsets and the average for all studies included in the review.
Source: EPPI (2024[14]), *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

StatLink https://stat.link/qcm0jk

Evidence, researcher and policy maker characteristics

Evidence characteristics include the type of evidence, its source, availability, accessibility, credibility, legitimacy, relevance and factors such as how actionable the evidence or recommendations are. Researcher characteristics include researchers' skills, policy awareness, will and interest, and credibility. Policy maker characteristics include skills, research literacy, and will and motivation to use research evidence.

The characteristics of evidence and those of policy makers and researchers jointly influence evidence use

Evidence characteristics are a key factor influencing evidence use in education and other knowledge fields, while their significance depends in large part on policy maker characteristics. In the main dataset, many studies discuss the legitimacy and credibility of evidence, such as whether the evidence was considered trustworthy, and if it took a holistic or, conversely, a narrow political lens on an issue. In the main review, credibility of evidence was usually linked to researcher characteristics, such as the trustworthiness of individual researchers or their organisations, and was frequently discussed in relation to rigour, peer review and research quality (Oliver et al., forthcoming[13]).

Studies in the education subset reported researcher characteristics as influencing evidence use more frequently than in other knowledge domains. Researchers' policy awareness (n = 22) and skills (n = 18) were the most highly-reported factors in this category. One education paper reported findings from a study of academic researchers in Australia and demonstrated that a high awareness of the priorities of non-academic end users in their sample meant that research projects and findings were tailored to meet these end-user needs (Cherney et al., 2012[25]). While beyond the scope of this chapter, a more fine-grained and comprehensive content analysis of the individual studies examining these factors would allow insight into whether these factors were more often reported as barriers or as facilitating factors, and whether the education sector has more challenges than other sectors in fostering a culture of research use in policy among academic and policy communities.

In the education subset, the type of evidence (n = 40) and the relevance of evidence (n = 40) were the most frequently cited evidence characteristics. These studies often interrogate the extent to which research evidence is "policy-ready" i.e. the outputs incorporate or act in response to a discourse originated by policy makers (such as reported by Brown (2012[38]; 2014[39])). They also often point to a situation where different types of evidence and their value are not well understood or regarded (e.g. Gleeson et al. (2020[40])) which inevitably limits the possibilities for a quality use of research. In practice, this might mean that researchers have a limited ability to convey the benefit of evidence, or that policy makers have a limited ability to understand different evidence types and use them in effective ways. In both cases, there may be a need for professional learning to increase the first key step in evidence uptake: understanding and interpreting evidence itself (OECD, 2024[41]). In the OECD 2021 policy survey, over half of respondent ministries considered that extensive learning opportunities to develop policy makers' research knowledge and skills were absent in their systems (Hill and Torres, 2023, p. 71[42]). Crucially, the quality of learning opportunities for improving research engagement skills is as relevant as their quantity (Hill and Torres, 2023[42]).

Policy characteristics, organisation and resources

Policy characteristics include the competing pressures on policy decision making, framing, and the context of decision making. Studies that found organisation and resources to play a role examined factors such as funding, staff turnover and continuity, communication channels, time, culture, managerial support and legislative support.

The context of decision making, such as politics and power, are determining factors for evidence use

The context of decision making (n = 31) emerged as the most highly-reported factor in this category in the education subset. One study examined the role of power and race relations in the context of higher education policy in an Australian state, and concluded that selectively determining policy success using quantitative data masked real racial inequalities (Street et al., 2021[43]). A study conducted in England found that ministerial views on teacher education led to evidence from national reviews being cherry-picked to fit within the decision-making context (Helgetun and Menter, 2020[44]).

Human and financial resources, as well as supportive leadership within research and policy organisations, matter for evidence uptake

Managerial support (n = 28), staff and personnel resources (n = 32) and material resources (n = 29) emerged as the most highly-reported organisation- and resources-related factors in the education subset. This echoes OECD recommendations that tailored human resource strategies are needed to build the necessary skills within a ministry or policy organisation to allow systematic and thoughtful engagement with research, as well as organisational structures and processes that ensure resources and time to engage with research and provide tools to do so (OECD, 2024[41]). Ideally, these structures need to be stable and long-term so that they are resistant to the organisational changes, staff turnover and political shifts that happen in policy organisations (OECD, 2024[41]). Similarly, studies in the United States on research-practice-partnerships have argued the necessity of the long-term continuity of such partnerships (Penuel et al., 2015[45]; Farley-Ripple, Oliver and Boaz, 2020[46]). Education studies in the review reported contradictory pressures on academic researchers that disincentivise time spent on activities aimed at feeding evidence into the policy process, such as investing time and resources into research-practice and research-policy collaborations (Matthews et al., 2018[47]; Heinrich and Good, 2018[48]). This suggests there is still significant scope for systems to consider how they can better incentivise policy-oriented research, and research-policy partnerships, where dedicated funding for such initiatives and a rethinking of academic incentives are important avenues to explore.

The 2014 systematic review also found organisation and resources as both key barriers and facilitators to the use of evidence in policy (Oliver et al., 2014[12]). The persistence of these organisational barriers to evidence use in policy over time suggests that implementing changes to well-established cultures within academic and policy organisations remains a difficult task (Mouthaan and Révai, 2023[22]).

Factors relating to intermediaries: A new research focus

Studies exploring the role of intermediaries in determining evidence use have been increasing steadily. The role of intermediaries was not coded separately from research and researcher characteristics in the systematic review conducted in 2014 (Oliver et al., 2014[12]), suggesting that intermediaries did not feature prominently in earlier research.

The role of intermediaries in supporting evidence use is increasingly explored

In the present review, around one-fifth of studies in both the main dataset and the education subset reported factors relating to intermediaries to play a role in determining evidence use. In the education subset, studies explored the role of intermediaries that are active at the local, national and global levels. These studies examine, for instance, the effects of the Indicators of Education Systems Programme of the OECD on the organisation's growing status as a knowledge broker in education (Grek and Ydesen, 2021[49]); the role of US state higher education governing agencies as information hubs that state policy makers and campus officials turn to inform their decision making (Rubin and Ness, 2019[50]); and the role of professional associations as knowledge brokers in the United States, in enabling members' access to

research and facilitating between-state research exchanges (Hopkins et al., 2018[51]). Of the 16 education studies that reported on intermediaries influencing evidence use, 13 were published after 2018, and the remaining 3 were published between 2013-2017, suggesting a surge in interest in researching intermediaries in very recent years. This surge is indicative of the proliferation of intermediaries that are actively brokering knowledge in the education sectors of different systems (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[52]). These actors seem likely to gain further importance in the evidence landscape, and more attention is needed to increase their effectiveness in ensuring that evidence is being produced, mobilised and used.

Contact and collaboration

Recognising that collaboration in itself is not sufficient to ensure evidence use, research may have moved on to study other factors

On the surface, the data seem to indicate that contact and collaboration are factors of comparatively less importance in education than in other knowledge domains. While this descriptive study is not suitable for a comparative evaluation of how much different factors matter across policy domains, one interpretation is that contact and collaboration may already be well established in the education sector compared to sectors such as conservation. Education may have moved on from discussions around the importance of collaboration, placing more emphasis on the need to incentivise researchers to generate relevant evidence. The data may also indicate that while there is a growing recognition that trusting relationships are important, they are not sufficient for evidence use. In this sense, contact and collaboration on its own does not constitute enough of a facilitator of evidence use – it needs to be supported within an organisation with high absorptive capacity and leadership.

Knowledge mobilisation interventions

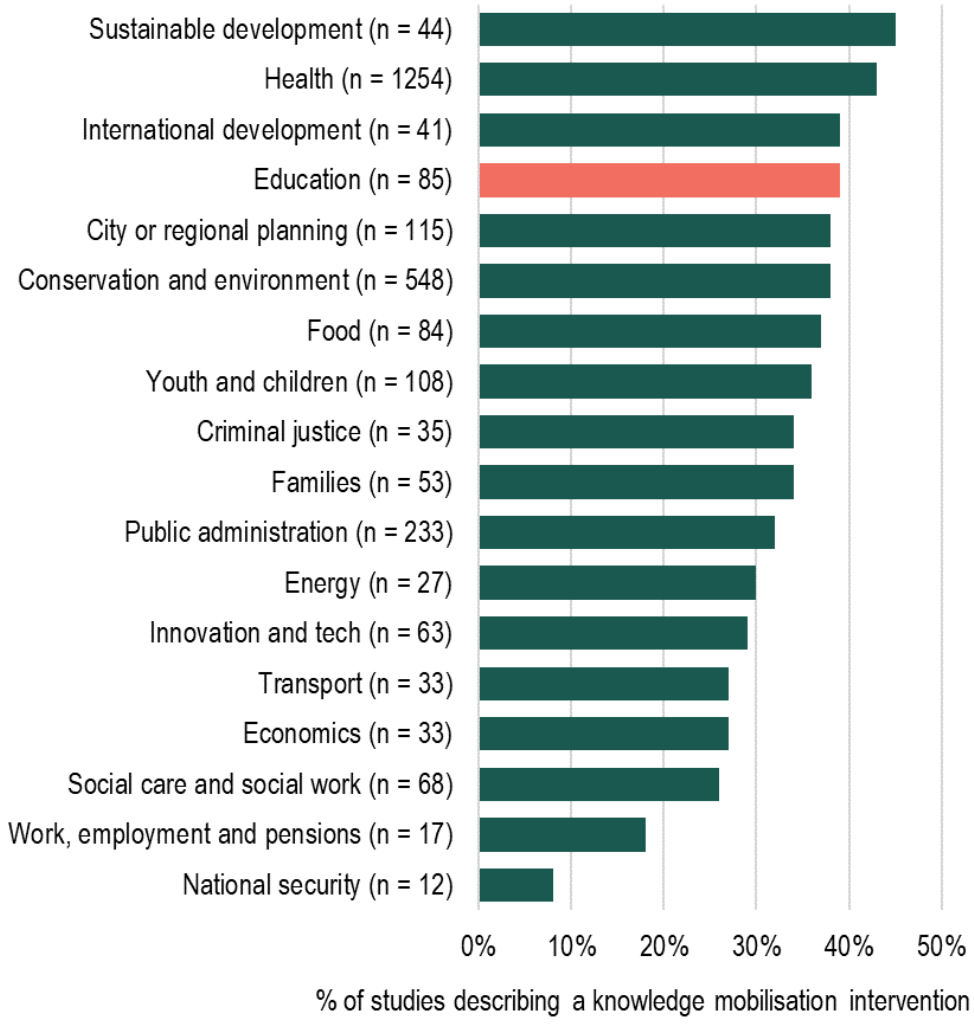
A number of studies reviewed specific knowledge mobilisation interventions (see Box 2.3). These studies provide a descriptive account of the intervention, and sometimes an evaluation of the intervention's impact or effectiveness. Such analyses provide concrete insights into the mechanisms being deployed in specific contexts, organisations, systems or countries to mobilise research in policy. Development, health and education were the knowledge domains with the highest percentage of studies that described a knowledge mobilisation intervention (Figure 2.7).

Intervention studies across sectors

Box 2.3. Types of knowledge mobilisation interventions

The described interventions include intermediary organisation activities; policy briefs; policy dialogues; networks; research-practice and research-policy partnerships; training or capacity-building activities; the provision of a resource (such as indicators, a database or map); and other such interventions aimed at increasing the use of research in policy.

Figure 2.7. Studies describing a knowledge mobilisation intervention, by knowledge domain



Source: EPPI (2024[14]), *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

StatLink https://stat.link/6sakom

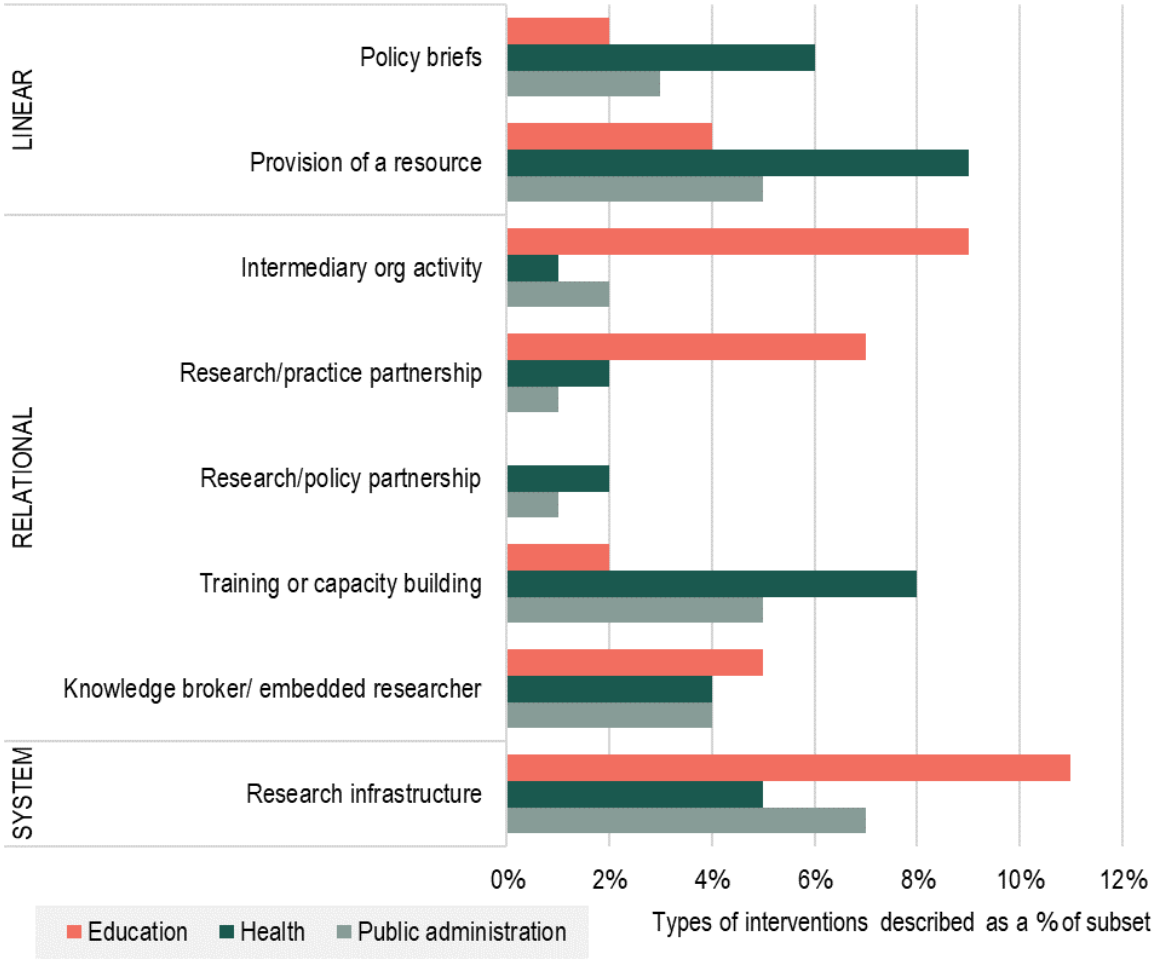
A significant share of education studies explore knowledge mobilisation interventions, but few are evaluations

The data suggest that knowledge mobilisation interventions are most frequently observed in applied sciences and social sciences. While a comparatively high proportion of education studies describe a knowledge mobilisation intervention, only a small proportion of these report on their effectiveness. This echoes findings from the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (the intermediaries' survey) that much knowledge mobilisation in the education sector is simply not evaluated. Understanding effectiveness would allow for building a cumulative knowledge base on what works in knowledge mobilisation, but requires significantly more systematic and quality evaluation of knowledge mobilisation activity (see Chapter 6 for further detail).

Types of interventions

Figure 2.8. Types of knowledge mobilisation interventions included in the subset

Types of interventions described as a percentage of the total knowledge domain subset



Source: EPPI (2024[14]), *Barfac visualisation: What factors influence evidence use?*, https://eppi.ioe.ac.uk/eppi-vis/Review/Index/616.

StatLink https://stat.link/o6cg4e

Linear mechanisms that can address issues of accessibility are less commonly reported

Health intervention studies were more likely to report policy briefs or to provide a tool or resource than education intervention studies. This confirms other research that shows that mechanisms and processes to render research accessible to policy audiences are more common in the health domain (Education.org, 2021[30]). The OECD 2021 policy survey found that among respondent systems, policy makers perceived some types of education research to be quite or highly relevant to policy needs, but not very accessible (Mouthaan and Steponavičius, 2023[28]). While the exact causes of low research accessibility may vary by context or system, policy briefs and toolkits can help address issues of accessibility. Similarly, regular

consultations with policy makers on their research needs can help to ensure alignment of outputs and tools with actual research gaps and needs. Intermediary organisations can play a role in supporting these initiatives and identifying specific needs.

Reported relational activities vary widely: In education, very few focus on capacity building

Education studies were far less likely than other knowledge domains to describe training or capacity-building activities, with only two of the 33 education studies describing such interventions (see Figure 2.8). In comparison, in public administration 5% (12 out of 75 studies), in sustainable development 35% (7 out of 20 studies) and in health 19.5% (105 out of 536 studies) of intervention studies described training or capacity-building initiatives. This is surprising given the relatively high level of capacity-building activities of educational organisations reported in Chapter 3.

Collaborations between research and policy communities did not feature in descriptions of interventions in education, yet we know that increasingly, different systems are experimenting with establishing these types of partnerships, including networks between science and policy actors (for country examples, see (OECD, 2024[41])). In comparison, seven intervention studies in education described research-practice partnerships. This includes a study of partnerships in the United States between researchers and school districts that showed that the involvement of practice partners in the scheduling and co-ordination of research activities, as well as researcher-developed learning opportunities for practitioners, helped practitioners to better understand how to administer language and literacy interventions (Alonzo et al., 2022[53]). Another study presented and tested a conceptual framework that aims to explain the mechanisms in these partnerships that lead to evidence-based decision making among practitioners. The authors note that an intentional process of measuring and examining outputs in a partnership can help to improve the partnership's outcomes (Wentworth, Mazzeo and Connolly, 2017[54]). What these studies also have in common is that they emphasise the importance of allocating time to developing relationships of trust within the partnership, and of continuous and open communication, for the collaboration to be successful. All seven studies on research-practice partnerships focus on the North American context, suggesting that research on these types of partnerships in other geographical contexts would be highly valuable.

System-level: Research infrastructure and intermediary organisation activity descriptions are prominent

Education papers detailing knowledge mobilisation interventions more often described research infrastructures for knowledge mobilisation (e.g. a new evidence synthesis unit or a funding stream) and intermediary organisation activities than papers describing interventions in health, criminal justice or public administration. As noted earlier, this could be indicative of a shift in focus in education research from interventions focused on relationships and collaboration to the necessity of resources to support knowledge mobilisation. Of the education studies describing knowledge mobilisation interventions (n = 33), 9 studies discussed such research infrastructures (see Figure 2.8). These include the study by Zapp and Powell (2017[55]) that describes the growth of federal programme- and project-based funding in Germany that many organisations rely on; and the study by Ranchod (2017[56]) examining the development of a research-policy nexus as a space for exchanges between researchers, government officials and other stakeholders in a research-based national-level government department in South Africa. Descriptions of these kinds of systems approaches give insight into co-ordination mechanisms at the system level that are critical to supporting research engagement (Maxwell, Sharples and Coldwell, 2022[57]). 8 of the 33 education intervention studies described intermediary organisation activities – this is a welcome addition to the literature given that little is known about the characteristics and impact of intermediaries in the knowledge mobilisation sphere in education (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[52]).

In their review of the main dataset, Oliver et al (forthcoming[13]) highlight a few implications of a proliferation of knowledge mobilisation initiatives. First, it may imply that taking a systems perspective (i.e. mapping

these initiatives and their associated actors) will need to be done routinely, which will be challenging. Secondly, in an ideal situation, new initiatives build on knowledge derived from existing initiatives (e.g. by drawing on evaluation data) in order to take an evidence-informed approach on what works in knowledge mobilisation. However, this kind of data is not always publicly accessible (see Chapter 6) and better ensuring its existence and accessibility will require substantive concerted effort and resources. Overall, it remains concerning that the now well-established organisational barriers to using evidence in policy persist, and may continue to hamper the effectiveness of new knowledge mobilisation initiatives.

Conclusion

This review of the subset of education papers included in the Oliver et al. (forthcoming[13]) review aimed to detail the main trends in research on knowledge mobilisation in education. A few key messages emerge from this analysis, with implications for future research co-ordination and collaboration in the education sector.

While the review was limited to studies written in English, the analysis confirms an already established phenomenon: that much research on knowledge mobilisation emerges from just a few Anglo-Saxon countries and contexts. If we interpret this as an indication that there is a vibrant community of knowledge mobilisation research in institutions in these countries, then it can be expected that this will continue to be the case for foreseeable future. It is therefore important to dig deep to better understand how this research can be applied to other contexts, and which aspects of these studies are generalisable. On the other hand, this chapter has reiterated the need for more research on knowledge mobilisation in countries beyond the Anglosphere. Some notable efforts have been made to showcase knowledge mobilisation initiatives from non-Anglo-Saxon contexts including the Evidence Informed Policy making in Education in Europe project (see (Gough et al., 2011[58]; Oliver et al., 2022[59])) and OECD efforts (OECD, 2022[17]; OECD, 2023[29]), including this publication.

The comparative analysis also confirms that cross-sectorial learning in the field of knowledge mobilisation remains a highly valuable activity (OECD, 2022[17]; Boaz, Oliver and Hopkins, 2022[60]). Learning from other sectors is one way to address long-standing challenges in knowledge mobilisation, and this chapter has highlighted instances where other knowledge domains can offer inspiration in areas where the education sector appears to be weaker. This includes implementing much-needed capacity building initiatives in policy communities but also establishing well-functioning mechanisms for synthesising evidence for policy (both of these are more established in the health sector).

While the growth in descriptions of knowledge mobilisation initiatives is a promising development, in domains such as education too little is being done to examine their effectiveness. Are these new initiatives learning from past initiatives? Are they connected to and building on one another? The evidence use field thus needs to consider how it can ensure learning on “what works” in these initiatives, which requires resources for conducting evaluations; and how it can make this learning available to those who need it, which necessitates better co-ordination and use of resources within the system (Oliver et al., forthcoming[13]). Crucially, systems approaches are needed to support and co-ordinate this growth in initiatives and ensure they are indeed effective, while adding to the cumulative knowledge base on effectiveness.

The data in this chapter show that while systematic reviews can be of great value, little is known about whether and how education policy makers use them. As evidence characteristics remain the main factor influencing use of evidence in policy, it remains important to address quality concerns in education research, while further research can explore how different types of evidence can be better incorporated into policy. Again, understanding how this is done in other policy sectors is a good starting point. Finally, while this chapter has focused on analysing the overall observable trends in the education subset in terms

of their focus, there is also considerable value in understanding the substantive conclusions of such studies and collaboratively exploring their implications for policy and practice.

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Annex 2.A. Methods of the systematic review

The 2024 updated systematic review screened on title and abstract (n = 18 175) and on full text (n = 5 444), of which 2 199 papers were included in the final review. Fifteen electronic databases were searched using search strings and keywords reflecting three concepts: “evidence”; “barriers and facilitators”; and “policy makers”. To be included, studies had to be empirical research (describing a study design) or systematic reviews describing or explaining how evidence is used in policy or practice. Studies that did not report on factors influencing evidence use were excluded, as were studies in languages other than English. Multiple reviewers from different knowledge domains were involved in coding studies. Studies were stored, screened and keyworded using the Evidence for Policy and Practice Information (EPPI) Reviewer software, where keywording was done in categories such as knowledge domain, overall focus of the study and the study’s aim in relation to exploring evidence use.

For some categories – such as factors found to influence evidence use, and characterisation of interventions – a pre-defined list was used to code but was iteratively updated if reviewers proposed new factors or types of interventions based on their reviews. For example, “factors relating to intermediaries” was added as a code for factors found to influence evidence use when identified by several reviewers.

Further details on the protocol for the updated 2024 systematic review on factors affecting evidence use in policy can be found in Oliver et al (forthcoming[13]).

Annex 2.B. Details of the education subset

Annex Table 2.B.1. Education subset: List of studies included in the review

Author(s)	Year	Title
Afdal, Hilde Wgss	2013	Policy making processes with respect to teacher education in Finland and Norway
Alonzo, Crystle N; Komesidou, Rouzana; Wolter, Julie A; Curran, Maura; Ricketts, Jessie; Hogan, Tiffany P.	2022	Building Sustainable Models of Research-Practice Partnerships Within Educational Systems
Archibald, T.	2015	"They just know": the epistemological politics of "evidence-based" non-formal education
Ashcraft, L.E; Quinn, D.A; Brownson, R.C.	2020	Strategies for effective dissemination of research to United States policy makers: a systematic review
Azuh, D; Joshua, S; Ibietan, J.	2016	The use of data in policy-making in Nigeria's educational sector: Implications for national development
Baek, Chanwoong	2022	Internalising externalisation: utilisation of international knowledge in education policy making
Bainbridge, A; Troppe, T; Bartley, J.	2022	Responding to research evidence in Parliament: A case study on selective education policy
Bartlett, Will	2013	Obstacles to Evidence-based Policy-making in the EU Enlargement Countries: The Case of Skills Policies
Bélanger, N; Dulude, E.	2021	Investigating the challenges and opportunities of a bilingual equity knowledge brokering network: A critical and reflective perspective from university partners
Bonetti, Sara	2017	Identifying the complexities of early care and education professionals' use and production of quantitative data
Briscoe, Patricia; Persad, Robin	2021	Building entrepreneurial researcher capacity to increase positive changes in practice
Brown, C.	2012	The 'policy-preferences model': a new perspective on how researchers can facilitate the take-up of evidence by educational policy makers
Brown, Chris	2014	The policy agora: How power inequalities affect the interaction between researchers and policy makers
Brown, Chris; Rogers, Sue	2014	Measuring the effectiveness of knowledge creation as a means of facilitating evidence-informed practice in early years settings in one London borough
Bushouse, B.K; Mosley, J.E.	2018	The intermediary roles of foundations in the policy process: building coalitions of interest
Campbell, Carol; Pollock, Katina; Briscoe, Patricia; Carr-Harris, Shasta; Tuters, Stephanie	2017	Developing a knowledge network for applied education research to mobilise evidence in and for educational practice
Cherney, Adrian; Povey, Jenny; Head, Brian; Boreham, Paul; Ferguson, Michele	2012	What influences the utilisation of educational research by policy-makers and practitioners? The perspectives of academic educational researchers
Cherney, Adrian; Head, Brian; Povey, Jenny; Boreham, Paul; Ferguson, Michele	2015	The utilisation of social science research-The perspectives of academic researchers in Australia
Cohen, A.K; Ozer, E.J; Abraczinskas, M; Voight, A; Kirshner, B; Devinney, M.	2020	Opportunities for youth participatory action research to inform school district decisions
Connolly, Faith; Durant, Tracey L; Durham, Rachel E.	2020	Indicators to Assist in Addressing Equity Through Policy Adoption
Cooper, Amanda	2014	Knowledge mobilisation in education across Canada: a cross-case analysis of 44 research brokering organisations
Daly, Alan J; Finnigan, Kara S; Jordan, Stuart; Moolenaar, Nienke M; Che, Jing	2014	Misalignment and Perverse Incentives: Examining the Politics of District Leaders as Brokers in the Use of Research Evidence
De Lisle, Jerome	2016	Evolving data use policy in Trinidad and Tobago: The search for actionable knowledge on educational improvement in a small island developing state

Author(s)	Year	Title
De Ruiter, R; Schalk, J.	2017	Explaining cross-national policy diffusion in national parliaments: A longitudinal case study of plenary debates in the Dutch parliament
Farley-Ripple, Elizabeth N.	2012	Research Use in School District Central Office Decision Making: A Case Study
Faubert, B.C.	2019	Transparent resource management Implications for leadership and democracy in education
Fitzgerald, K.G; Tipton, E.	2022	The Meta-Analytic Rain Cloud Plot: A New Approach to Visualizing Clearinghouse Data
Forbes, S.	2017	Determining state sector statistics training priorities
Forbes, C.	2022	Exploring barriers and solutions to encouraging evidence-into-use within an embedded evaluation approach: Reflections from the field
GNdara, Denisa; Hearn, James C.	2019	College Completion, the Texas Way: An Examination of the Development of College Completion Policy in a Distinctive Political Culture
Gleeson, J; Walsh, L; Rickinson, M; Kirkby, J; O'Donovan, R; Grimmett, H.	2020	Challenges and Opportunities of Evidence Use in Practice in Australian Children's Development Programs
Gorard, S; See, B.H; Siddiqui, N.	2020	What is the evidence on the best way to get evidence into use in education?
Green, Chris; Taylor, Celia; Buckley, Sharon; Hean, Sarah	2016	Beyond synthesis: augmenting systematic review procedures with practical principles to optimise impact and uptake in educational policy and practice
Grek, Sotiria; Ydesen, Christian	2021	Where science met policy: governing by indicators and the OECD's INES programme
Head, B.W.	2016	Toward More "Evidence-Informed" Policy Making?
Heinrich, Carolyn J; Good, Annalee	2018	Research-informed practice improvements: exploring linkages between school district use of research evidence and educational outcomes over time
Helgetun, Jo B; Menter, Ian	2022	From an age of measurement to an evidence era? Policy-making in teacher education in England
Hodgson, Ann; Spours, Ken	2016	Restrictive and expansive policy learning challenges and strategies for knowledge exchange in upper secondary education across the four countries of the United Kingdom
Hopkins, M; Wiley, K.E; Penuel, W.R; Farrell, C.C.	2018	Brokering research in science education policy implementation: the case of a professional association
Hordsy, Rita	2017	How do different stakeholders utilise the same data? The case of school leavers and graduates information systems in three European countries
Ion, G; Marin, E; Proteasa, C.	2019	How does the context of research influence the use of educational research in policy-making and practice?
Jimerson, Jo Beth; Childs, Joshua	2017	Signal and Symbol: How State and Local Policies Address Data-Informed Practice
Johns, Carolyn; MacLellan, Duncan	2020	Public administration in the cross-hairs of evidence-based policy and authentic engagement: School closures in Ontario
Lassnigg, Lorenz	2012	'Use of current best evidence': Promises and illusions, limitations and contradictions in the triangle of research, policy and practice
Lewis, David	2018	Peopling policy processes? Methodological populism in the Bangladesh health and education sectors
Lewis, Maria M; Bray, Laura E.	2019	A call for amicus briefs as a means to influence special education policy: Lessons learned from *Endrew F.*
Lotz-Sisitka, Heila; Rosenberg, Eureta; Ramsarup, Presha	2021	Environment and sustainability education research as policy engagement: (re-) invigorating 'politics as potential' in South Africa
Lundin, Martin; Oberg, PerOla	2014	Expert knowledge use and deliberation in local policy making
MacGregor, Stephen; Malin, Joel R; Farley-Ripple, Elizabeth N.	2022	An Application of the Social-ecological Systems Framework to Promoting Evidence-informed Policy and Practice
Marin, Elena; Ion, Georgeta; Stngu, Mihaela	2019	How can researchers facilitate the utilisation of research by policy-makers and practitioners in education?
Marin, Patricia; Yun, John T; Garces, Liliana M; Horn, Catherine L.	2020	Bridging Divides: Understanding Knowledge Producers' Perspectives on the Use of Research in Law
Matthews, P; Rutherfoord, R; Connelly, S; Richardson, L; Durose, C ; Vanderhoven, D.	2018	Everyday stories of impact: interpreting knowledge exchange in the contemporary university
McDonnell, Lorraine M; Weatherford, M.	2013	Evidence use and the Common Core State Standards movement: From problem definition to policy adoption

Author(s)	Year	Title
McShane, Ian	2016	'Educare' in Australia: Analysing policy mobility and transformation
Molla, Tebeje	2014	Knowledge aid as instrument of regulation: World Bank's non-lending higher education support for Ethiopia
Montz, Burrell E; Galluppi, Kenneth J; Losego, Jessica L; Smith, Catherine F.	2015	Winter weather decision-making: North Carolina school closures, 2010-2011
Nathanail, E; Adamos, G ; Mitropoulos, L; Karakikes, I; Yatskiv, I.	2020	How efficiently educational programs prepare professionals to meet current and future challenges of transport interchanges
Niemann, Dennis; Martens, Kerstin	2018	Soft governance by hard fact? The OECD as a knowledge broker in education policy
O'Connor, J.	2022	Evidence based education policy in Ireland: insights from educational researchers
Orr, L.L; Olsen, R.B; Bell, S.H; Schmid, I; Shivji, A; Stuart, E.A.	2019	Using the Results from Rigorous Multisite Evaluations to Inform Local Policy Decisions
Pasachoff, Eloise	2017	Two Cheers for Evidence: Law, Research, and Values in Education Policy Making and Beyond
Pizmony-Levy, Oren; McDermott, Meredith; Copeland, Thaddeus T.	2021	Improving Environmental and Sustainability Education (ESE) policy through research-practice partnerships: Reflections and analysis from New York City
Project Evident	2021	Actionable evidence: toward equitable outcomes: practical framework for research, evaluation, and technical assistance in the education and social sectors
Ramot, R; Bialik, G.	2020	Researchers as Knowledge Brokers: A Step toward Research-Informed Policy? Lessons from the Israeli Case
Ranchod, R.	2017	Building the research-policy nexus in South Africa: insights from a skills planning policy intervention
Reckhow, Sarah; Tompkins-Stange, Megan	2018	Financing the education policy discourse: philanthropic funders as entrepreneurs in policy networks
Rickinson, Mark; de Bruin, Kate; Walsh, Lucas; Hall, Matthew	2017	What can evidence-use in practice learn from evidence-use in policy?
Rickinson, M; Walsh, L; de Bruin, K; Hall, M.	2019	Understanding evidence use within education policy: a policy narrative perspective
Rubin, Paul G; Ness, Erik C.	2021	State Higher Education Governing Agencies and the Knowledge Brokering Process: Investigating Their Role as Multi-facing Organizations in the United States
Schlaufer, C.	2016	Global evidence in local debates: the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) in Swiss direct-democratic debates on school policy
See, Beng Huat	2018	Evaluating the evidence in evidence-based policy and practice: Examples from systematic reviews of literature
Segerholm, Christina; Lindgren, Joakim; Novak, Judit	2022	Evidence-Based Governing? Educational Research in the Service of the Swedish Schools Inspectorate
Shepherd, Jonathan	2014	How to achieve more effective services
Sirat, Morshidi; Azman, Norzaini	2014	Malaysia's National Higher Education Research Institute (IPPTN): narrowing the research-policy gap in a dynamic higher education system
Skalitzky, E; Joyner, H ; Weymouth, L.	2022	Local Data for Action: Statewide Dissemination of School Wellness Policy Evaluations in Wisconsin
Steiner-Khamsi, Gita; Karseth, Berit; Baek, Chanwoong	2020	From science to politics: commissioned reports and their political translation into White Papers
Stratford, R; Wals, A.E.	2020	In search of healthy policy ecologies for education in relation to sustainability: Beyond evidence-based policy and post-truth politics
Street, C; Guenther, J; Smith, J; Robertson, K; Ludwig, W; Motlap, S; Woodroffe, T; Ober, R; Gillan, K; Larkin, S.	2022	Do numbers speak for themselves? Exploring the use of quantitative data to measure policy 'success' in historical Indigenous higher education in the Northern Territory, Australia
Wentworth, Laura; Mazzeo, Christopher; Connolly, Faith	2017	Research practice partnerships: A strategy for promoting evidence-based decision-making in education
Winton, Sue; Evans, Michael P.	2016	Consulting, Mediating, Conducting, and Supporting: How Community-Based Organizations Engage with Research to Influence Policy
Wollscheid, Sabine; Stensaker, Bjørn; Bugge, Markus M.	2019	Evidence-Informed Policy and Practice in the Field of Education: The Dilemmas Related to Organizational Design

Author(s)	Year	Title
Wyse, Dominic; Torgerson, Carole	2017	Experimental trials and 'what works?' in education: The case of grammar for writing
Yingling, D.L; Mallinson, D.J.	2020	Explaining variation in evidence-based policy making in the American states
Zapp, Mike; Powell, Justin J.W.	2017	Moving towards Mode 2? Evidence-based policy-making and the changing conditions for educational research in Germany
Zhang, Q.T.	2018	Theory, practice and policy: A longitudinal study of university knowledge exchange in the United Kingdom

Note

[1] The 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey (see OECD (2022[17])) collected data from 37 ministries and departments of education in 29 countries to map the knowledge mobilisation mechanisms, actors and challenges across education systems. Responses were collected from ministries of education at the national or sub-national level – e.g. state, province, canton.

3 The heat is on: Mapping knowledge mobilisation

Nóra Révai, OECD

This chapter describes the different types of activities that educational organisations undertake to facilitate the use of research. It presents a heatmap of knowledge mobilisation activities across various educational organisations worldwide, which visualises these efforts from sparse or non-existent to activities that are systematically implemented. By examining this spectrum of activity, the chapter aims to identify patterns and highlight areas in need of improvement. Two case studies, one set in the Netherlands and one in the United Kingdom, provide examples of a multi-faceted approach to knowledge mobilisation.

Key messages of this chapter

A heatmap of knowledge mobilisation activities can support countries and organisations in improving and co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level. The international landscape suggests that a variety of organisations engage in numerous activities to support the use of research in policy or practice.

- Evidence dissemination, as well as collaboration and partnership building are the dominant knowledge mobilisation mechanisms. Support for organisations in developing processes and structures for research engagement is also relatively frequent. Activities aimed at improving knowledge mobilisation at the system-level, such as co-ordination of efforts, are rarer but still surprisingly widespread.
- However, there are also clear gaps: Training and capacity building are the weakest links of knowledge mobilisation, particularly for researchers and intermediaries.
- Four knowledge mobilisation profiles emerge from the data: *Research-focused mobilisers*, who focus on evidence generation and dissemination; *research funders*, who fund and commission research; *partnership builders* who focus on facilitating collaboration among actors and creating communication channels, and *capacity builders with a system focus* who build actors' research capacity and provide support for organisations and systems.
- The optimal distribution of activities may depend on the unique characteristics of the different types of organisations (e.g. mission, skills, legitimacy). Some knowledge mobilisation roles can be more clearly attributed to certain types of organisations, such as developing teachers' research engagement skills to initial teacher education institutions, whereas others depend on the context and may be different for every system.

Examining the coverage and the distribution of activities, four types of knowledge mobilisation systems can be distinguished: dysfunctional (low coverage, unco-ordinated), redundant (high coverage, unco-ordinated), patchy (low coverage, co-ordinated) and optimal (high coverage, co-ordinated).

Introduction

Numerous countries across the OECD have heavily invested in facilitating and reinforcing the use of education research in recent years. Despite this investment, ministries of education continue to report that a lack of mechanisms to facilitate research use is a major barrier to its systematic use in policy and practice (OECD, 2022[1]). At the same time, an increasing number of organisations engage in activities that mediate between research and its use in policy and practice (Burns and Schuller, 2022[2]; Oliver et al., 2022[3]). The OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (henceforth, the intermediaries' survey) collected data from 288 intermediary organisations in 34 countries to better understand how they are supporting research engagement (see Chapter 1).

The current chapter presents the global picture of knowledge mobilisation activities across different types of organisations. It first discusses the typology of activities included in the intermediaries' survey and the underlying conceptual model. Then it presents the overall intensity of knowledge mobilisation before going into the analysis by type of organisation. The chapter includes two case studies that target system-wide improvement. It concludes with some reflection prompts for the readers.

Understanding "knowledge mobilisation" in the survey

The term "knowledge mobilisation" is used broadly in the intermediaries' survey to refer to any *intentional efforts to increase or improve the use of research evidence in education policy and/or practice*. For the purposes of a survey, a list of 21 activities was identified based on a review of literature and previous surveys (Oliver et al., 2022[3]; Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[4]). The list includes well-specified and distinct activities of knowledge mobilisation, categorised in six thematic groups:

- evidence generation;
- evidence dissemination;
- collaboration and partnerships;
- capacity building;
- organisational support;
- local, regional or national-level support (see Chapter 1 and Annex Table 3.A.1 for more details).

In practice, these activities often occur simultaneously within a more complex initiative. For example, the Knowledge Roundabout described in the Netherlands case study later on in this chapter includes evidence generation, dissemination and capacity building within one initiative. While the list covers a wide range of activities, it is not fully comprehensive. Indeed, organisations engage in a very wide range of activities, not all of which can be captured in a survey (for more examples see (OECD, 2023[5]; OECD, 2024[6])).

Together with the conceptual and practical challenges described in Chapter 1, these complexities imply that the intermediaries' survey is naturally limited in terms of its scope and, perhaps, conceptual clarity. In addition, as pointed out in Chapter 1, the set of respondents cannot be considered as representative of any country's knowledge system, nor of the different types of intermediaries. While the wide range and high number of respondent intermediaries allow for an analysis of the aggregated data and some cautious implications with respect to the international landscape of knowledge mobilisation, this chapter does not offer comparative analysis across countries.

> **The heatmap is a reflection tool more than a presentation of statistical outcomes.**
>
> *– Rien Rouw, Strategic Advisor, Ministry of Education, Culture and Science, the Netherlands*

The heatmap should primarily be used as a reflection tool (see Box 3.1). The authors invite the readers to think beyond the survey results. For instance, the reader might use the list of knowledge mobilisation activities as a diagnostic tool for their own organisation or develop a heatmap for their own system (see Reflection questions and activities box at the end of the chapter).

Box 3.1. Readers' guide to the heatmap: A reflection tool

The heatmap can help reflect on the overall distribution of knowledge mobilisation activities in two ways:

From the perspective of the activities

Looking at the rows, the heatmap can help readers to identify activities and groups/types of activities that are missing: none or very few organisations do them intensively.

From the perspective of organisations

Looking at the columns, the heatmap can help readers reflect on whether "the right organisations are doing the right activities". It can point to activities that a certain type of organisation perhaps should be doing but is not, or those that some are doing but maybe should not.

Note of caution: No normative assumption

The heatmap should not be interpreted under the normative assumption that the darker red cells, the better. It would not be meaningful, nor cost-efficient, for all types of organisations to engage deeply in all knowledge mobilisation activities.

Heatmap of knowledge mobilisation

The heatmap of knowledge mobilisation (Figure 3.1) shows the proportion of organisations carrying out each activity intensively, i.e. to a large extent or systematically (calculated from respondents answering to what extent they carry out each activity on a 5-point Likert scale).

Figure 3.1. Knowledge mobilisation heatmap

Types of activities	Activities	Formal intermediary (61)	Public intermediary (49)	Research institution (138)	Initial teacher education inst. (48)	Inspectorate / QA service (27)	Funding organisation (31)	Teacher union (29)	Consulting firm (40)	Overall (288)
Evidence generation	Conducting primary research	48%	35%	72%	63%	48%	29%	21%	60%	51%
	Conducting secondary research	62%	47%	59%	31%	41%	42%	17%	65%	47%
	Conducting systematic reviews or meta-analyses	44%	22%	36%	29%	11%	29%	14%	33%	27%
	Conducting intervention/programme evaluations	31%	29%	33%	17%	30%	19%	10%	43%	25%
	Commissioning and funding research	21%	43%	22%	21%	11%	65%	17%	18%	25%
Evidence dissemination	Producing, curating and maintaining an evidence repository	48%	39%	38%	29%	33%	39%	17%	40%	34%
	Disseminating research in user-friendly formats	69%	53%	60%	44%	26%	65%	38%	55%	53%
	Establishing and maintaining communication channels for disseminating research	79%	63%	64%	48%	59%	74%	48%	68%	63%
Collaboration and partnerships	Mapping research users or mobilisers	41%	37%	41%	44%	22%	29%	28%	38%	37%
	Facilitating connections/collaboration among actors to increase research use	67%	55%	72%	65%	33%	58%	45%	60%	60%
	Building partnerships with actors to facilitate research use	66%	57%	67%	60%	22%	45%	45%	65%	56%
Capacity building	Training practitioners or policy makers to help them use research	46%	22%	46%	48%	22%	16%	17%	48%	33%
	Training researchers (e.g. to communicate research)	13%	8%	30%	33%	7%	13%	14%	18%	20%
	Training intermediaries to develop brokerage skills	7%	4%	15%	15%	4%	6%	3%	13%	10%
	Building leadership capacity to support research use	41%	18%	31%	33%	15%	26%	28%	53%	29%
Organisational support	Directly supporting policy organisations/schools in developing infrastructure, processes and cultural changes	46%	41%	44%	33%	26%	39%	38%	63%	41%
	Directly supporting the development/implementation of policies in policy orgs / practices in schools with research	38%	39%	40%	35%	37%	26%	21%	60%	36%
Local, regional or national-level support	Evaluating knowledge mobilisation initiatives	33%	22%	23%	21%	15%	32%	21%	30%	23%
	Supporting the scaling/sustainability of effective knowledge mobilisation initiatives	34%	22%	22%	19%	15%	29%	14%	33%	21%
	Coordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system-level	51%	43%	31%	25%	26%	32%	24%	48%	34%
	Creating/sustaining system-level infrastructure, processes or incentives for knowledge mobilisation	33%	39%	25%	25%	15%	26%	21%	28%	26%

Notes: Data show the percentage of the given type of organisation that reports doing the given activities to a large extent or systematically. As respondents could identify as several types of organisations, the same respondent might be represented in several columns. The last column shows the overall percentage of organisations that reports doing the given activities to a large extent or systematically. The number of respondents per type of organisation is indicated in parentheses. Redder shades represent progressively higher percentages (more common activities), while bluer shades represent progressively lower percentages (less common activities).Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

Perspective of activities

The heatmap suggests that all activities are covered to some extent by these types of organisations, but the extent varies widely.

Evidence dissemination, as well as collaboration and partnership building are the dominant knowledge mobilisation mechanisms

Close to two-thirds of surveyed organisations reported establishing communication channels for dissemination, the activity most commonly carried out systematically. While this activity was classified as dissemination, it can also be a relational approach if designed to be interactive (bi-directional). Disseminating research in user-friendly formats is also a common form of knowledge mobilisation, reported by more than half of the respondents.

On average, one in three organisations reported curating and maintaining an evidence repository (i.e. a structured database or collection of research syntheses). Repositories can be a major support for research users, particularly if they are easy to navigate and provide transparent information on the type and quality of evidence (Gough, Sharples and Maidment, 2022[7]). However, having too many diverse repositories can be a barrier – users may get lost in such volume and it might be difficult to judge which repository serves what purpose and can help answer what types of questions. They might also use different standards of evidence, which not only adds to the difficulty of navigating among them, but may also create mistrust. Importantly, it may reflect duplicated effort, which raises questions about cost-efficiency, given that maintaining a repository is costly.

The Education Endowment Foundation (EEF)'s Teaching and Learning Toolkit is perhaps the best-known evidence repository and has achieved international attention, with many countries currently adapting it to their own context. It focuses primarily on meta-analyses of causal evidence (randomised control trials (RCTs) and quasi-experimental designs). Increasingly more knowledge centres focus on systematic reviews, including a broader range of methodologies (e.g. the Norwegian Knowledge Centre, DIPF | Leibniz Institute for Research and Information in Education, the EEF itself) although such form of rigorous synthesis is still more rare than in the health sector (Education.org, 2021[8]).

While a large proportion of all types of organisations facilitate collaboration and build partnerships for research use, the mapping of users or mobilisers of research evidence is somewhat less widespread. Yet, strategic knowledge mobilisation should involve a good understanding of the actors and their needs, with regular updates given the continuously shifting landscape of actors (Gough, Sharples and Maidment, 2022[7]). An example of a systematic mapping is outlined in the case study below.

Training and capacity building are the weakest links of knowledge mobilisation, particularly for researchers and brokers

Knowledge mobilisation is more impactful when research is practice-centred and tailored to policy and practice needs (Farley-Ripple and MacGregor, 2024[9]). The effectiveness of research-practice and research-policy partnerships hinges upon the knowledge, competencies and attitudes of its participants, among other factors (Phelps, 2019[10]; Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[11]). Researchers' understanding of practitioners' and policy makers' context, their openness to prioritising users' needs and ability to communicate research effectively are characteristics often less important for academic career progression compared to the number of publications and citations in academic journals (OECD, 2024[12]). The data suggest that researchers do not necessarily have learning opportunities to build this capacity. This may have deeper underlying reasons, as the following quote suggests:

> **Lack of training for researchers may reflect social norms: Academics might prefer to see themselves as 'pure researchers' and do not want to receive training for policy engagement.**
>
> *– Javier González, Director of Laboratory for Research and Innovation in Education for Latin America*

The term "training" suggests formal learning, e.g. in the form of courses and workshops. However, in academic and policy environments, learning is often informal and happens through experiences, as the quote below reflects. Responses may have been different if the question had been phrased differently (e.g. had included informal learning and other forms of capacity building, such as masterclasses).

> **I would say I have training in my job, but it is more learning by doing. We need to reflect on what we mean by training.**
>
> *– Elisabeth Buk-Berge, Norwegian Ministry of Education and Research*

Effective brokering requires individual competencies such as communication skills and an ability to facilitate quality interactions in challenging contexts (e.g. where power relations between researchers and teachers may be at play) (Edwards, 2012[13]). They also need to recognise opportunities for crossing the boundaries between the research and practice or policy contexts, and flexibly shift between these (Bakx et al., 2016[14]; Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[11]). Yet, the activity least commonly reported is training brokers, i.e. individuals or organisations whose role is to bridge the research-policy or research-practice gap (Akkerman and Bakker, 2011[15]). A promising initiative is a pilot project to train early-career teachers and researchers to become successful brokers (see the case study from Germany in (Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[11])). OECD work has also pointed to a lack of peer learning across intermediaries (OECD, 2023[5]). The EEF has established its Education Evidence Network to facilitate exchange and learning about evidence synthesis across organisations adapting the EEF Toolkit internationally (EEF, 2024[16]).

Support for organisations is relatively frequent, activities aimed at improving knowledge mobilisation at the system level are rarer but still surprisingly widespread

More than one-third of organisations report supporting schools and/or policy organisations in developing processes for knowledge mobilisation, or directly aiding them in research implementation. Sustained and direct support at the level of organisations is said to be more effective than one-off training for individuals (Oliver, forthcoming[17]), so this is promising news. Slightly less than one in four respondents report scaling or evaluating knowledge mobilisation initiatives (see also Chapter 6), and creating system-level infrastructure, processes and incentives (see the Netherlands case study below for examples). This still seems high, considering that the main mission of most respondents is not knowledge mobilisation per se (but teacher training, school inspection, consultancy, etc.) and thus one might think that engaging in system-level improvement of knowledge mobilisation would fall out of their scope. There is also a question of what the desirable extent of system-level improvement is. Would it be more effective to have fewer actors focusing on this kind of activity to create coherence in terms of infrastructure, processes and incentives?

Many organisations co-ordinate knowledge mobilisation at the system level

This leads to the question of co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level across different actors, which is reportedly done by more than one-third of the surveyed organisations to a large extent or systematically. What does such co-ordination involve? Do organisations co-ordinate collectively (e.g. operate as a network) or does this widespread engagement represent parallel efforts? How many actors can co-ordinate knowledge mobilisation at the same time and who should those actors be? Answers to these questions will be different depending on how education is governed in a system. In top-down, centralised systems, the national ministry might be an accepted actor to co-ordinate knowledge mobilisation, while in decentralised systems, an independent body, such as a formal intermediary or some

form of a network of organisations might be better suited (see the United Kingdom case study for further examples on systemic influences).

Perspective of organisations

The heatmap shows that all types of respondent organisations engage in several knowledge mobilisation activities intensively. Most organisations reported engaging in 7 activities out of 21 to a large extent or systematically. The distribution is skewed towards the bottom, indicating that many organisations focus on a few activities intensively and there are very few with a large scope, carrying out a high number of activities systematically. The most active ones are formal intermediaries and consulting firms, closely followed by research institutions, while inspectorates and quality assurance agencies, and teacher unions, are the least active.

Four knowledge mobilisation profiles emerge: Research-focused mobilisers, research funders, partnership builders and capacity builders with a system-focus

There are four distinct knowledge mobilisation profiles that emerge from the data[1]:

Table 3.1. Four knowledge mobilisation profiles

Profile	Characteristics	Dominant approaches
Research-focused knowledge mobilisers	These organisations focus on research production and research dissemination. Their main focus is on conducting primary and secondary research, systematic reviews and, to a slightly lesser extent, programme evaluations. Disseminating research in user-friendly formats and establishing communication channels for dissemination are activities that often – although not consistently – go together with research production. Occasionally, these organisations also curate an evidence repository.	Linear approaches.
Research funders	Organisations that focus primarily on commissioning and funding research. Two activities complement this profile to an extent: supporting the scaling and sustainability of knowledge mobilisation initiatives and creating system-level infrastructure, processes and incentives.	Linear approaches with some degree of systems approaches.
Partnership builders	Facilitating connections and collaboration among different actors and building partnership are two strongly linked activities. Organisations focusing on these relational approaches also tend to establish communication channels for dissemination and map research users and mobilisers.	Relational approaches.
Capacity builders and system-focused mobilisers	Building the capacity of different actors to reinforce research use tends to go together with activities that support organisations through co-design and development support, and systems at the local, regional or national level through evaluating, scaling and co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation and creating infrastructure, processes and incentives.	Relational and systems approaches.

Notes: Profiles were determined based on exploratory factor analysis conducted with the Factor Analyzer package of Python, using Promax rotation and maximum likelihood method (https://pypi.org/project/factor-analyzer/). Eigen values and factor loadings are provided in Annex Table 3.A.2.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

There are several implications of these knowledge mobilisation profiles. First, research producers are primarily focused on dissemination, whereas creating partnerships with users, building actors' capacity to understand and apply research, or providing systemic support for knowledge mobilisation are not systematically done by organisations with this profile. This may reflect a traditional view of research production, which is largely isolated from its application in policy and practice, as well as insufficient

capacity for substantive engagement with users, including a lack of human and financial resources or a lack of appropriate incentives for all actors. In the United Kingdom, several universities (e.g. University of Manchester, University of Nottingham and University College London) now have policy engagement centres, which focus on enabling their researchers and students to increase the impact of their research and to build their network with policy makers. The driving force behind such initiatives is primarily to promote the impact of the research undertaken within these institutions and it is therefore questionable whether they contribute to systemic support for knowledge mobilisation. However, it is also questionable whether it is realistic and desirable (e.g. in terms of resource allocation) for every research producer to build more substantive relationships and capacity with users or provide systemic support.

Second, the slight tendency of funders of research towards systems approaches shows that the sustainability and scalability of knowledge mobilisation, as well as system-level factors, are increasingly considered in funding schemes (see, for example, the Latvia case study in Chapter 5). On the other hand, funding is more rarely accompanied by evaluating knowledge mobilisation initiatives. This may prevent the field from generating evidence on knowledge mobilisation and being able to build on that in determining investment and scaling (see Chapter 6 for further detail).

Third, the fact that capacity building tends to go together with systems approaches, but less with partnership building, raises questions about the impact of partnerships. If partnership-building efforts are not integrated with capacity building, for example, to develop actors' research use skills, these partnerships may not lead to quality engagement with research (Langer, Tripney and Gough, 2016[18]; Farrell et al., 2021[19]). On the positive side, organisations with a system focus on knowledge mobilisation recognise that skills and capacity are key pieces in a system, and tend to complement activities such as co-design, organisational and local or regional-level support with training and capacity building.

Who is doing what in knowledge mobilisation is not neutral: Some roles are uncontroversial, while some might be contentious

The ideal distribution of activities may depend on the unique characteristics of the different types of organisations (e.g. mission, skills, roles). Some knowledge mobilisation roles can be more clearly attributed to certain types of organisations, whereas others depend on the context and may be different for every system.

An example of a clear role is training teachers, in the context of the intermediaries' survey, this pertains to developing their research engagement skills. Clearly, initial teacher education (ITE) institutions should play a major role in this with respect to teacher candidates. The 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey, which collected data from 37 Ministries of Education in 29 countries, demonstrated gaps in this field. Respondent ministries reported that developing such skills is required or widely covered in ITE in only slightly more than half of systems on average, and continuous professional development does not seem to compensate for this gap, with 42% of systems developing research skills in professional development (OECD, 2022[1]). Data from ITE institutions in the intermediaries' survey corroborates ministries' perceptions – less than half report training practitioners to help them use research to a large extent or systematically. Promising examples include the *Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona* (the Autonomous University of Barcelona) (see Box 3.2). Interestingly, 20 research institutions that do not function as initial teacher education institutes reported that they are active in training teachers and policy makers. Consulting firms are as active in training practitioners or policy makers as teacher education institutes, suggesting that this gap is at least partially filled by the private sector.

Box 3.2. Developing teachers' research skills at the Autonomous University of Barcelona

The Autonomous University of Barcelona offers a bachelor's programme to prepare primary school teachers and a master's programme to prepare teachers in secondary and vocational education. Research skills are part of the core competences to be developed and supported by various courses at both levels.

Table 3.2. Research competencies and courses at the primary and secondary levels

Level	Competencies	Example courses
Primary education	**Focus is on research use:** Graduates are expected to "act with responsibility, take decisions and critically analyse proposals on education emerging from research and education innovation".	Educational Psychology in Primary Education; Sociology of Education: Social and Educational Change and Multiculturality; Research and Innovation in Educational Practice.
Secondary education	**Focus is on conducting research:** Graduates are expected to "apply fundamental educational research techniques and methodologies, and the capacity to design and carry out research and innovation projects".	Sociology of Secondary Education; Innovation and Educational Research (related to the specific discipline); Scientific Research Methodology in the Classroom.

In addition, the university's summer school offers an optional hands-on course called "Solving Socio-Educational Challenges through Research: Hands on Experience", which equips education professionals with skills in research, evaluation and innovation through an immersive, challenge-based approach.

Source: Autonomous University of Barcelona (2024[20]), *Bachelor's degree in Teacher in Primary Education*, https://web.ub.edu/en/web/estudis/w/bachelordegree-G1026?subjects; Autonomous University of Barcelona (2024[21]), *Master in Teacher Training in Obligatory Secondary and Upper Secondary School Education, Vocational Training and Languages*, https://web.ub.edu/en/web/estudis/w/masteruniversitari-M2002?objectivesCompetencies; Autonomous University of Barcelona (2024[22]), *Solving Socio-Educational Challenges through Research: Hands on Experience*, https://www.uab.cat/web/cursos/cursos-de-ciencias-sociales-y-juridicas/research-methods-in-education-1345905134700.html.

An example of a less straightforward knowledge mobilisation role is that of education consulting firms. These for-profit organisations advise education authorities, schools or other education-related bodies on educational planning, research and project development. In the intermediaries' survey, education consulting firms reported to have as widespread knowledge mobilisation activities as formal intermediaries, i.e. organisations with an explicit mandate for this work. For example, a higher proportion of education consulting firms report organisational support activities, building leadership capacity and even co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level than formal intermediaries. If these consulting firms' primary interest is selling their services, their high-level engagement suggests substantive demand for knowledge mobilisation services. This demand may originate from insufficient or inappropriate knowledge mobilisation support by public institutions, which creates an opening filled by private providers. It could also stem from taking a wider market-based approach to the allocation of resources in education – the extent to which countries do this varies across OECD countries (OECD, 2024[23]). There are likely some systems where for-profit education consulting actors simply have a more commonly accepted, familiar and legitimate role in supporting public education, including knowledge mobilisation. When knowledge mobilisation is based on business interest, there is a question about its neutrality. Can business interests influence the selection of research evidence to be mobilised, or the nature and quality of the different

activities? To what extent could that be concerning? These questions hold for all for-profit actors, including, for example, increasingly privately-funded research institutes.

It must also be noted that all education consulting firms identified as other types of organisations as well: more than half of them also claim to be research institutes and around one-third identify as a formal intermediary (see Chapter 1). In some countries, education consulting firms compete for public research mobilisation grants. For example, in the United States, the Regional Education Labs (REL) are a mechanism to support state- and district-level decision making with educational data and evidence (see case study in Chapter 4). Some of the RELs, like Marzano Research (Box 3.3), are consultancies with a knowledge mobilisation mandate.

Box 3.3. Knowledge mobilisation by Marzano Research

Marzano Research is a private consulting firm in the United States that – as part of its applied research and consulting work – supports policy makers' and practitioners' intentional engagement with research. The work is often carried out in the form of research-practice partnership, particularly through the Regional Education Labs (RELs) programme.

Teacher as Researcher initiative in South Carolina, United States

The Teacher as Researcher initiative implemented by Marzano is a professional learning programme that supports teachers in conducting research in their own classrooms. In the 2022/23 academic year, 172 teachers in 32 schools participated in the programme, the costs of which were covered by the state of South Carolina.

Teachers are given instruction on research design through six two-hour workshops. They then conduct quasi-experiments to test the effectiveness of specific instructional strategies (by implementing it in one classroom and keeping their "traditional" strategy in another).

Internal evaluation of the programme is done through surveys, video recordings of the research design workshops and interviews with teachers. One challenge has been the timing and development of the workshops: while short sessions seem to be more manageable than, for example, a two-day research design workshop, it is still challenging to get teachers to volunteer for this kind of professional development initiative, given the time investment needed.

Source: Interview with Marzano Research, June 2024.

In addition to organisational interests, other factors should also be considered in assessing whether "the right organisation is doing the right activity". These include the organisational competencies and skills to conduct an activity at a high standard, as well as the perceived legitimacy of the organisation to engage in an activity (for example, its independence from government).

Bottom line: Knowledge mobilisation systems

Combining the perspective of activities and that of organisations, it is possible to examine a knowledge mobilisation system (e.g. at the local, regional or national level) along two axes: the coverage of activities and the extent to which activities are co-ordinated (i.e. well-aligned and complementary). A simplistic analysis would then distinguish between the four types of systems presented in Table 3.3. While the intermediaries' survey data does not allow for placing countries or sub-national education systems in this framework, it can serve as a reflection-starter. Importantly, this classification does not say anything about the quality of knowledge mobilisation activities and their impact, which would be a third dimension and is addressed in Chapter 6.

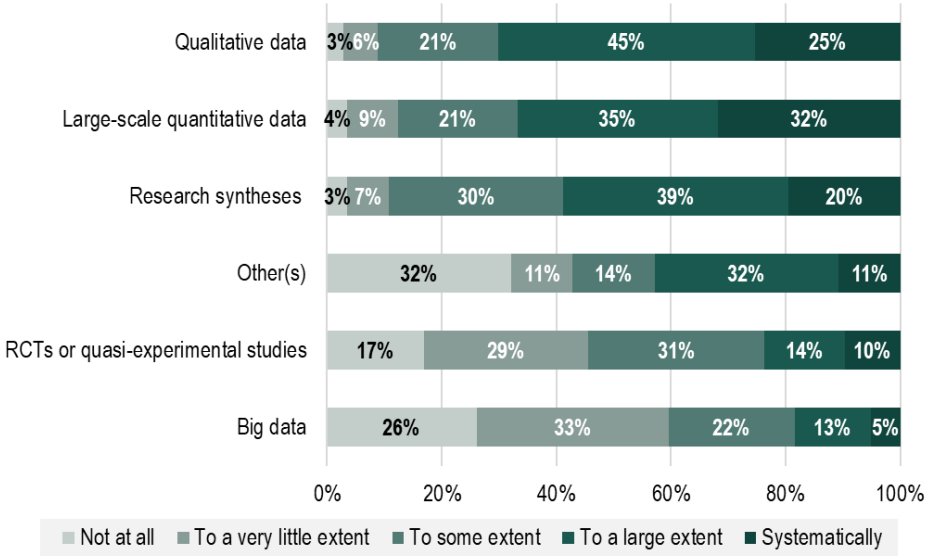
Table 3.3. Knowledge mobilisation at the system level

Distribution of activities	Coverage of activities: Low	Coverage of activities: High
Unco-ordinated	**Dysfunctional** Knowledge mobilisation is not appropriately facilitated by a range of activities. Activities that do exist may be duplicated or not conducted by the types of organisations with the appropriate profiles and capacity.	**Redundant** Knowledge mobilisation is facilitated by a range of activities that cover all key areas. However, activities may be duplicated or not conducted by the types of organisations with the appropriate profiles and capacity.
Co-ordinated	**Patchy** Knowledge mobilisation is not appropriately facilitated by a range of activities. Activities that do exist are well co-ordinated and are conducted by organisations with the appropriate profiles and capacity.	**Optimal** Knowledge mobilisation is facilitated by a range of activities that cover all key areas. Activities are well co-ordinated and are conducted by organisations with the appropriate profiles and capacity.

Evidence types

The intermediaries' survey also asked about the types of evidence organisations use in their knowledge mobilisation activities (see Figure 3.2). Typically, organisations focus on three types of research out of 6 (including "other") to a large extent or systematically (mode = 3, mean = 2.4). Just like with activities, few organisations demonstrate a broad coverage of research types (9% of organisations cover five types). Again, there is no normative assumption that all actors should cover all research types, if organisations are transparent about the types and quality of evidence that they use (Gough, Sharples and Maidment, 2022[7]).

Figure 3.2. Types of research at the centre of knowledge mobilisation



Note: Data show the percentage of organisations reporting that their knowledge mobilisation activities focus on the given type of research to a large extent or systematically.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/zp6wj4

The focus tends to be on qualitative data and large-scale quantitative data. Big data still seems to be novel and underexploited for knowledge mobilisation purposes in education. RCTs and quasi-experimental studies are the gold standard in health research, but still rare in education research (see also Chapter 2). Perhaps what is more worrying is the relatively low focus on research synthesis, which may reflect the lack of such synthesis in education (see Chapter 2).

In addition to the types of research listed in the intermediaries' survey, some organisations reported to also focus on mixed methods, policy reviews and critical analyses, collaborative research and curriculum policy audits. Interestingly, two organisations also mentioned other knowledge sources, such as knowledge from practitioners and from bottom-up deliberative stakeholder processes. Although these are not types of research, these data reflect the fact that quality engagement with research in reality involves combining and making sense of various sources of knowledge.

The following sections present two case studies. Both demonstrate a multi-faceted approach to knowledge mobilisation combining a number of activities in strategic ways.

Case study 1: Developing a knowledge infrastructure in Dutch education

The Netherlands' efforts to improve the use of education research in policy and practice have resulted in rethinking knowledge mobilisation at different levels and in a range of institutions.

Bringing practice and research together: The Ontwikkelkracht *programme*

The *Ontwikkelkracht* (development power) Programme[2], launched in January 2023, aims to develop learning capacity in the education system by building a knowledge infrastructure. The programme aims to foster interaction between educational research and practice by ensuring that insights from the classroom get a place in research, and that science insights are given a place in the classroom. *Ontwikkelkracht* was founded by a scientist and a teacher and is now led by the Ministry of Education, Culture and Science in collaboration with the Netherlands Initiative for Education Research (NRO), Education Lab Netherlands, *Groeikracht* and The Transformative School. *Ontwikkelkracht* follows three principles: Evidence-informed practice, working in co-creation and through a learning approach.

In 2022, EUR 332 million was allocated for this project from the National Growth Fund for the next 10 years (up to and including 2032). Of this amount, EUR 101 million has been allocated for the first 4 years. The other part (EUR 231 million) has been conditionally granted for the following 6 years.

In the pilot phase (2023/24 academic year), 41 schools participated in the *Ontwikkelkracht* programme. In 2024/25, almost 300 schools are joining the programme. The programme has four pillars:

- *Strengthen the research and school improvement culture* in schools by offering approaches to school improvement.
- *Make knowledge from research accessible* and useful for educational professionals.
- *Set up co-creation education labs* in which education professionals and researchers co-create new knowledge for complex issues from practice, hopefully resulting in new effective interventions that can be used in the classroom.
- *Train and support "expertise schools"* that successfully improve education in an evidence-informed way to *share their knowledge with other schools*.

The Netherlands Initiative for Education Research: A funder-broker approach

The Netherlands Initiative for Education Research (NRO) is part of the Dutch Research Council. The NRO was established in 2012 and has been fully operational since 2014 with an annual budget of around

EUR 15 million (NRO, 2024[24]) and supplemented with a substantial amount of programme-based funding. It has three main missions:

- facilitate the coherence of education research by providing co-ordination at a national level
- award grants for high-quality research
- facilitate knowledge use by improving the links between science, policy and practice.

In recent years, the NRO has been expanding its mission from an organisation originally focused on funding research to a knowledge intermediary with a comprehensive knowledge mobilisation strategy. It has become a member of the Education Endowment Foundation's (EEF) Education Evidence Network (EEF, 2024[16]) and has engaged in adapting the EEF Teaching and Learning Toolkit in the Netherlands. In addition, the NRO established a Knowledge Use Council (KBR) that advises the organisation on developing its knowledge mobilisation strategy and activities. It consists of experts from the policy, practice and research communities and meets four times a year. The following are two main processes of the NRO exemplifying its research funding and knowledge mobilisation activities respectively.

Knowledge Agenda

To ensure that the financial resources for education research are spent effectively, the NRO develops its research programme, the Knowledge Agenda for Education (NRO, 2022[25]), which sets out the themes for research funds for the period 2022-2028. The programme is driven by policy and practice needs that the NRO explores in partnership with professionals, including school leaders, policy officers, research institutes, advisors, scientific researchers and other stakeholders.

Following the publication of calls for proposals, the NRO assesses the proposals and selects the ones that receive funding based on their relevance and scientific quality. The selection process involves invited national and international experts from science and educational practice. Funded research projects are closely monitored through regular consultations with the research team and the intended end users to ensure that they retain their relevance for educational practice or policy.

The NRO disseminates research widely, including through its knowledge bank (a database of educational research), and supports researcher teams in disseminating their results through organising meetings where researchers, education professionals and policy makers can exchange knowledge and experience.

*Knowledge Roundabout (*Kennisrotonde*)*

The Knowledge Roundabout is a free online support and information service for schools that answers practitioners' questions based on scientific literature. The answers include a simple overview of the do's and don'ts, and are made available online as well as actively disseminated through social media and events. The process takes place in four steps:

1. The professional asks the question through a form on the Knowledge Roundabout website.
2. An employee of the Knowledge Roundabout – a knowledge broker or a contracted expert –contacts the professional and helps to shape the question into a research question.
3. The employee dives into literature to formulate the answer.
4. The answer is discussed with the person who asked the question and is published online.

A guide on how to formulate research questions supports practitioners in the process (NRO, 2019[26]). The Knowledge Roundabout has answered over 800 questions since it was founded in 2016 (Kennisrotonde, 2024[27]) and has an increasing reach, based on the number of incoming questions and followers on social platforms. The Knowledge Roundabout has been evaluated three times (2016, 2020 and 2023), each time by a different independent research organisation. They all concluded that professionals who ask questions are satisfied with the Knowledge Roundabout and that the answers help professionals to question and

change their practice. The Knowledge Roundabout has helped to remove barriers, such as limited time for using research, that professionals often experience. It can spark debates among professionals on social media, which leads to stronger shared knowledge backed up by research. A downside is the time it takes to answer questions (>10 weeks), although according to the last evaluation report (van den Berg and Prins, 2023[28]), most professionals do not mind that.

Challenges and limitations

The Netherlands' substantive investment in improving knowledge mobilisation has resulted in a rich knowledge mobilisation infrastructure. As this development has been running in parallel in many organisations and at different levels, there is now a question of how all the functions and activities could be co-ordinated and consolidated. While some level of collaboration exists between the different actors, there is certainly potential for more. For example, although the two initiatives described above cooperate on knowledge dissemination activities, it is unclear how they align their research agendas and broader knowledge mobilisation strategies. To use a metaphor recently applied to co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation: the Netherlands is currently reflecting on who is leading the "jazz band" of knowledge mobilisation (Maxwell, Sharples and Coldwell, 2022, p. 25[29]). While the Ministry of Education, Culture and Science could be a natural actor, in such a decentralised system as is the Netherlands, it might be perceived as overly controlling and putting the autonomy of other organisations at risk.

Equally, several initiatives are in early stages and more time is required to assess their effectiveness and impact on the quality of education policies and practices. While most initiatives invest in evaluating their impact, the diversity of these efforts will make it more difficult to disentangle the impact of each. Strategic co-ordination of the different efforts should also include a system-level approach to assessing their impact.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

Despite the outstanding question of what strategic leadership of knowledge mobilisation means, the Netherlands' initiatives can be useful for other countries who may be looking to enhance their approach. They involve substantive explorations, experimentations, advice from a range of different stakeholders and a systematic reflection on their achievements and impact. Conditions for developing such a knowledge infrastructure in the Netherlands included:

- political and policy emphasis on evidence-informed education practice;
- support from schools and school boards;
- an emerging teacher-led research movement.

These could be important levers in both centralised and decentralised education systems. In addition, the presence of a main actor – the NRO in the case of the Netherlands – can play a major role in preparing the ground for further initiatives by raising awareness of evidence use across the board.

Case study 2. A systems approach to supporting knowledge mobilisation in the Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC) Education Research Programme (the United Kingdom)

The ESRC Education Research Programme runs between 2021-2026 and funds nine projects implemented in the four UK nations (see Box 3.4). The programme set out to "ask new questions about how research, policy and practice can come together to empower educators and create meaningful change" (University College London, 2024[30]). While each of the nine projects has its own theory of change, they are intended to interact and partner in their knowledge mobilisation approaches and learning

journeys. The projects are supported by the programme team that is conducting research to understand how knowledge mobilisation efforts could be maximised and tailored for the context of the different UK nations. The research explores what a systems approach to knowledge mobilisation might look like in the context of different policy cultures in the four UK nations. This has taken the form of a comprehensive policy landscape mapping activity led by a research fellow at University College London (UCL).

Box 3.4. The Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC) Education Research Programme

The ESRC is part of United Kingdom Research and Innovation, a non-departmental public body funded by the government. The ESRC provides funding and support for research and training in the social sciences. In 2021 the ESRC commissioned an Education Research Programme to explore two themes:

- teaching and learning, focusing on the role of teachers, their recruitment, retention and professional development;
- the uses of technology for teaching and learning.

The five-year programme includes funding for a cohort of nine research projects based in universities across the United Kingdom. The Programme Director set an additional overarching vision for the programme: to explore new ways of working in partnership across the boundaries between education research, policy and practice in the four nations of the United Kingdom.

The main themes emerged from consultations with the research community and the commitment of the ESRC 2019 Delivery Plan to delivering a policy-relevant research programme. They also align with the Department for Education (DfE)'s Areas of Research Interest publication, which sets out the key areas in which the DfE welcomes evidence from the research community (Department for Education, United Kingdom, 2024[31]).

Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education 2023; Interview conducted on Teams, June 2024.

Education policy landscape mapping in the UK four nations

There is a complex ecosystem of activities in education policy making, influencing how evidence is used outside of government, yet an overview of this ecosystem is missing. The rationale for the mapping is that both the policy contexts and the actors determine how evidence is taken up. As education is a devolved competency in the United Kingdom, these elements differ between its four nations.

The mapping looks at the underlying structure of knowledge mobilisation in the four devolved education systems. It seeks to answer the following questions:

- What are the underpinning structural elements in each context that make a difference to how research reaches practitioners and policy makers, and the uses to which research is put?
- How do contextual factors and policy levers drive different forms of knowledge mobilisation and research engagement in each of the four UK nations?

This activity is supported by a wider mapping of the United Kingdom landscape of independent, non-governmental organisations (such as charities and think tanks) that conduct research and produce evidence and knowledge relevant to education policy. The different projects in the programme are also engaged in the stakeholder mapping.

Methodology

The mapping activity has involved a desk-based review of the relevant literature and policy documents in the different nations. Documents that were examined include the Areas of Research Interest documents that are published by the DfE in England; in Scotland, the Scottish Government's School Research Plan; in Wales, the National Strategy for Education, Research and Inquiry. Subsequently, interviews were held with key stakeholders across the UK nations to gain their perspectives on the strengths and weaknesses of the approaches adopted.

Emerging findings on structural elements

System characteristics that make a difference to knowledge mobilisation in each of the UK devolved education systems include:

- the ways in which schools are organised locally and how responsibilities for their oversight are shared;
- the processes through which curriculum and assessment arrangements develop over time;
- the role that school inspection and performance data play in system monitoring and prompting system change.

These different structures and processes affect the terms on which researchers, policy makers and practitioners interact. Some devolved education systems place more emphasis on deeper collaboration between these parties than others and organise accordingly. These are dynamic systems that create a sense of knowledge needs and gaps, as well as incentives to move knowledge about. England stands out for its high levels of government control coupled with a market economy in knowledge mobilisation in which different actors are encouraged to compete for market share.

Regardless of the precise arrangements adopted, each system raises questions about where research fits in. Is the function of research to generate new knowledge, be more active in knowledge mobilisation, or become more engaged in knowledge exchange?

Emerging findings on drivers of research engagement

While the shared rationale for fostering research engagement is to improve system functioning in each devolved education system, the policy levers and policy spaces that encourage this vary. In a simplified model, knowledge mobilisation can operate in two directions: using *push mechanisms* to disseminate knowledge to users or using *pull mechanisms* that link researchers, practitioners and policy makers in dialogic ways that facilitate users making use of research that is relevant to them. The initial findings show that the policy culture and differences in the policy levers in the four nations of the United Kingdom influence how research evidence is taken up and whether push or pull mechanisms are more common:

- In England, the research that gets through to practitioners is strongly influenced by a combination of its "What Works" agenda and policy levers that encourage research use as part of its high-stakes accountability system. These are primarily based on push principles. The most used research is what is featured in the EEF Teaching and Learning Toolkit, which focuses on RCTs and meta-analyses of interventions.
- In Scotland, there is more emphasis on pull mechanisms established through knowledge exchange in different fora. The national strategy calls for cross-sector collaboration in "identifying joint priorities and shared evidence needs; synergising and aligning research agendas; the co-design and co-delivery of research and evaluation; and sharing learning" (Scottish Government, 2023, p. 9[32]). This leads to a wider range of research entering the system and an awareness of the different audiences it can inform.

- In Wales, as part of the new Curriculum for Wales, teachers are encouraged to work with the research community to design and implement a curriculum that meets their learners' needs. The government actively supports locally-based partnerships between schools and higher education institutions to help achieve this objective. This policy environment creates room for both knowledge push and knowledge pull.

Challenges and limitations

There has been much written about the influence of the policy context on evidence uptake (see e.g. (Ehren, 2019[33]; Walker et al., 2020[34]; Greany and Higham, 2018[35])). Given this, the challenge for this programme is to move beyond descriptive analyses and propose more varied processes of knowledge mobilisation and knowledge exchange that can work practically and constructively within different policy contexts, and with the unique constellation of actors that are present in that system. This is particularly challenging for projects whose implementation plans extend across different policy or political cultures. A finding from the ESRC Education Research Programme is that better understanding of how to co-ordinate across different contexts despite policy differences depends on knowledge exchange strategies that bring researchers and local policymakers into productive conversation early on.

A specific challenge for the programme has been navigating the planning of impact generation within a traditional funding structure. The original funding arrangement required the implementers to plan for impact at the beginning of the projects. However, such an early impact plan may struggle to take into account contextual drivers and barriers that are as yet unfamiliar and also liable to change. The implementers have expressed to the funder that planning for impact through knowledge exchange throughout the project cycle would be more effective and may require more flexible funding arrangements.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

Ultimately, understanding the influence of different policy cultures and contexts in a politically diverse country like the United Kingdom will help to illuminate how knowledge mobilisation strategies can be tailored to such different contexts.

Similar groundwork can be beneficial in the initial planning phases of knowledge mobilisation initiatives in any context to ensure that they are appropriate to the context and effectively use the levers available. This can involve a regularly updated mapping at the level of the broader policy system (e.g. regional or national level) of:

- structural elements, such as institutions and their roles;
- contextual drivers and policy levers of research engagement, as well as barriers.

This can be conducted (or co-ordinated) by a central intermediary in the system, such as a research institution or formal intermediary. The central mapping could then be examined and perhaps further expanded for smaller local contexts in which intermediaries operate.

Conclusion

This chapter examined the international landscape of knowledge mobilisation activities carried out by different types of organisations across OECD education systems. While many types of organisations engage in numerous activities to support the use of research in policy or practice, there are also clear gaps. Very little capacity building seems to be available for researchers and intermediary actors to develop brokerage skills. Certain types of organisations do not systematically carry out activities that would suit their profile (e.g. develop teachers' research use skills in initial teacher education), while others conduct

activities that may potentially (although not necessarily) carry risks to quality evidence use (e.g. education consulting firms' wide-ranging involvement).

Importantly, these data call for an understanding of how knowledge mobilisation can be better co-ordinated at the wider system level. Is the field characterised by duplicative efforts (e.g. many evidence repositories exist) or are these complementary? In either case, mapping these efforts and understanding how they are similar or different – e.g. what type of evidence do they aim to mobilise, for which target audiences, and how – would help to create a more efficient knowledge mobilisation system. To this end, the heatmap presented in this chapter offers a tool that education systems can adapt and use in their own contexts. Transparency of intermediary functions and communication among these organisations could save costs and help target users, such as policy makers and practitioners, to navigate the myriad of knowledge mobilisation initiatives and platforms. Knowledge sharing and peer learning among intermediaries could contribute to improving their efforts.

Reflection questions and activities

Co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level

What do you think the optimal distribution of activities would be among different types of organisations in your system?

Activity: With a team in your organisation, identify five actors that already play a key role in knowledge mobilisation in your system and five others that are not yet active but you think should be. Draw a map of these organisations outlining their mission, the nature of their connections and their existing knowledge mobilisation activities.

Consider the following factors:

- unique skills and capacity of the different organisations/actors from the perspective of knowledge mobilisation;
- level of autonomy and independence from government;
- the nature of existing relationships among organisations: strength of relationship, power relations and hierarchies, dependencies and accountability, competition and collaboration;
- any other important factors you can think of.

Discuss strengths and weaknesses in the map you drew up: What works well? What could be improved and how? Which actor(s) should play a role in co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation in your system?

Improving knowledge mobilisation activities

- What other types of knowledge mobilisation activities (not captured in this intermediaries' survey) does your organisation or system engage in?
- Which combinations of activities are common in your system? How would you characterise your system in relation to Table 3.3?
- How effective do you think these activities are? What evidence is there on their effectiveness and what is missing?
- Which of the activities should be scaled up and which ones should be scaled down? How would you go about that?

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Annex 3.A. Knowledge mobilisation activities and their factor analysis

Annex Table 3.A.1. List of knowledge mobilisation activities in the intermediaries' survey

Type of activity	Activity
To what extent does your organisation generate, synthesise and communicate research products in the following ways?	
Evidence generation	Conducting primary research (e.g. generation of original data for own analysis)
	Conducting secondary research (e.g. analysing existing datasets, carrying out literature reviews)
	Conducting systematic reviews or meta-analyses
	Conducting specific intervention/programme evaluations (e.g. randomised control trials)
	Commissioning and funding research (e.g. through call for tender, grants)
Evidence dissemination	Producing, curating and maintaining an evidence repository
	Disseminating research in user-friendly formats (e.g. research briefs, blogs)
	Establishing and maintaining communication channels for disseminating research (e.g. websites, social media, events)
To what extent does your organisation foster relationships and build capacity among practitioners, policy makers and researchers to reinforce research use in the following ways?	
Collaboration and partnerships	Mapping potential research users or mobilisers (e.g. researchers, policy makers, practitioners, stakeholders)
	Facilitating connections and/or collaboration among actors with the aim of increasing research use
	Building partnerships with different actors to facilitate research use
Capacity building	Offering training for practitioners or policy makers to help them use research (e.g. to access, interpret and apply research findings)
	Offering training for researchers (e.g. how to communicate research for policy/practice)
	Offering training for intermediaries to develop brokerage skills (e.g. mapping users' needs, synthesising evidence)
	Building leadership capacity to support research use (e.g. training, coaching, mentoring for leaders in policy organisations and schools)

Type of activity	Activity
To what extent does your organisation support other organisations in reinforcing research use in the following ways?	
Organisational support	Working directly with policy organisation(s) (e.g. ministries) or schools to support them in developing infrastructure, processes and cultural changes (e.g. designing a theory of change or programmes/interventions to encourage research use)
	Co-designing or directly supporting the development and/or implementation of policies in policy organisations/ practices in schools (e.g. supporting innovation processes with research; structuring research-informed conversations; supporting a rigorous evaluation of the new policy/practice)
Local, regional or national-level support	Evaluating knowledge mobilisation/research use initiatives in terms of their effectiveness/impact
	Scaling up (e.g. to other schools) and/or supporting the sustainability of effective knowledge mobilisation/research use initiatives (e.g. through stable funding)
	Co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level across different actors (e.g. through a network/forum of intermediaries; strategic distribution of roles)
	Creating and/or sustaining system-level infrastructure, processes or incentives for knowledge mobilisation (e.g. establishing an intermediary organisation/unit; incorporating research use in accountability and improvement processes; academic incentives)

Annex Table 3.A.2. Factor loadings

	Factor 1	Factor 2	Factor 3	Factor 4
Conducting primary research	0.21	-0.09	0.64	-0.18
Conducting secondary research	-0.18	0.04	0.76	0.06
Conducting systematic reviews or meta-analyses	0.22	-0.12	0.58	0.08
Conducting intervention/programme evaluations	0.38	-0.07	0.37	-0.03
Commissioning and funding research	-0.17	-0.07	0.01	0.74
Producing, curating and maintaining an evidence repository	0.15	-0.05	0.32	0.34
Disseminating research in user-friendly formats	-0.15	0.33	0.45	0.05
Establishing and maintaining communication channels for disseminating research	-0.22	0.49	0.36	0.03
Mapping research users or mobilisers	0.14	0.49	0.02	0.12
Facilitating connections/collaboration among actors to increase research use	0.14	0.87	-0.11	-0.08
Building partnerships with actors to facilitate research use	0.20	0.81	-0.05	-0.17
Training practitioners or policy makers to help them use research	0.82	0.13	0.05	-0.34
Training researchers (e.g. to communicate research)	0.60	0.04	0.04	-0.08
Training intermediaries to develop brokerage skills	0.77	-0.13	0.00	0.00
Building leadership capacity to support research use	0.82	-0.03	-0.02	-0.11
Directly supporting policy organisations/schools in developing infrastructure, processes and cultural changes	0.54	0.18	-0.01	0.02
Directly supporting the development/implementation of policies in policy organisations/practices in schools with research	0.51	0.16	0.16	-0.04
Evaluating knowledge mobilisation initiatives	0.51	0.02	-0.03	0.30
Supporting the scaling/sustainability of effective knowledge mobilisation initiatives	0.53	0.01	-0.08	0.40
Co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level	0.47	0.23	-0.11	0.25
Creating/sustaining system-level infrastructure, processes or incentives for knowledge mobilisation	0.47	0.09	-0.11	0.36

Notes: The exploratory factor analysis was conducted with Promax rotation and maximum likelihood method. The four-factor model was selected based on Eigen values greater than 1.

Notes

[1] Profiles were determined based on exploratory factor analysis conducted with the Factor Analyzer package of Python, using promax rotation and maximum likelihood method. (https://pypi.org/project/factor-analyzer/). Eigen values and factor loadings are provided in Annex Table 3.A.2.

[2] *Ontwikkelkracht* means “development power”, which refers to the fact that the programme is developing a major infrastructure

4 Mind the gap: Comparing perspectives of ministries and intermediaries

José Manuel Torres, OECD

Melissa Mouthaan, OECD

This chapter examines the differing perspectives of ministries of education and knowledge intermediaries regarding research use in education policy and practice within their systems. It focuses specifically on the mechanisms supporting quality research use and on the barriers to such research use, as well as available resources. The chapter first presents and compares the results from two OECD surveys, followed by an in-depth analysis and discussion of the findings. It also features two case studies on knowledge mobilisation: i) a dialogue platform in Japan where stakeholders can identify issues and bridge misunderstandings towards building a common ground; and ii) how the challenge of ensuring uptake of national-level knowledge mobilisation initiatives is being met in the United States by involving state-level intermediaries. The chapter concludes with questions for reflection and activities to encourage further thinking and discussion on knowledge mobilisation.

Key messages

Policy makers and intermediaries often occupy distinct roles in education systems and in knowledge mobilisation initiatives, and comparing their perspectives can reveal misalignments and potential areas for collaboration. Drawing on data from two OECD surveys, this chapter presents the perspectives of these actors on the mechanisms supporting quality research use, and on the barriers to such research use.

The comparative data and analysis in this chapter suggest the following:

- There is a notable perception gap between intermediaries and ministries concerning both mechanisms to facilitate research use and barriers. This may be due to differences in perspectives and relative positions in the education landscape, or due to mechanisms initiated by policy makers not being well communicated to other actors "downstream", or to a perception among intermediaries that the mechanisms that exist are insufficient or ineffective.
- Intermediaries often perceive there to be fewer mechanisms to support and promote research use among practitioners than ministries do, highlighting potential gaps in awareness of or satisfaction with these mechanisms.
- A key point of diverging opinion is the adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation in practice, with intermediaries across respondent systems reporting that resources are insufficient – an opinion not altogether shared by ministries.
- While some perception differences may be natural or unproblematic, in many instances a shared understanding of mechanisms and barriers through better communication and collaboration could help to enhance research use in educational policy and practice.

Introduction

Miles' Law states: "where you stand depends on where you sit" (Miles, 1978[1]). Even when two groups are part of the same system, their perceptions and realities may differ significantly on the same subject. This divergence is not by definition a challenge when it comes to research use in policy and practice – indeed, having multiple perspectives can enrich decision-making and lead to a more holistic understanding of complex issues. However, it may also signal a deeper, underlying misalignment within the system.

This chapter explores the different perspectives of ministries of education and knowledge intermediaries on the mechanisms for supporting quality research use in education policy and practice in their systems, and the barriers preventing it. The perspectives of researchers and policy makers are well represented in research on knowledge mobilisation, both in education and other policy fields (see Chapter 2). This body of literature has shown how the gaps between these communities have limited the policy impact of research (Pino-Yancovic et al., 2023[2]; Brown, 2014[3]; Bandola-Gill, 2019[4]). To tackle the research-policy gap, some systems have started to implement interventions aimed at promoting researchers' understanding of the policy context, and policy makers' research literacy (OECD, 2023[5]; OECD, 2024[6]).

In contrast, fewer studies have collected empirical data on the perspectives of individuals or organisations that act as intermediaries regarding knowledge mobilisation in education policy or practice. Some exceptions included in a 2024 systematic review (Oliver et al., forthcoming[7]) are studies by Vanderlinde and van Braak (2010[8]), Bélanger and Dulude (2021[9]) and Bushouse and Mosley (2018[10]), which explore intermediary perspectives in the Flemish, Canadian and US contexts. These studies highlight that intermediaries act on their perceptions to influence the education landscape. Given the importance of bridging the research-policy and research-practice gaps, understanding the perspectives of all actors within the system – including intermediaries – is essential to supporting more coherent, effective knowledge mobilisation efforts.

The analysis in this chapter contributes to this literature. It draws on data from two OECD surveys (see Box 4.1 and Chapter 1) to explore and compare the perspectives of ministries and intermediaries on the use of research in education policy and practice contexts.

Box 4.1. The OECD surveys on knowledge mobilisation

The Policy Survey

The 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey (OECD, 2022[11]), collected data from 37 ministries and departments of education in 29 countries[1] to map the knowledge mobilisation mechanisms, actors and challenges across education systems (henceforth, the "policy survey"). Responses were collected from ministries of education[2] at the national or sub-national level – e.g. state, province, canton.

The Intermediaries' Survey

The 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (see Chapter 1) collected data about the knowledge mobilisation activities of 288 intermediary organisations in 34 countries to better understand how they are supporting research engagement (henceforth, the "intermediaries' survey").

This chapter begins by outlining the methodology used to compare the results from both surveys, followed by an analysis of data comparing the responses of ministries of education and knowledge intermediaries, and a discussion of the findings. The chapter then showcases two case studies. The first is set in Japan, in a context where the centralised nature of education decision making can lead to significant differences in perspective. It shows how one intermediary addresses this challenge by setting up a stakeholder

dialogue platform where disagreements and perspectives are discussed using evidence. The second is set in the United States, a federal and decentralised education system that leans heavily on regional and local intermediaries to promote evidence use, supporting their activities through federal grants. The chapter concludes with some questions for contemplation and activities to encourage further discussion.

Comparing the perspectives of policy makers and intermediaries

To enable meaningful comparisons between the two surveys, certain questions were intentionally repeated across them to directly examine responses of ministries and intermediaries on key issues. To analyse these responses side by side, we developed a methodology that accounts for variations in respondent numbers and perspective across systems (see Box 4.2). This approach provides a structured framework to identify similarities and discrepancies between these groups, offering valuable insights into their differing perspectives on research use.

Box 4.2. The comparative methodology for analysis of the two survey results

The methodology: The majority view

To ensure a valid comparison, only education systems that had responses from both their ministry and at least one knowledge intermediary were considered, reducing the sample to 22 systems[3], represented by 176 organisations. Due the variability in the number of intermediary respondents (e.g. 15 in Chile and the Flemish Community of Belgium, versus one in Slovenia), responses within a single system were aggregated based on the majority view. Specifically, the ministry's response was compared to the response of ***the majority (more than half) of the intermediary organisations in each country***. For instance, if six out of ten Lithuanian intermediaries reported a certain mechanism, the aggregated response considered that Lithuanian intermediaries overall reported that mechanism. This majority rule reflects the dominant perspective among intermediary respondents, while maintaining comparability with the singular ministry viewpoint.

The statistical significance

Given the nature of the data (proportions) and the small sample size, Mann-Whitney U tests were applied to determine whether the difference between the responses of ministries and intermediaries were statistically significant or not. This significance is indicated in the notes of each figure included in the chapter.

Notes on limitations

Numerically and conceptually, comparing the responses from a country's ministry of education to the policy survey with responses from the same country's knowledge intermediaries to the intermediaries' survey presents some challenges.

First, intermediary organisations often represent a variety of experiences, roles and interactions with research in practice, whereas a ministry's response typically reflects a singular, albeit collective, viewpoint. This difference may create variability in the intermediary responses that a single ministry viewpoint cannot capture, resulting in richer data on the intermediary side and complicating direct comparisons.

Second, the surveys were conducted at different times (2021 and 2023 respectively), meaning that the recorded perceptions of ministries and intermediaries are not entirely temporally aligned. Any major policy changes or reforms between the two surveys could affect these comparisons. As such, the

findings should be interpreted with caution, particularly where systems have undergone substantial reform during this interval.

Third, aggregating intermediary responses based on the majority perspective may overlook significant minority views, which could provide insights into more diverse or less dominant perspectives on research use mechanisms. For instance, the majority perspective may represent the perspective of a single type of organisation and be unrepresentative of other types of organisations present in the system.

Fourth, there may be differences in how key concepts are understood and interpreted by respondents across different organisations. Although the first survey defined certain terms and the second survey included a glossary of key concepts, variations in interpretation may still have influenced responses.

Finally, the analysis still lacks the perspective of actors deeply rooted in the practice context of education research, such as teachers and school leaders. While some teacher unions responded to the second survey, practitioners' direct insights remain under-represented.

Questions that appeared identically in both surveys focused on:

- the presence of mechanisms that facilitate the use of research in education policy and practice;
- the presence of barriers that hinder the use of research in education policy and practice;
- the resources allocated to knowledge mobilisation in education policy and practice;
- respondents' satisfaction with some characteristics of education research; and
- respondents' satisfaction with some aspects of education research use.

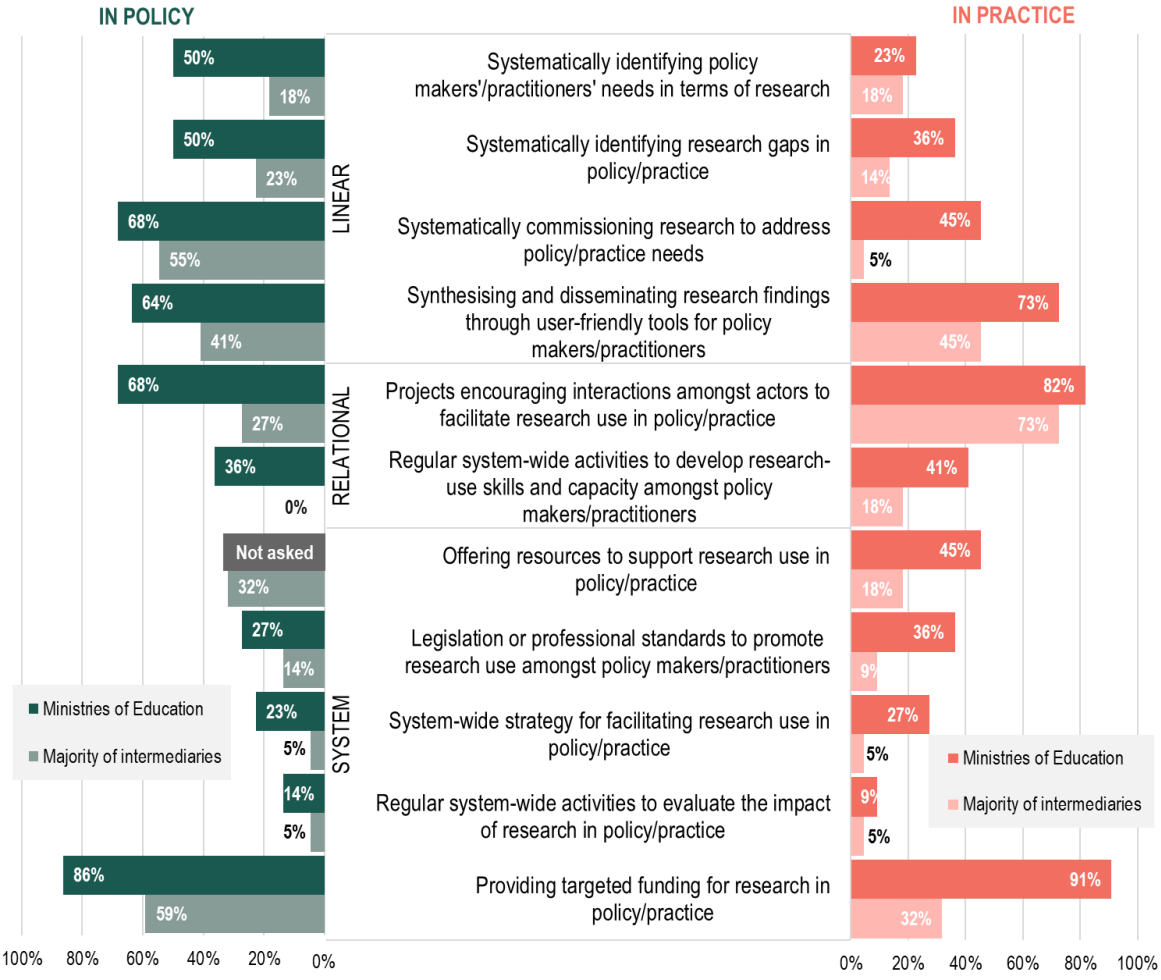
In the interest of scope, this chapter's analysis is focused on comparing responses to the first three topics.

"Super mechanisms" facilitating research use

The mechanisms and barriers to the use of research that ministries and intermediaries reported were presented in an earlier OECD report in a chapter entitled "Facilitating research use: Scary Barriers (and Super Mechanisms)" (see Torres (2022[12]) in OECD (2022[11])). Therein, mechanisms and barriers were defined as the processes or means that either enable or hinder, respectively, the use of evidence in policy making and practice. These mechanisms and barriers were categorised by drawing on the conceptual framework characterising research-policy-practice links proposed by Best and Holmes (2010[13]): linear, relational and system. The same categorisation is used here.

The comparative data presented here show that ministries tend to report mechanisms that facilitate the use of research in both policy and practice as being present more often than intermediaries do (see Figure 4.1).

Figure 4.1. Mechanisms facilitating research use in policy and practice



Notes: The dark-coloured bars represent the percentage of ministries of education (within a pool of 22 systems) that reported a given mechanism. The light-coloured bars indicate the percentage of systems (within the same pool of 22 systems) in which the majority (more than half) of intermediaries reported a given mechanism. Green bars represent mechanisms in policy, whereas red bars represent mechanisms in practice. A Mann-Whitney U test proved that the difference between the responses of ministries and intermediaries was statistically significant for mechanisms in both policy (p value = 0.033) and practice (p value = 0.015).
Source: OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey data, 2021, and OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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There is a significant perception gap on the presence of relational mechanisms to facilitate research use in policy

With regards to research use in policy, two relational mechanisms – projects encouraging interactions and capacity-building activities – illustrate a notable perception gap between ministries and intermediaries. Capacity-building activities are reported less frequently than interaction-focused projects, particularly by intermediaries. In fact, none of the selected countries had a majority of intermediaries reporting regular activities to support the development of research-use skills in policy. This is significant because research indicates that facilitating interaction alone is insufficient to improve the use of research; to be truly effective, such efforts should be paired with capacity-building activities (Kislov et al., 2014[14]; Campbell et al., 2017[15]).

It is encouraging to note that in all but one system where ministries reported the presence of capacity-building activities for policy makers, they also reported activities that foster interactions between policy makers and researchers. This alignment suggests that efforts to improve skills and capacity to use research may be integrated in some of the projects that generate interaction.

There are differing views on the adequacy of available funding and commissioned research to facilitate research use in practice

A notable discrepancy exists in the perceptions regarding whether research is being commissioned to address practice needs, especially when compared to the smaller gap observed in "identifying practitioners' needs". However, this smaller gap in the latter is due to the fact that most ministries and intermediaries did not report systematic activities for identifying these needs. This disparity suggests that ministries may be commissioning research based on needs that have not been fully identified through systematic processes, potentially resulting in a mismatch between commissioned research and the actual requirements of school practitioners. Additionally, while ministries may believe that commissioned research is adequately aligned with practice needs, intermediaries could view these efforts as insufficient, either due to a perceived lack of funding or because their perspectives may not carry sufficient weight in shaping research agendas. This disconnect indicates potential issues in how effectively ministries and intermediaries co-ordinate the identification and prioritisation of practice needs, suggesting that these mechanisms may not be working as intended.

There is a notable gap between the perceptions of ministries and intermediaries regarding the availability of funding. This suggests that ministries and intermediaries have differing views on the adequacy and allocation of current funding for research use in practice. Alternatively, intermediaries may not have a good overview of the funding schemes that may be available.

There is relative consensus among actors that system-wide mechanisms are generally lacking

Beyond funding mechanisms, both ministries and intermediaries report the existence of system-wide mechanisms far less frequently than linear and relational ones, indicating a shared view on their limited presence in educational systems. In the rare cases where ministries consider these mechanisms to be present in their systems, intermediaries are often unaware of their existence. The fact that such mechanisms are reported to be missing is particularly concerning, as system-wide mechanisms are intended to target and impact the entire educational system.

For instance, "system-wide activities to evaluate the impact of research" was one of the least frequently reported mechanisms by both groups. This highlights the lack of evaluation of research use initiatives, something that has already been flagged in other studies ((Golden, 2020[16]; Oliver et al., 2022[17]); see also Chapter 2). The lack of system-wide efforts to assess the broader impact of research on educational practice points to a critical gap in many systems' ability to learn from and improve their own initiatives. The US federal education system addresses this gap on system-wide mechanisms through structured initiatives like the Regional Educational Laboratories (RELs) and Comprehensive Centers (CCs), which are designed to strengthen evidence use across diverse regions. These programmes demonstrate the importance of co-ordinated, system-wide approaches to overcome structural barriers and ensure that research benefits the entire education system (see US case study in this chapter).

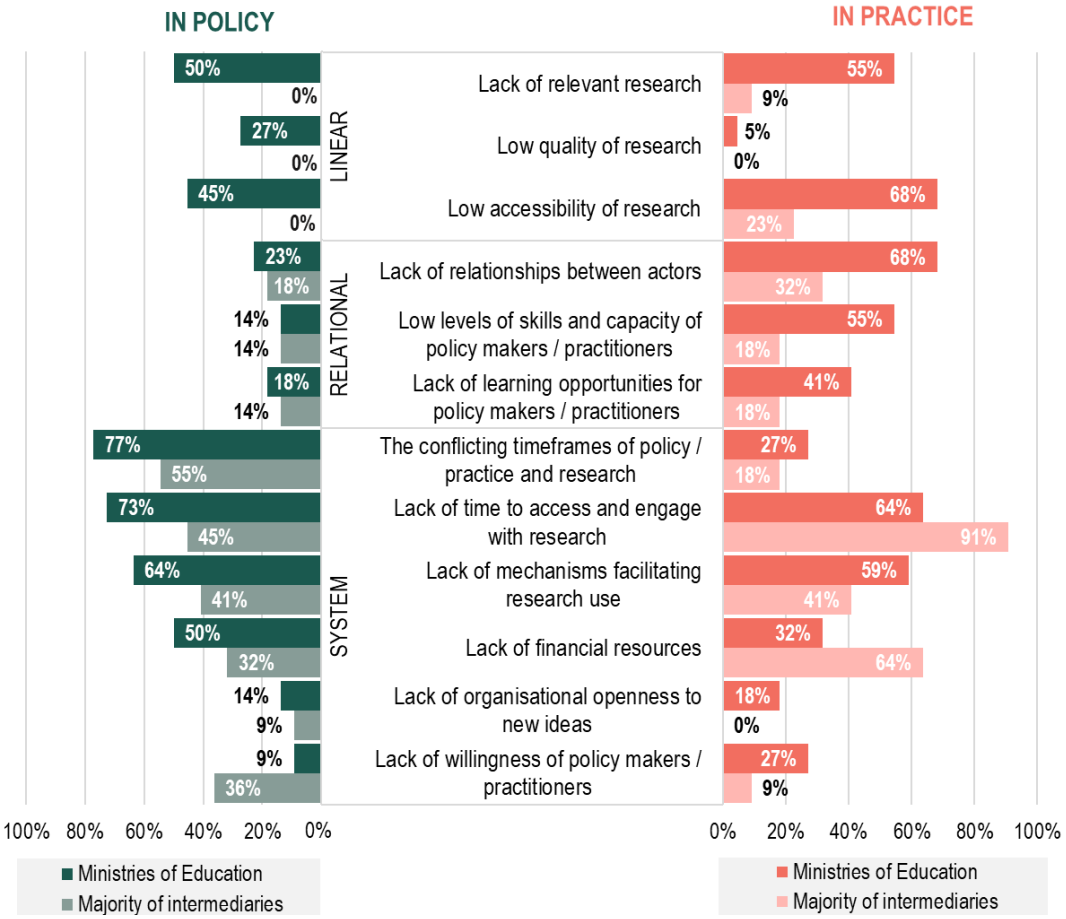
"Scary barriers" to research use

At the education system level, ministries tend to report more barriers to the use of research in practice than do intermediaries, where the difference is statistically significant. This is not the case in policy, where the difference is not significant (see Figure 4.2).

Ministries are more concerned by issues of accessibility and relevance of research than intermediaries

The most significant perception gaps regarding barriers to knowledge mobilisation centre on the same linear factors in both policy and practice contexts: the lack of relevant research and its low accessibility (see Figure 4.2). Whereas ministries in several systems often report these issues as barriers, intermediaries, who are typically more involved in producing and disseminating research, do not share this view. In fact, the majority of intermediaries in the pool of 22 examined systems do not perceive relevance and accessibility as barriers to the use of research in practice, constituting the most substantial divergence between the perspectives of ministries and intermediaries in this analysis. This is even more noticeable in policy, where the share of intermediaries reporting these barriers remained a minority in all participating systems.

Figure 4.2. Barriers to research use in policy and practice



Notes: The dark-coloured bars represent the percentage of ministries of education (within a pool of 22 systems) that reported each barrier. The light-coloured bars indicate the percentage of systems (within the same pool of 22 systems) in which the majority (more than half) of intermediaries reported each barrier. Green bars represent barriers in policy, whereas red bars represent barriers in practice. A Mann-Whitney U test proved that the difference between the responses of ministries and intermediaries was not statistically significant for barriers in policy (p value = 00.077) nor in practice (p value = 0.068). Both ministries and intermediaries were asked to report a maximum of six barriers, with ministries asked to rank them and intermediaries to just report them.

Source: OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey data, 2021, and OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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This raises important questions about how each group perceives and values research relevance and accessibility. It is possible that differing perspectives arise from the different roles ministries and intermediaries play in the knowledge mobilisation process. Intermediaries are often involved in producing and brokering research, which may explain their awareness of research. Given that it is their role to disseminate research, they may overestimate the practical utility of their outputs and/or activities. Ministries, on the other hand, may see themselves primarily as consumers of research rather than active participants in the research production process. In this role, they may struggle to find research they deem relevant, may be unaware of it, or may have different criteria for judging relevance and accessibility. Further research could determine whether the reported gaps arise from differing roles, communication breakdowns or structural challenges.

There is general agreement on persistent systemic issues such as lack of time to use research in policy

Beyond the high levels of disagreement regarding the accessibility and relevance of research, ministries and intermediaries do show alignment in some areas. This is particularly evident with regards to the use of research in policy, where barriers reported by both groups tend to cluster around system-level challenges. The most frequently mentioned obstacles are the conflicting timeframes between research and policy processes, the lack of time to access and engage with research, and the absence of mechanisms facilitating research use. These shared perceptions suggest that both ministries and intermediaries recognise the critical importance of these systemic issues. Ideally, this common ground would provide a strong foundation for collaborative efforts to develop solutions and implement more effective strategies to overcome these barriers.

Ministries consider that relational factors impeding research use are more problematic in practice than in policy settings

Relational aspects such as a lack of relationships between actors or a lack of skills to use research were not considered important barriers to the use of research in policy by either ministries or intermediaries. The relative absence of concern regarding these factors in the policy sphere may reflect that relationships and opportunities to learn between researchers, some intermediaries and policy communities are already fairly developed. For example, many systems have formalised initiatives in place for exchanges between research-policy communities, such as secondments and policy fellowships (OECD, 2023[5]; OECD, 2024[6]).

This represents a noticeable contrast with practice settings, where ministries in particular tend to highlight relational factors as barriers preventing the effective use of research by practitioners. Ministries are more than twice as likely as intermediaries to report the lack of relationships between actors in the practice context as a barrier. However, it is still notable that in one-third of systems, a majority of intermediaries also report this as a barrier, despite more than 70% of systems having the majority of intermediaries report fostering initiatives that encourage interaction among actors (see Figure 4.1). This raises the question of whether all these initiatives are indeed fostering the kind of relationships that have proven to be the most valuable: sustainable and collaborative (Farrell et al., 2021[18]). Overall, the disparity in perspectives might also suggest that intermediaries may be participating in informal or formal practitioner networks whose activities and working practices are less visible to ministries. For instance, research-practice partnerships have been spreading in many systems (e.g. the United States, Canada, Norway, Sweden) but many of these might be bottom-up initiatives, not necessarily known to ministries (Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[19]).

Intermediaries remain sceptical that policy makers are truly willing to engage with research

One barrier that stands out is the "lack of willingness of policy makers" to use research, which is reported far more frequently by intermediaries than by ministries. In fact, the number of systems with a majority of intermediaries highlighting this issue is four times greater than those with ministries reporting it. This suggests that intermediaries may hold a more critical view of policy makers' priorities and their commitment to research-informed decision making. It may reflect a perception that policy makers' use of research remains strategic and ad-hoc – e.g. cherry-picking research to support pre-existing views or political agendas – rather than a willingness to use research evidence to change established practices or to fundamentally reassess education policies.

However, intermediaries' scepticism may also reflect a lack of familiarity with the context in which policy makers work. It is becoming increasingly recognised that knowledge derived from research evidence must compete with other forms of knowledge, such as professional knowledge, in the process of evidence-informed policy making. This process of combining forms of knowledge and related dynamics may, however, remain obscure to intermediary actors working outside of the policy environment.

Regarding practice, ministries take a broad view of challenges, while intermediaries' concerns focus on time and resources

On an aggregated level, the barriers most frequently reported by intermediaries are lack of time and lack of financial resources – the only barriers where more than half of systems had a majority of intermediaries reporting them – whereas participating ministries typically reported a broader spread of barriers. For example, six barriers were reported by more than half of the ministries. This broader range of barriers reported by ministries may indicate a more systemic view, considering multiple points of friction.

In general, ministries reported each barrier in practice more frequently than intermediaries, with two exceptions. First, the majority of intermediaries reported a lack of time to access and engage with research in nine out of ten systems. This highlights how intermediaries, who often have closer ties to school systems or educational networks, are more likely to be confronted by the realities of the classroom environment and the operational demands that limit practitioners' time for research engagement. A second exception is the lack of financial resources, which was felt more keenly by intermediaries. Financial support, and the lack of it, appears to be a bigger concern for organisations with a stronger on-the-ground presence in schools and classrooms.

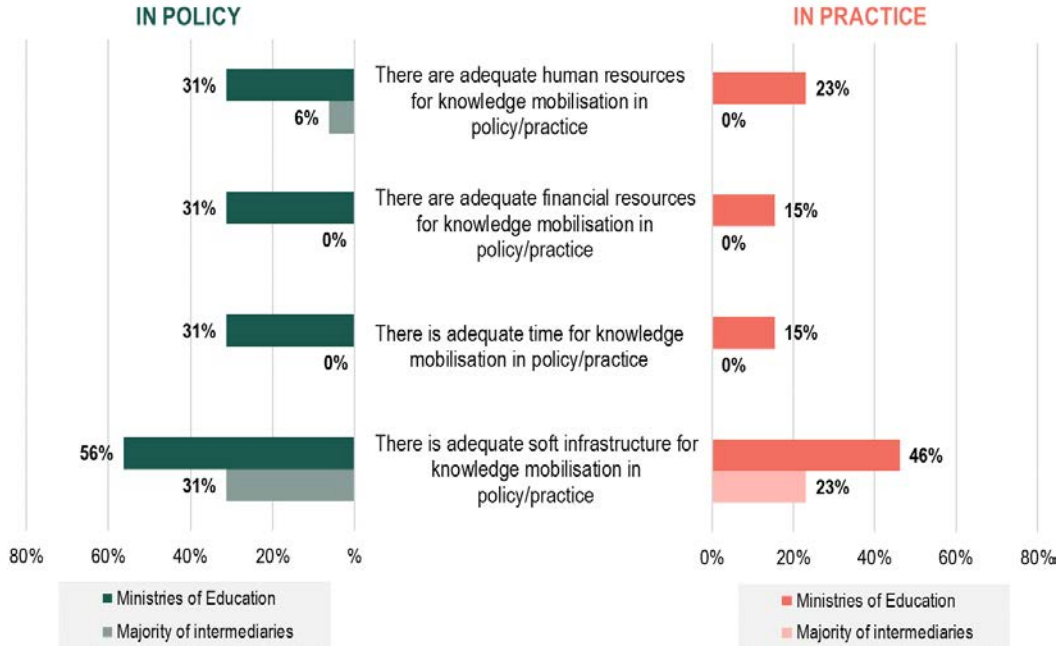
In both policy and practice contexts, intermediaries feel that resources to support research use are inadequate

One of the key points of diverging opinion is the adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation (see Figure 4.3). While only a minority of ministries agreed or strongly agreed that there are adequate human resources, time or financial support for knowledge mobilisation in practice, in none of these systems did a majority of intermediaries agree with their ministry that such resources are indeed adequate. Intermediaries may be better placed to observe the direct impact of a resource-constrained environment that they feel hinders effective research use in practice contexts.

A similar pattern is observed regarding the policy context, where ministries tend to be slightly more positive about resource adequacy than in practice. Again, intermediaries tend to not agree. In this case, ministries are arguably better placed to know if there is sufficient time, as well as human and financial resources, for knowledge mobilisation in policy.

Figure 4.3. Adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation

Level of agreement of ministries and intermediaries with the adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation



Notes: The dark-coloured bars represent the percentage of ministries of education (within a pool of 16 systems in policy, and 13 in practice) that agreed or strongly agreed with each of the statements. The light-coloured bars indicate the percentage of systems (within the same pool of systems) in which the majority (more than half) of intermediaries agreed or strongly agreed with each statement.
Source: OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey, 2021, and OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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These differences in resource perceptions may suggest that intermediaries – being more directly involved in implementation – may not see the tangible effects of allocated resources. This could result from several factors, including bureaucratic delays, inefficiencies in fund or resource distribution, or misalignment between policy intentions and actual resource allocation.

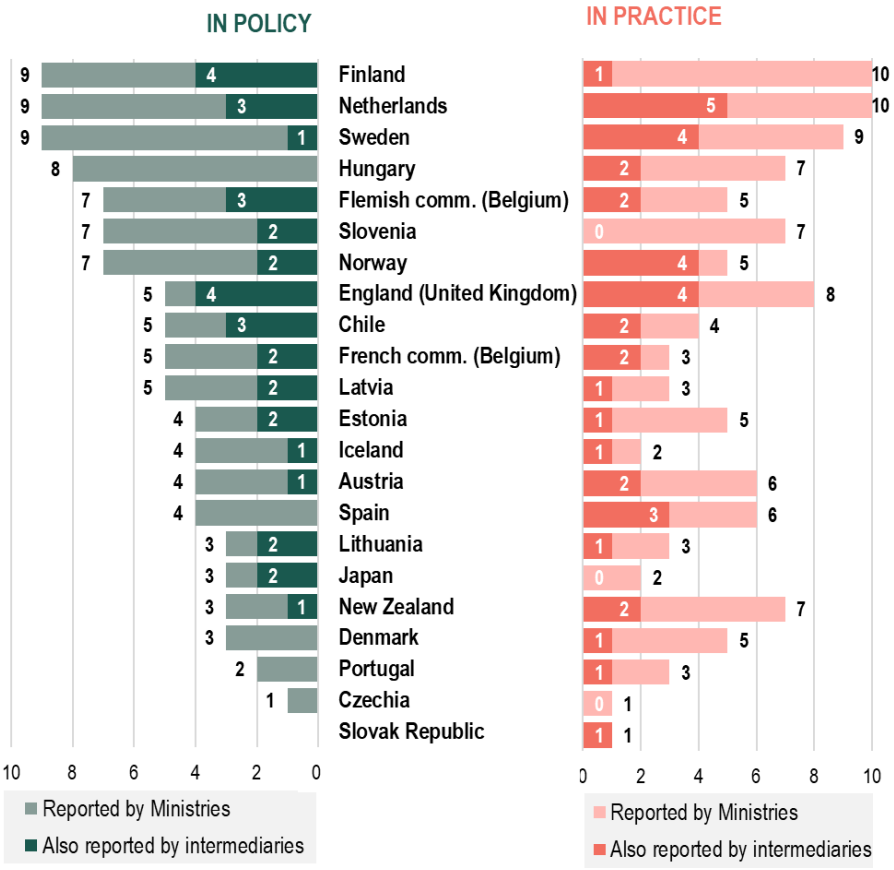
In-country comparisons on mechanisms: Agreement between ministries and intermediaries

Instances where the majority of intermediaries *within a country or system* agreed with their ministry of education on the existence of a mechanism to facilitate research use reveal wide disparity. Even when ministries reported the presence of a particular mechanism, the majority of intermediaries in the same system typically did not acknowledge it.

On average, only one-third of mechanisms reported by ministries were also reported by the majority of intermediaries in their education system (see Figure 4.4). Some countries/systems (e.g. United Kingdom, Chile) show higher-than-average intermediary agreement on mechanisms reported by their ministries. While the small intermediary sample sizes may distort country-level data, in general, higher levels of agreement may indicate better alignment between ministries and intermediaries in these countries, reflecting more effective stakeholder communication, implementation of mechanisms, and perhaps a more collaborative approach to practice and research. The “Evidence for Dialogue” programme launched and co-ordinated by the National Institute for School Teachers and Staff Development (NITS) is an example of

an initiative in Japan that is intended to foster engagement and interaction between stakeholders and create more common ground between communities (see Japan case study in this chapter).

Figure 4.4. Agreement between ministries and intermediaries on mechanisms in policy and practice, by country/system



Note: The light-coloured bars represent the number of mechanisms reported by ministries of education (within a pool of 22 systems). The dark-coloured bars represent the number of mechanisms reported by ministries of education (within a pool of 22 systems) that were also acknowledged by the majority of intermediaries in that system. Green bars represent mechanisms in policy, whereas red bars represent mechanisms in practice. Countries are ranked in descending order based on the number of mechanisms reported by ministries of education in policy.

Source: OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey data, 2021, and OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/uq0jao

Analysing disagreement

While the analysis has shown instances where intermediaries and ministries are aligned in their views of barriers or mechanisms around research use, it has also highlighted several points of disagreement. Discrepancies in views between ministries and intermediaries suggest a fundamental disconnect in how mechanisms and barriers are perceived and reported at different levels and by different actors within OECD education systems. This misalignment could be attributed to several factors, discussed in the following sections.

Different standards on what is considered adequate

Ministries may consider a mechanism to be "in place" even when limited resources or minimal actions have been dedicated to it, whereas intermediaries may report that a mechanism does not exist when they do not view it as sufficient for meaningful impact. For instance, what the ministries see as a sufficient resource provision may be perceived by intermediaries as inadequate or ineffective in practice (see Box 4.3 for examples). Regarding barriers, a major point of divergence appears to be the recognition of whether or not the resources allocated at a system level are adequate and sufficient to achieve systematic, high-quality research use among practitioners. Intermediaries' responses send a strong signal that such resources are often insufficient – something that does not appear to be recognised by policy makers in their system. Recognising the main barriers that actors on the ground face when striving to support knowledge mobilisation can help to identify priority policy actions that would best address these barriers.

Box 4.3. Intermediaries' views on adequacy of mechanisms and resources

Example 1: Chilean NGO Educación 2020, a knowledge intermediary in Chile, mentioned significant financial challenges to evaluate research use initiatives, as funding is often available for either implementation or evaluation, but not both. Additionally, short-term funding limits the ability to demonstrate impact in quantitative terms, leaving qualitative data as the primary evidence of change (see the Chile case study in Chapter 5.)

Example 2: An intermediary organisation in the United States identifying as a think tank reflected on a misalignment in the US context, where mechanisms to fund research and support knowledge mobilisation appear to be present, but are not considered entirely effective:

> *"[The United States] is an unusual system because it has all the resources and capacity needed, but it is not applied in a systematic manner. Part of the problem is the federal system, but part of it is also a rather old-fashioned approach to knowledge mobilisation that is still primarily based on linear and, to some extent, relational models. [There is] very little systemic/deep activity, with the exception of [a few] very talented people working specifically in this area."*
>
> *– US intermediary, OECD 2023 intermediaries' survey response*

(see more on knowledge mobilisation in the United States in the case study below).

Source: OECD interview with Educación 2020, June 2024; OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education, 2023.

Different vantage points

Ministries often have a system-wide, strategic view of mechanisms and barriers, whereas intermediaries operate closer to the ground, dealing directly with the practical realities of implementing research in education practice settings. This may lead to a certain degree of cognitive dissonance as described by one expert (see quote below). As noted, this difference in vantage points is not necessarily problematic and can reflect that these actors perform different roles, and it may not be a function of all intermediaries to have an oversight of the whole system. The view of intermediaries might be limited to the local context, local schools or other educational actors that they work with. Intermediaries may therefore be less aware of mechanisms that exist elsewhere in the system but do not directly affect their day-to-day practices.

> ***This is a problem of cognitive dissonance: For the ministries, a small amount of resources invested is enough to say [the mechanism] exists, while intermediaries do not acknowledge this to be the case. Ministries think they do things better than they actually do.***
>
> *– Miquel Àngel Alegre, Project Manager at Bofill Foundation*

Communication gaps

The presence of certain mechanisms may not always be communicated effectively within the education system, leading to a lack of awareness among intermediaries and insufficient co-ordination (see quote below). Ministries may assume that intermediaries are informed about policies or strategies, but poor communication may hinder this. This gap suggests that even when formal policies are in place, they may not be well known or clearly communicated to all actors involved in the system.

> ***In a jazz band, everyone knows their role and follows a changing rhythm. Here, players are jamming loose notes, not forming a band.***
>
> *– Jonathan Sharples, Professorial Research Fellow at Education Endowment Foundation and University College London*

Power gaps

When it comes to funding intermediaries to carry out research and knowledge mobilisation, it is often ministries who provide the funds for such activities, as well as the funds for evaluating impact. As such, there can be a power imbalance between ministries and intermediaries. This leads intermediaries to experience difficulties when addressing issues such as inadequate resources, and may explain some of the more critical perspectives of intermediaries on knowledge mobilisation barriers in their systems. Generally, the power imbalance where intermediaries are often recipients of funds, and ministries the providers of funds, means that there is a strategic logic for intermediaries to strongly highlight resource inadequacy, as noted in the quote below.

> ***Organisations will never say that they have enough resources from the government. It's just not in the DNA of an ambitious organisation, and it can also be part of the negotiation strategy.***
>
> *– Tia Loukkola, Head of Innovation & Measuring Progress Division, OECD*

The following two case studies are set in education systems with very different governance structures: Japan is a highly centralised system, whereas the United States is very decentralised. Both of these types of systems present challenges to aligning actors' perceptions and activities related to knowledge mobilisation, and both demonstrate promising practices to do so.

Case Study 1: Dialogue platform to build common understanding – Japan

The National Institute for School Teachers and Staff Development (NITS) in Japan is a publicly funded organisation that provides continuous professional development and learning programmes for teachers and educational staff. NITS serves as a bridge between research and practice in education, leading innovative approaches to professional development practice and ensuring that the latest evidence and data from surveys and scientific studies are effectively disseminated and used to improve teaching quality across the country.

NITS and knowledge mobilisation

There are three main knowledge mobilisation activities NITS engages in.

Teachers' professional learning

One of the key knowledge mobilisation activities of NITS is the integration of research into professional learning programmes. NITS invites teachers and teacher administrators from various prefectures as secondees to work with researchers and teacher education professionals for extended periods, typically two to three years, during which they collaborate on creating and delivering professional development programmes informed by research. The seconded teachers then return to their prefecture's board of education and schools, and they are expected to share and implement these programmes and programme development practices, effectively mobilising research knowledge and approaches to research use at the grassroots level.

Linear dissemination of research

NITS uses a variety of communication channels to disseminate research findings, including publications, email newsletters and social media. Their biweekly newsletter reaches Boards of Education, school management and teachers. Researchers contribute to these newsletters by writing directly to practitioners and policy makers, fostering a direct line of communication between the research community and those involved in the day-to-day implementation of educational policies.

Generating networks

While establishing networks is not the primary mission of NITS, it has emerged as one of the most significant spill-over effects of their initiatives. By convening teachers from across Japan for professional development sessions, NITS facilitates the formation of professional networks, in which teachers often maintain contact through shared mailing lists or other means even after the sessions have ended, allowing them to continue exchanging ideas and learning from each other's experiences in different contexts. Many participants have cited this networking opportunity as one of the most valuable aspects of their involvement with NITS, as it provides them with access to a wider pool of knowledge and practices.

Enhancing research use in a hierarchical system

Japan's education system has often been described as highly centralised (OECD, 2012[20]). The Japanese system is marked by a top-down approach where the Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology (MEXT) develops and implements education policy, and decides on the distribution of public resources (OECD, 2018[21]). While there has been a strong move towards a policy of increased decentralisation and more local ownership (OECD, 2018[21]) in response to the 1998 report of the Central Council for Education (MEXT, 1998/9[22]) that promoted the devolution of authority, the educational agenda is still mostly determined through clear national direction. It is possible that this dynamic has implications for the open exchange of ideas and the application of research evidence, e.g. that it is difficult to challenge preconceptions or opinions that are embedded in and vertically promoted within the system.

In this context, one of the key ambitions of NITS is to foster a culture of collective agreement among educational stakeholders regarding the use of research evidence. In response to these perceived challenges, NITS launched the "Evidence for Dialogue" initiative.

The "Evidence for Dialogue" initiative

This initiative seeks to foster a paradigm shift around evidence use by promoting critical dialogue among diverse stakeholders including researchers, school board members, local authorities, teachers and school leaders. The initiative moves beyond traditional linear knowledge mobilisation models, promoting a culture where evidence is not merely presented as "what works" in education but serves as a platform to build common ground among stakeholders (of diverse interests and priorities). Through this platform,

stakeholders can identify issues and bridge misunderstandings in evidence-use practices to inform more effective educational policies and practices.

An example of the methodology involves gathering survey data from teachers to uncover factors influencing their professional learning needs and their understanding of teacher professionalism. The collected data form the common basis for a trilateral meeting involving the boards of education (local authorities), professional development providers and researchers to build a consensus around the issues to be addressed through professional development and teacher learning. Unlike traditional meetings wherein researchers present findings and solutions, these meetings focus on interpreting survey findings and co-creating solutions through dialogue. This collaborative process can extend beyond the school to engage the broader community.

Following the preliminary dialogue, which identifies additional research needs and potential changes to current practices, teachers are invited to join the discussion. Their delayed participation ensures the sensitive handling of data and information shared in initial meetings.

The preliminary dialogue lasts one day, with all expenses covered by NITS. However, if participants wish to continue, they share the costs. This co-payment system not only covers the expenses of data analysis, planning and logistics, but also encourages participants to commit to collaboration and mutual investment, which are essential for building a lasting and balanced partnership based on equality.

Challenges and limitations

Despite its innovative approach, the "Evidence for Dialogue" initiative faces several challenges. The first challenge concerns the **selection of research evidence.** Often, research is chosen based on its alignment with the current government policy rather than its quality or relevance. This politicisation of research can lead to the promotion of certain researchers' work, particularly those who have close ties to the ministry of education or are involved in policy development. As a result, the research that is mobilised through NITS may be reflective of political pressures and become non-representative of the broader educational research community.

The second challenge relates to the **lack of evaluation of the impact of knowledge mobilisation efforts.** As a pioneering initiative in Japan, the "Evidence for Dialogue" programme was piloted in two prefectures in July 2024. These initial pilot programmes will serve as a foundation for evaluating the initiative's effectiveness and shaping the narrative to encourage further investment from policy makers and school boards. While NITS is responsible for measuring the impacts of its initiatives, the responsibility to systematically measure the long-term effects on teachers rests at the local level. Due to the high financial costs and methodological difficulties associated with long-term evaluations, as well as jurisdictional gaps, this remains a challenge for NITS and local authorities. While the institute conducts pre- and post-surveys for its professional development courses and uses the Net Promoter Score[4] to assess participant satisfaction, these measures still fall short of capturing the full impact of the initiatives on educational outcomes.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

Despite these challenges, the "Evidence for Dialogue" initiative offers a promising model that could be adapted and implemented in other countries or educational organisations. Its emphasis on creating a shared understanding of educational challenges through evidence-based dialogue offers particular promise. By involving a wide range of stakeholders in these discussions, the initiative can help bridge the gap between research and practice and foster a more collaborative approach to problem-solving.

The initiative may be of particular value to countries where the education system is similarly hierarchical, or where there is a significant disconnect between policy makers and practitioners, as it could help to

create a more inclusive and responsive educational environment. For example, in contexts where rural municipalities and educators face similar challenges to those in Japan, such as difficulties in accessing sufficient resources, accessing professional learning or recruiting teachers to their schools (OECD, 2018[21]), the dialogue approach could be used to develop professional development programmes that are tailored to the needs of teachers in these areas.

Moreover, the initiative's focus on co-creating solutions rather than imposing top-down policies is particularly relevant in diverse educational contexts, where one-size-fits-all approaches are often ineffective (Farley-Ripple, Oliver and Boaz, 2020[23]). By engaging stakeholders in the process of identifying and addressing educational challenges, the "Evidence for Dialogue" model can empower them to take ownership of solutions to issues and ensure that they are grounded in the realities of their specific contexts.

Case Study 2: Knowledge mobilisation actors in a federal, decentralised and highly diverse system – the United States

In a federal and decentralised education system such as the United States, it is hard to ensure the uptake of national-level knowledge mobilisation initiatives only promoted by state-level actors. This means that in addition to the main national knowledge mobilisation actor, the Institute of Educational Sciences (IES), the education system needs to rely on regional and local intermediaries and mechanisms to support evidence use. This case study presents two groups of such actors (see Box 4.4).

Box 4.4. Federally supported regional and local intermediaries in the United States

Regional Education Laboratories

Regional Educational Laboratories (RELs) were established almost 60 years ago by the United States Department of Education as a network of ten intermediary organisations that seek to address the educational needs of designated regions across the country. RELs are sponsored by the Institute of Education Sciences delivered through competitive tender by contracted firms, universities and other research institutes. An annual public budget of almost USD 60 million supports the programme (Institute of Education Sciences, 2024[24]).

Comprehensive Centers

Comprehensive Centers (CCs) are established through cooperative agreements with the Department of Education, with the most recent version of the programme authorised in 2005. The centers support state, regional and local education agencies and schools in offering all students a comprehensive and rigorous education and in addressing national needs and priorities, and adequate and equitable funding for schools. The programme is operated by the Office of Elementary and Secondary Education and runs in cycles of five years with an annual funding of around USD 50 million. At least one center is required in each of the ten regions served by the RELs.

Source: IES (2024[25]), *About the Regional Educational Laboratory Program*, https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/rel/About/ (accessed on 14 November 20214); US Department of Education (2024[26]), *Comprehensive Centers Program*, https://www.ed.gov/grants-and-programs/grants-birth-grade-12/comprehensive-centers-program (accessed on 14 November 2024).

Regional Educational Laboratories

The RELs' main mission is to support state departments of education, school districts and other education stakeholders in using data and evidence with a goal to improve student outcomes. Their work also involves

generating relevant evidence using state and/or local data. An evaluation of the RELs conducted in 2015 found that most of the applied research generated was strong in quality and relevance. Around 50% of state administrators and 26% of district administrators who were familiar with the REL programme were very satisfied with it. While this evaluation did not link the REL programme to student outcomes directly (Carlson et al., 2015[27]), some of the RELs themselves conduct small impact studies that do that for certain services, such as professional development toolkits. The RELs offer evidence-based support for both policy and practice.

RELs supporting states and districts in attracting and retaining teachers

Several RELs supported state education offices and school districts in addressing the challenge of teacher shortages many states are facing (NCEE, 2023[28]):

- REL Midwest surveyed certified non-teaching teachers in Michigan to understand what would bring them back in the profession (Lindsay, Gnedko-Berry and Wan, 2021[29]). This evidence was then used by the Michigan Department of Education to design a teacher policy.
- REL Northwest partnered with one of Alaska's school districts to identify evidence-based strategies to increase teacher retention. The REL supported the district in developing a theory of action for monitoring and improving teachers' working conditions.
- REL Central partnered with the South Dakota Department of Education to support the development of new pathways into teaching for candidates such as paraprofessionals and other residents who have interest in entering the teacher workforce.

RELs supporting districts and schools in evidence-based teaching practices

Despite considerable investment in making the resources produced by the IES What Works Clearinghouse (WWC) user-friendly, notably through practice guides, WWC resources are still hard for teachers to apply directly (Nelson, 2021[30]; Barton and Tindle, 2019[31]). The IES recognised that RELs need to play the intermediary role of curating information and offering professional development resources based on the WWC Practice Guides that can be used by districts and schools as they implement evidence-based practices. Thus, a new feature of the 2022-2027 REL cycle is that all RELs create a toolkit for educators based on one of the What Works Clearinghouse (WWC) Practice Guides. Some examples of similar REL work are (Boccanfuso, 2023[32]):

- *REL Appalachia's focus on improving maths outcomes*: The REL has supported "community math nights" and has offered capacity building to schools to promote positive math attitudes with students and families. It has supported the implementation of research-based instructional practices based on WWC's practice guides.
- *REL Southeast's focus on improving literacy in Mississippi*: After the Mississippi Department of Education's successful improvement of early years foundational literacy skills (the "Mississippi Miracle"), the REL is currently supporting the Improving Adolescent Literacy Partnership of four school districts through training courses for teachers. It relies on WWC Practice Guides to effectively integrate literacy strategies into a range of academic courses.

The above examples, together with Box 3.4 in Chapter 3, demonstrate that the RELs engage in a range of knowledge mobilisation activities, including generating context-relevant evidence, capacity building and providing direct support to policy and practice organisations in using evidence.

Comprehensive Centers

The main mission of the CCs is to provide technical assistance to build the capacity of education agencies at all levels in improving student outcomes. Technical assistance often included fostering ownership and

long-term change and supporting organisational process changes through partnering, cross-state sharing and modelling new practices. According to the evaluation of the 2012-2018 cohort, recipients of CC services reported the technical assistance significantly benefit their knowledge and skills (85% moderate to great extent), while only less than half of them perceived a large contribution to organisational capacity and capacity for policy design and implementation (Weinstock et al., 2019[33]).

The 2019-2024 cohort consisted of one national, 19 regional and one content CC (focusing on improving literacy). CCs' knowledge mobilisation activities include, for example:

- *National CC for coordination and peer learning*: 1. The National CC designed and implemented three Communities of Practice to help state agencies share promising practices and promote strategies to accelerate learning recovery and promote equity in response to the pandemic (CCNetwork, 2019[34]). 2. In partnership with the US Department of Education, the national CC hosted the "Meeting the Moment" event in 2024 to foster collective work of state educational agencies and the CC Network. The interactive workshops and panels featured evidence-based tools and strategies (CCNetwork, 2019[35]).
- *Nebraska CC for school improvement*: the Nebraska Department of Education partnered with the Region 11 CC to create a replicable, scalable and sustainable school improvement process with evidence-based solutions to ensure effective support for multilingual students. The two partners facilitated a broader professional learning partnerships with state agencies, the CC focusing on high-leverage practices to all teachers of multilingual learners (CCNetwork, 2024[36]).

In the new, 2024-2029 cohort the number of regional CCs was reduced to 14 and it includes a National CC and four content CCs on English learners and multilingualism, early school success, fiscal equity and strengthening and supporting the educator workforce.

Challenges and limitations

In a large federal and decentralised education system like the United States, a diverse set of intermediary actors can help ensure that the different evidence-building and use needs of state and local education agencies are addressed. However, role clarity and systematic collaboration between those actors is necessary to maximise the efficiency of their activities.

The RELs and CCs were established with a shared goal: improving student outcomes by supporting evidence-based policy and practice. Although given a unique emphasis (applied research for the RELs, and improved state implementation of federally-devised elementary and secondary education programmes for the CCs), both programmes were expected to provide technical assistance to regions, states and localities to achieve that goal. Because each state and locality in the United States is served by a specific REL and CC, there is the opportunity for collaboration and complementarity between the two programmes. Yet, it remains unclear how often these opportunities are leveraged.

For example, the US Department of Education regularly convenes all federally-sponsored technical assistance providers to increase awareness of the work of different providers on a particular topic and to encourage them to share their resources on that topic. However, the needs of specific states or local areas are not discussed in an in-depth manner with a focus on how different providers may want to improve co-ordination or collaboration of their work there.

Similarly, although the Department of Education requires that RELs and CCs coordinate conversations with state education agencies about the agencies' needs and encourages them to collaborate on projects when appropriate, in practice such collaborations appear infrequent. As an example, a state education agency might ask a Regional CC to support implementation of an evidence-based practice in a state, and the REL to evaluate its implementation and impact. Notably, some actors report this type of complementarity is more common when the same intermediary organisation operates the REL and CC

serving a specific state or region. More intentional local and regional co-ordination of knowledge mobilisation and collaboration among key actors, including mapping intermediaries and their activities and roles, could promote greater efficiency and increase the effectiveness of both programmes.

Finally, although regular evaluation of the RELs and the CCs is a major strength of the programmes, the evaluations could benefit from using more sophisticated measures of impact. They focus primarily on self-reported perceptions of the value of services provided by RELs and CCs (e.g. on the extent to which materials produced by the centres have been used) and lack long-term behavioural change indicators for education agencies and schools, as well as indicators measuring ultimate impact on student outcomes and the teaching workforce for example.

Expanding the practice: Lessons for others

Providing substantial grants for regional and local intermediaries for a clearly described mission to support evidence use can serve as a model for other federal systems. In the United States, the landscape of these intermediary actors is highly diverse and, because of the sheer size of the country, it is harder to co-ordinate their work and generate peer learning. This might be easier for smaller and less diverse countries, such as Germany, Switzerland, Austria or Spain. Even for non-federal systems, a network of smaller intermediaries serving local needs and supporting evidence use and capacity building could be an inspiring practice to support knowledge mobilisation at scale.

The regular external evaluation of the REL and the CC programmes by IES is certainly a practice that other countries can learn from. These evaluations help shape the next cohort of the programme and improve what worked less well. The achievements of CCs are also shared through accessible impact stories, which can inspire educational actors to benefit from these services. A combination of sharing intermediary perceived outcomes for dissemination purposes and publishing formal evaluations supports evaluative thinking about knowledge mobilisation within and across organisations in the system.

Conclusion

Achieving consensus among different stakeholders on the adequate existence and effectiveness of mechanisms to support research use can facilitate co-ordinated efforts to enhance the integration of research into policy and practice. A shared understanding may provide a foundation for aligning resources, strategies and expectations, ensuring that both groups work collaboratively towards a common goal. Conversely, a lack of consensus may hinder the effective implementation of these mechanisms, as differing perceptions could lead to misaligned efforts, underused resources, and fragmented initiatives that fail to generate the desired impact. By identifying and addressing any gaps in the perception of research use mechanisms, ministries and intermediaries can strengthen their collaborative efforts. Similarly, better alignment among stakeholders on the main barriers to research use across different levels of the education system would allow for a targeted, co-ordinated approach to address these challenges and allocate resources accordingly.

The analysis in this chapter thus signals a need for improved communication and collaboration between ministries and intermediary actors to enhance the use of research in education policy and practice. Regarding mechanisms, a question that arises is whether it is crucial for all intermediaries to be aware of all mechanisms to facilitate research use in their systems. While there is a clear benefit for all intermediaries to have a comprehensive overview of the funding mechanisms in place that are relevant to them, would they need an up-to-date overview of all funding mechanisms? Is it crucial for all intermediaries to be aware of the system-level strategies that their ministries implement “downstream” to identify research gaps in practice, for example? It is entirely possible for a mechanism to be targeted at a specific sub-group

of actors and communicated effectively to those actors by means of a targeted communication strategy, whereby it may not be visible to other actors in the system but is nonetheless working effectively.

It is possible that full agreement between ministries and intermediaries is unattainable given the significantly different spaces that these actors occupy in education systems. It is even arguable whether a complete alignment in views is a desirable goal, as differences in perspective between stakeholders provide material for robust debate, which can in turn lead to innovative proposals and reform. Yet, to improve the research use ecosystem, it is important to strive for a better alignment in understanding between ministries and intermediaries. Ideally, policy makers should prioritise transparent communication strategies and foster collaborative environments where feedback from intermediaries is actively sought and integrated in policy work. Future work should focus on developing and evaluating strategies to improve alignment between these groups, ensuring that mechanisms intended to support research use are highly visible to their target audience and beneficiaries, are well communicated and effectively implemented at all levels of the education system.

Reflection questions and activities

Consider the data and messages that have been presented in this chapter. Are the findings representative of the situation in your country/system?

- How do policy makers in your country communicate research-use mechanisms to relevant audiences? For example, how are major funding calls for education research shared with intermediaries and other actors?
- What do you think are the main barriers to research use in education policy or practice in your system? What could be the roles of policy makers and intermediaries in overcoming these barriers?
- What strategies are in place in your system to help build relationships between ministries and intermediary organisations to enhance the use of research in policy and practice? Do these strategies or initiatives allow them to build relationships that are collaborative and can be sustained over time?

Activity 1 – Short term

Using the case studies above, try to identify a few lessons that can be learned. Is there a similar dialogue platform or initiative in your country/system/organisation? If so, how is it similar to or different from the above examples? If there is not, would it be helpful to establish one? Who could take responsibility for this?

Activity 2 – Long term

Identify ten organisations in your system that play a major role in facilitating research use in either policy or practice. Organise a one-day meeting with these organisations, in which you discuss your respective perspectives on existing mechanisms and barriers, and what could be the role of each actor in overcoming barriers.

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Notes

[1] OECD member countries: Austria, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, Czechia, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, Hungary, Iceland, Japan, Korea, Latvia, Lithuania, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Portugal, Slovak Republic, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden, Türkiye. OECD member countries' jurisdictions: Flemish and French Communities of Belgium, Quebec, Saskatchewan (Canada), Appenzell Ausserrhoden, Lucerne, Nidwalden, Obwalden, St. Gallen, Uri, Zurich (Switzerland), England (United Kingdom), Illinois (United States). Non-member economies: Russian Federation, South Africa.

[2] The policy survey targeted the highest level of decision making in education (ministry/department of education). In federal systems, this corresponds to the state (province, canton, autonomous community, etc.) department. Respondents were asked to co-ordinate the response across departments. Follow-up interviews revealed that ministries of education had various definitions of policy makers, most commonly associating the term with high-level ministry officials (e.g. Directors, Deputy Directors and Director Generals), recognising those with influence over the policy process, rather than those tasked with implementation of policies.

[3] Austria, Chile, Czechia, Denmark, England (United Kingdom), Estonia, Flemish and French Communities of Belgium, Finland, Hungary, Iceland, Japan, Latvia, Lithuania, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Portugal, Slovak Republic, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden.

[4] The Net Promoter Score is a method for calculating the likelihood of a teacher recommending a service on a scale of 0-10.

5 Going for broke: Knowledge mobilisation funding and resources

Jordan Hill, OECD

Analysing the results of the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education, this chapter looks at which organisations fund research and knowledge mobilisation and how they do so. This chapter also presents the sources of funding for intermediary organisations and explores the different ways in which they resource their knowledge mobilisation efforts. It offers reflections on strengths and weaknesses of research projects, knowledge mobilisation teams/departments and larger knowledge mobilisation programmes. It also draws lessons for education from wider science, technology and innovation policy, where there is unexplored potential for cross-sectoral learning. Finally, the chapter offers two case studies, one focused on a programme for funding policy research in Latvia and another analysing the funding of a well-known knowledge intermediary in Chile.

Key messages

There is already a solid foundation of resources directed towards mobilising knowledge in education, but improving how this work is financed can enhance these efforts. Funding programmes must ensure a genuine rebalancing towards more complex but impactful work in education, focusing less on the number of publications and more on the quality of relationships, partnership infrastructure, and capacity for interpreting and using findings. This chapter analyses the funding landscape of knowledge mobilisation and finds that:

- Research institutes are most often selected as a funding recipient and, on average, they have by far the largest share of allocated funding. The rhetoric from funders and policy makers on the importance of co-created solutions does not appear to extend to more balanced funding for a diversity of education actors.
- Funders consider a variety of factors when deciding to allocate funding to research projects although, overall, the dissemination of funded research results was most commonly considered and the presence of monitoring and evaluation processes was least commonly considered.
- The education sector can learn from the broader experiences of science, technology and innovation (STI) policy. Two examples are wrap-around services, such as technology transfer offices, and researcher mobility schemes, such as Industrial PhDs.
- Short-term research projects that disseminate research carry low risk but tend to have limited impact when used in isolation. Larger programmes provide important stability for intermediary efforts in education.
- There is a correlation between the adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation and the satisfaction of intermediaries with both the quality of education research and how policy makers and practitioners engage with it. It is important to combine additional resources with more formal recognition of knowledge mobilisation as a professional discipline in education, as well as high-quality training on effective strategies and skills for intermediaries.

Introduction

The funding landscape for knowledge mobilisation has changed significantly in the last five years, and there are more ambitious programmes emerging, many of which are education-specific (Hayter, 2024[1]). While this is a positive development, there remains a general lack of empirical research into which funding practices are more likely to successfully mobilise knowledge in education (Tseng in (Bangs et al., 2022[2])). This lack of knowledge risks wasting money and limits the ability of funders to contribute their perspectives to the overall knowledge base on how research can be produced and used well.

A stronger knowledge base can eventually help tackle big funding questions, such as the optimal funding balance between “blue-skies” research and needs-led research. It could also help to better articulate what the language of public research funding means for knowledge mobilisation in education. For instance, international science policy often makes a distinction between “basic research” (more experimental or theoretical) and “applied research” (directed primarily towards a specific, practical aim or objective) (OECD, 2015[3]). However, the distinction between these two terms often appears artificial in education, where developing solutions to problems frequently requires carrying out both theoretical and practical research in a seamless manner, combining it with professional or tacit knowledge. This tension is what led Schrader and Goeze (2011[4]) to develop the principle of “application-oriented basic research” education. This term is used in the knowledge mobilisation strategy of the German Institute for Adult Education (German Institute

for Adult Education, 2024[5]), and likely other intermediaries trying to span the boundaries of research, policy and practice.

This chapter looks at some of the very basic questions that can help to inform these larger discussions in the long term. Specifically, it analyses the results of the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (henceforth, the "intermediaries' survey"), which collected data about the knowledge mobilisation activities of 288 intermediary organisations in 34 countries to better understand how they are supporting research engagement (see Chapter 1). Analysis of this data is complemented with desk research to explore the funding landscape from the perspective of both knowledge intermediaries and the organisations that fund them. Where appropriate, the chapter also draws on the results of the 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey (henceforth, the "policy survey"), which collected data from 37 ministries of education in 29 countries to map the knowledge mobilisation mechanisms, actors and challenges across education systems (see (OECD, 2022[6])).

This chapter investigates the following questions:

- **Which organisations fund education research and/or research mobilisation and how do they do so?**
- **What sources of funding do intermediaries have and how do they use it for knowledge mobilisation?**
- **What is the relationship between resources and intermediaries' satisfaction with knowledge mobilisation?**

Which organisations fund education research and/or research mobilisation and how do they do so?

Diverse types of organisations finance education research and knowledge mobilisation. Of the 288 respondents to the intermediaries' survey, 31 organisations (11%) listed themselves as an organisation that funds education research and/or research mobilisation activities. The source of the funding for these 31 organisations was almost always listed as public funding from regional, national and international sources; or private funding, in the case of independent foundations. There was very little mixture of public and private sources of funding for funding organisations. The respondent funding organisations can be grouped into roughly five categories:

- independent foundations and NGOs (n = 8);
- ministries of education (MoE) and arm's-length public bodies (n = 8); for example, National Centres for Teaching Excellence, education agencies;
- formal intermediaries (n = 6); for example, those hosting evidence portals;
- public research agencies (n = 6); for example, those whose mission is to fund basic or applied research;
- academic associations and initiatives (n = 3); for example, academies of science or university-school partnerships.

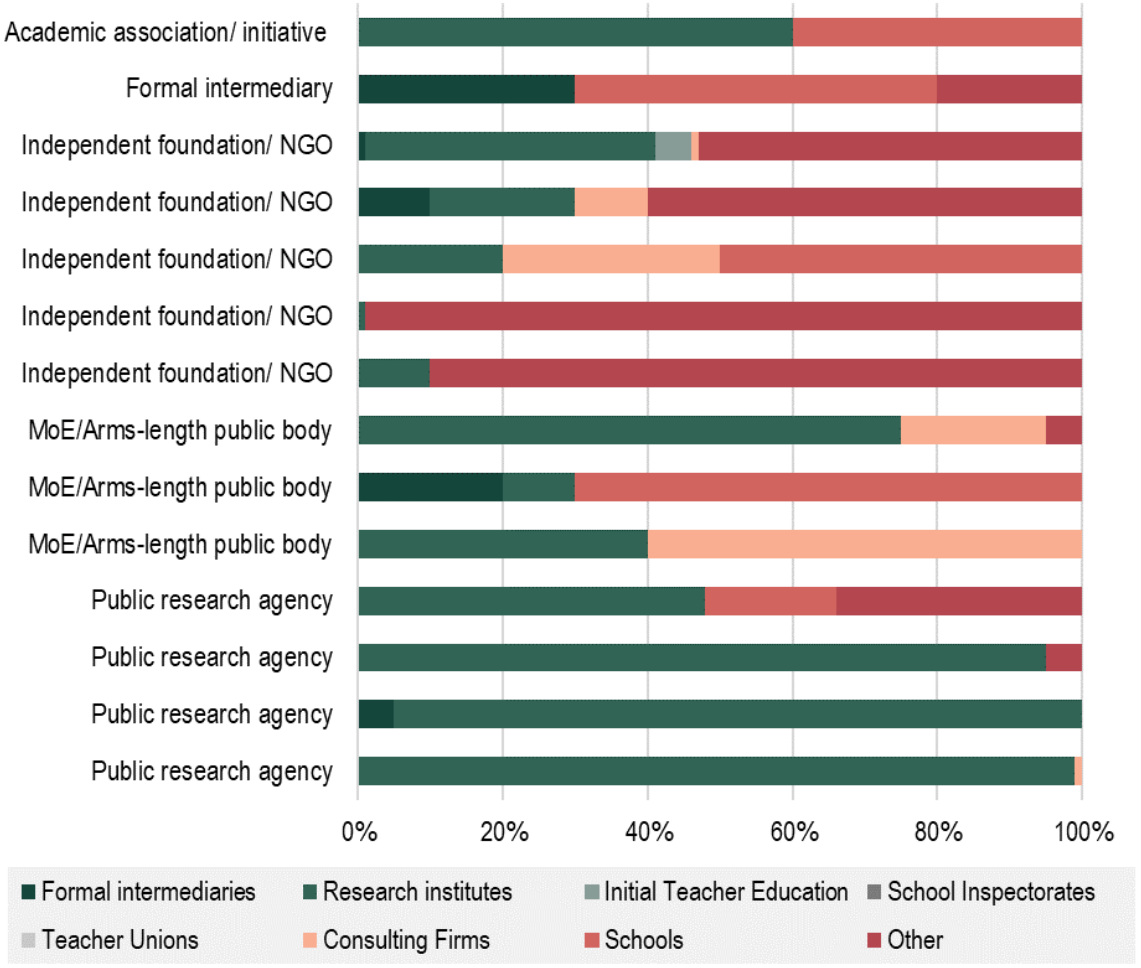
Funding recipients

The intermediaries' survey included a question asking funding organisations which kinds of organisations they were funding and the percentage of their portfolio allocated to each organisational type.

Research institutes are most often selected as a funding recipient and, on average, they have the largest share of allocated funding by far

Of the funding organisations who responded to this question, 42% reported allocating all their funding to just one type of recipient. In 70% of cases, the one type of recipient was research organisations, and in 20% of cases it was formal intermediaries. The remaining funding organisations (Figure 5.1) split at least some of their allocations across different recipient types. It is important to bear in mind that these funding organisations did not explicitly state whether they are funding education research, knowledge mobilisation or both. It is therefore not possible to estimate the ratio of knowledge mobilisation funding compared to research funding in the sample.

Figure 5.1. Funding organisations that allocate to multiple recipients



Notes: Data shows the responses of those 14 respondents that selected more than one funding recipient type with respect to the percentage of funding they allocate to different types of organisations (out of a total number of 24 respondents to this particular question). Responses have been anonymised by type of funding organisation. Data is arranged alphabetically by type of funding organisation. The "Other" category predominantly refers to the private sector (including educational technology companies providing administrative services to funders) as well as non-governmental organisations and community groups. None of the respondents reported to allocate funding to school inspectorates and teacher unions.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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Low levels of funding for schools may jeopardise genuine research-practice partnerships

Although research institutes were reported to be the primary beneficiaries of funding, the "other" category, which most often included private companies, civil society and NGOs, also received a notable proportion of funding. By contrast, only five funding organisations allocated funding to schools, and the average allocation percentage was much lower compared to research institutes. This allocation landscape is not surprising, researchers are often the principal investigators on research projects and funding tends to support the researchers and research organisations (Tseng in (Bangs et al., 2022[2])). At the same time, funders consistently (and increasingly) emphasise the importance of collaboration between research producers and users to promote research uptake. The funding split reported in the intermediaries' survey favours research institutes so heavily that it raises questions with regards to the nature and extent of support for collaborative knowledge production and/or mobilisation.

Research on partnership work in education consistently finds that strategies to shift power relations in research endeavours have more chance of success if funding mechanisms take into account the need to create trust, foster high-quality relationships between partners and implement an iterative process in collaborative research (Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[7]). If collaborative initiatives between research institutes and schools do not receive financial support in a way that is proportional to the real involvement of each party, there is a risk of deepening existing power imbalances between research producers and users. This, in turn, can jeopardise the impact of knowledge mobilisation.

> **Beyond research funding, authentic collaborations mean schools need support to cover the time, effort, staffing and expertise that they invest. This is an important point that doesn't seem to be properly considered in the public funding schemes that I am aware of.**
>
> *– Lou Aisenberg, Senior Policy Manager for the Innovation, Data and Experiments in Education (IDEE) programme at J-PAL Europe.*

Of course, an alternative interpretation of the data could simply be that funders aim not to burden schools with the administrative work required to receive funds, and prefer research institutes to do this work, since they have more capacity to deal with large, complicated grant administration. In this case, funders may wish to reconsider which expenses are allowed, encouraged, or even required in grant budgets to cover tasks, such as applying findings to practice and supporting communities to mobilise research to advocate for change (Tseng in (Bangs et al., 2022[2])). This could make receiving funds more attractive, transparent and intuitive for schools. Although the current data do not allow for an estimation of the amount of funding being allocated by funders, it seems unlikely that the funding allocated by the five organisations reporting to fund schools would tip the balance towards a more equitable distribution across diverse education actors.

Funding criteria

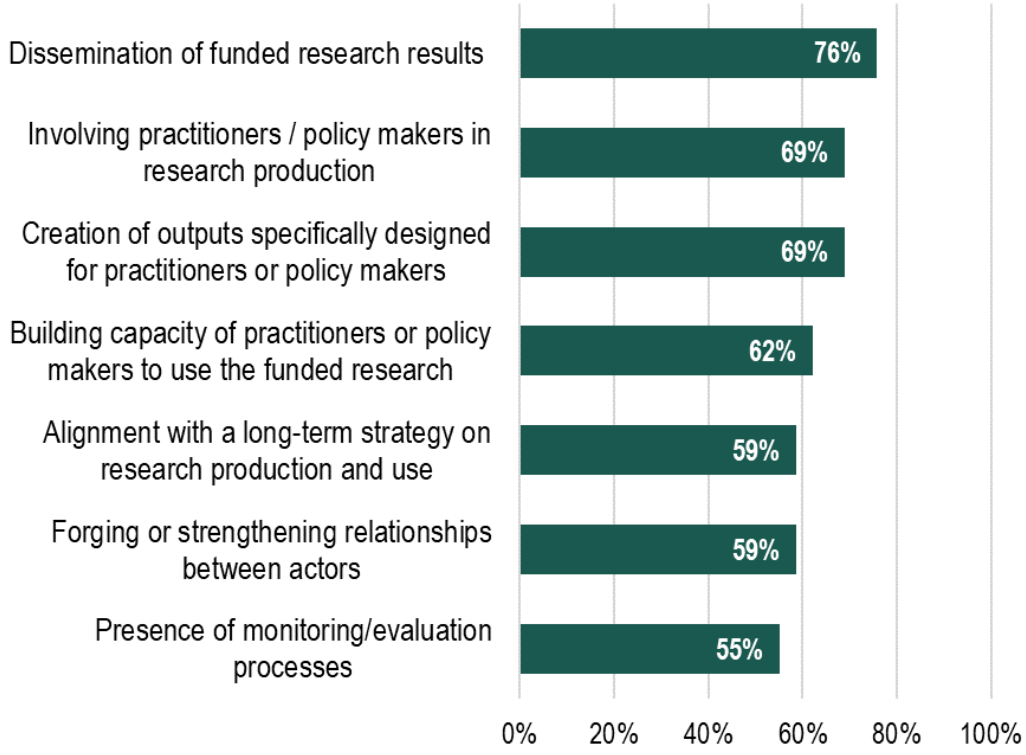
When it comes to how funders evaluate the merits of the proposals they receive for research, different types of funders place emphasis on different knowledge mobilisation factors when considering research proposals (Figure 5.2).

Funding organisations consider different knowledge mobilisation factors in a roughly balanced way when deciding to allocate funding to research projects

At the aggregate level, dissemination of funded research results was the most commonly reported factor for funding consideration, and presence of monitoring and evaluation processes was least commonly reported. Despite a significant percentage of shared gaps and overlaps, it is possible to discern slight preferences for certain factors among different types of funding organisations. For instance, only two out of seven independent foundations reported that they consider building the capacity of practitioners or policy

makers to use the funded research in their funding decisions. By contrast, all seven of the arm's-length public bodies and ministries reported that they consider this as a factor.

Figure 5.2. Knowledge mobilisation factors considered by funders in decisions to allocate funding to research projects



Note: N = 29. Two funding organisations did not respond to this question. Data are arranged in descending order from highest average percentage across all factors.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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While the data do not allow for an estimation of the amount of funding being allocated by these funder types, data on these activities in other chapters of this publication (e.g. Chapters 3 and 6) suggest that the focus of funding is leaning towards more traditional dissemination, while not enough may be allocated to monitoring and evaluation. An additional unanswered question is the extent to which different funders proactively co-ordinate in terms of their needs, goals and funding programmes to strengthen their impact. There are positive examples of funding co-ordination mechanisms outside of education that aim to make more efficient use of limited resources, from which the education sector can learn (Box 5.1).

Box 5.1. Co-ordinating funding to maximise impact in Sweden

In 2012, the Swedish Innovation Agency, the Swedish Energy Agency and the Swedish Research Council jointly implemented the Strategic Innovation Area (Borowiecki and Paunov, 2018[8]). This was expanded in 2013 to become Swedish Strategic Innovation Programmes, with total resources of SEK 16 billion going to research and innovation initiatives scheduled to last 12 years.

Around half of the funding comes from national government and half from companies, public authorities and research institutes. The initiative is evaluated every three years and a meta-evaluation reported long-term collaborations, new projects (both publicly funded and self-funded) and use of project results to improve products, services or processes as key programme impacts (Åström and Arnold, 2023[9]).

Lessons from science, technology and innovation policy

When it comes to public research funding in education, as in most sectors, it remains focused on producing academic papers in peer-reviewed journals. However, research funding in diverse sectors increasingly includes an innovation component that is seen not just as a tool to promote economic growth, but as a way of addressing societal challenges (Schwaag Serger et al., 2023[10]). Education can – and should – benefit from long-standing and evaluated innovation management and knowledge management approaches adopted as part of broader science, technology and innovation (STI) policy (Halász, 2022[11]). This section looks at two such approaches – wrap-around innovation services and researcher mobility schemes – to understand how they may support knowledge mobilisation in education.

Wrap-around innovation services ensure resources for a range of knowledge mobilisation activities

Many, if not most, regions in OECD countries have permanent knowledge mobilisation structures, such as technology transfer offices, designed to facilitate innovation. These “wrap-around” services combine financial support with localised, targeted training, networking and innovation expertise, offering specific lines of capacity building for entrepreneurial researchers at different stages. The growing recognition of the role of innovation in addressing societal challenges means these knowledge mobilisation structures are expanding their scope and mission beyond economic growth and taking into account societal needs (Borrás, Gerli and Cenzato, 2024[12]).

Wrap-around services often employ a systematic “quadruple helix” approach, bringing together academia, public and private sectors and civil society as part of local STI policy (OECD, 2020[13]). In the case of Canada, 67 Technology Access Centres provide locally-focused advice, funding, intellectual property development and networking events. Since 2010, these centres are funded by the Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council of Canada (Tech-Access Canada, n.d.[14]). Specific to social sciences, the United Kingdom Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC) funds 32 Impact Acceleration Accounts housed in research institutions. Each grant is worth GBP 1.25 million over a five-year period and is used for institutions to support social sciences researchers with projects and training to work with partners from across other sectors to mobilise knowledge (ESRC, n.d.[15]).

Such tailored, localised innovation support initiatives were not commonly reported in the open-ended responses to the intermediaries’ survey, suggesting that they may be less widespread in education, or not thought of as particularly promising practices. One privately-funded example that was reported was the Education Fund of the Good Deed Foundation, whose model (Box 5.2) more closely resembles that of a wrap-around innovation service, rather than an education research funding scheme. Another education-specific example is the network of nine transfer agencies (*Transferagenturen*) in Germany offering

evidence-based advice to local authorities (OECD, 2020[16]). Both examples are still quite small and rare compared to the amount of support provided by STI policies for knowledge mobilisation more broadly. Making such tailored, wrap-around support more systematic and/or accessible in OECD education systems would more closely align education research with recognised good practices in innovation.

Box 5.2. Wrap-around innovation support in education practice

The Good Deed Foundation is a 20-year-old private philanthropy foundation in Estonia. The Education Fund is a programme of the foundation with contributions from more than 60 companies and entrepreneurs and a total size of over EUR 3 million. The fund supports education initiatives (both financially and through its expertise and network), invests in education start-ups, implements its own initiatives, and commissions research. It focuses on the quality of school management, increasing the supply of teachers and the science of learning and meta-cognition.

In addition to financial support, the fund provides management advice, expert networks, communication and impact assessment, legal advice and fundraising advice. For example, the Alpha Kids initiative, which brought together teachers and researchers to co-create age-appropriate and culture-based digital learning games for children aged 3-8. The games currently have 120 000 users across 420 educational institutions in Estonia.

Source: Good Deed Foundation (n.d.[17]), *Good Deed's Funds and Incubator*, https://heategu.ee/en/funds/education-fund/ (accessed on 18 July 2024).

Researcher mobility schemes and knowledge transfer fellowships are effective ways of deepening relationships between research and its users

STI funding explicitly aims to scale up the results obtained from publicly funded research. This often means the commercialisation of research for new products or the licensing of technology (Guimón, 2019[18]). Essential to this process is fostering intense science-industry relations, co-financing and co-creation of knowledge over the medium to long term through shared facilities and mixed teams (Guimón, 2019[18]). Despite recent efforts to foster the mobilisation of research through intensifying collaboration between research, policy and practice, genuine co-creation of knowledge, shared facilities and mixed teams remains outside the mainstream in the education sector in many OECD countries. Instead, the value of partnership work in education is often normatively described as "nice to have", rather than something bringing tangible benefits (Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[7]). However, work on knowledge mobilisation conducted in the last 20 years gives a strong indication that the relationships built during genuine collaborations can raise the relevance, accessibility and use of research in education.

Researcher mobility schemes are a core tool used to deepen relations between science, policy and industry. A classic example in STI funding is Industrial PhD schemes, which first appeared in Denmark in 1970 and are now widespread in Europe and North America (Compagnucci and Spigarelli, 2024[19]). Industrial PhD graduates experience working in the dual cultural context of academia and industry, developing the capacity of adaptation, flexibility, and an applied-driven approach to addressing challenges and needs (Compagnucci and Spigarelli, 2024[19]). There is a promising trend of applying the Industrial PhD model to the policy making context, such as the Norwegian Public Sector PhD programme (OFFPHD). OFFPHD was established in 2014 at the Ministry of Education and Research, and is explicitly modelled on Norway's industrial PhD scheme, enabling a PhD to be undertaken in a university by a candidate working in a public sector body (OECD, 2023[20]). In 2022, France also launched a public sector PhD scheme (Government of France, 2023[21]). Indeed, the number of such policy fellowship opportunities is increasing

in OECD education systems (for an example in Wales, see (OECD, 2023[20])). However, these initiatives are much rarer when it comes to education practice.

Industrial PhD schemes are not the only kind of researcher mobility that STI policy uses to foster knowledge mobilisation between actors. Others include knowledge mobilisation partnerships/fellowships (Box 5.3), which are attracting positive attention in diverse sectors (e.g. health (PenARC, 2024[22])). When learning from STI funding, there is an obvious question of generalisability. Education is different from STI in the sense that it is not industry- or market-driven to the same extent. This is another reason why more empirical research on funding mechanisms in education is required, to allow an informed assessment of the transferability of schemes from other sectors.

Box 5.3. Looking beyond Industrial PhD schemes: Knowledge Transfer Partnerships in the United Kingdom

When it comes to STI funding, the United Kingdom's Knowledge Transfer Partnerships programme is one of the most widely recognised internationally, in part because of its 45+ year history and published independent impact evaluations (Guimón, 2019[18]; UKRI/ SQW, 2023[23]).

Each Knowledge Transfer Partnerships involves a firm, a university and a suitably qualified graduate (75% have a master's or PhD degree) who will undertake an innovation project within the firm for a period of one to three years, under the joint supervision of the university and the firm.

The university employs the graduate, but the firm co-finances the salary alongside a public grant (GBP 80 000 to 100 000). Besides contributing to science-industry knowledge transfer, the programme is a useful tool to enhance the propensity of early-career researchers to engage with industry.

What sources of funding do intermediaries have and how do they use it for knowledge mobilisation?

Funding sources

In the intermediaries' survey, each respondent was asked to provide a breakdown of their overall funding sources (Figure 5.3).

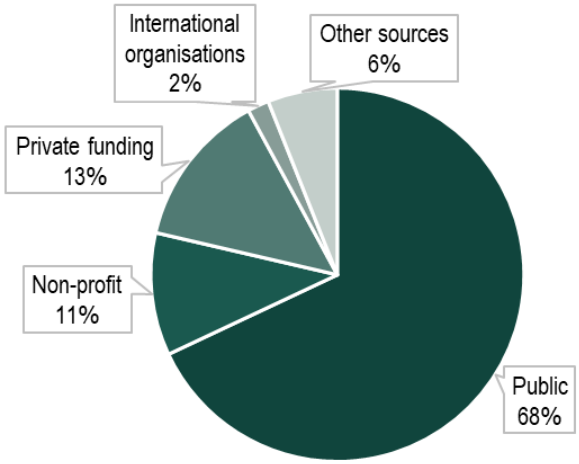
Public funding dominates sources for knowledge mobilisation

By far the largest volume of funding for respondent intermediaries comes from the public sector. This is not surprising, since so many of the intermediaries in the sample are universities or public research institutes. In terms of the diversity of funding, non-profit and private sources were reported by just under half of respondents, and international organisations were sources of funding for around one-quarter of respondents. However, the average amount of funding received from these sources is very small.

While some consider high levels of public funding as a positive sign (see quote below), the dominance of public funding across much of the sample does mean that many intermediaries need to make extra effort to maintain an image of independence, while also emphasising their alignment with the funding priorities of policy makers in order to benefit from future public grants (MacKillop and Downe, 2023[24]).

> **The level of public funding could suggest that policy makers see knowledge mobilisation as a real priority and the task is not just being left to a small group of organisations who are fortunate enough to have income from their wider commercial investments that they can either distribute to others or use directly for their own work.**
>
> *– Jonathan Kay, Head of Evidence Synthesis, Education Endowment Foundation*

Figure 5.3. Funding sources for intermediary organisations in education



Notes: The "other sources" category triggered a qualitative question and responses included fees for education associations and unions, interest on endowments and selling products or services.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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These aggregated data hide variation at the country level. Looking only at countries with the most respondents (≥ 10 organisations), the average percentage of funding from public sources ranges from 94% in the Netherlands, to just 28% in Australia. Australian respondents reported that the greatest share of their funding came from the "other" category, where several education associations reported that they rely mostly or entirely on membership fees. The United States had the highest average funding (24%) from non-profits (associations, think tanks, foundations) and from the private sector (22%). This may be partly explained by the higher prevalence of philanthropic organisations – which are mostly focused on the education sector – in the United States compared to other OECD countries. Of the philanthropic assets identified in one major international comparison study, 60% were held by US foundations while the combined assets of foundations in the Netherlands, Germany, Switzerland, Italy, the United Kingdom, France, Spain, Türkiye and Ireland equated to 37% (Johnson, 2018[25]).

Other sources include commercial activities, endowment and tuition fees

In the qualitative responses to the intermediaries' survey, several organisations gave examples of commercial activities that provided them with funding. For example, subscription fees, income from endowments, tuition fees and student accommodation, as well as sales of products and services. In some cases, the funding sources for commercial activities may still be public (e.g. where publicly funded schools are paying for professional development services, or public universities pay a membership fee to an umbrella organisation). Nonetheless, the range of commercial activities that contribute to making the work

of knowledge intermediaries possible, points to an often-unrecognised entrepreneurial landscape across intermediaries in education, with potential for peer exchange that could unlock additional resources for organisations. For instance, intermediaries could share information about how they blend funding to overcome potential interruptions or variability in finances, as outlined in the Chile case study later on in this chapter.

Activities funded

The qualitative responses collected in the intermediaries' survey were supplemented with desk research of respondent organisations to reveal a diverse array of income streams and structures for different intermediary organisations. Despite this variety, it is possible to reflect on three broad ways knowledge mobilisation is resourced by intermediaries: research projects; teams and departments; and larger programmes. These three formats are not mutually exclusive, are often combined and have their respective advantages and disadvantages.

Funding that focuses on disseminating research from projects does not recognise the costs involved in impactful knowledge mobilisation

Project funding is generally linked to tangible and time-bound deliverables or outputs that cannot easily be adjusted and have a fixed (usually short) timeframe. For example, intermediaries indicated the use of European Union (EU) Horizon 2020, Horizon Europe, Erasmus + and Cohesion Funds for project-based work. But EU funds are by no means the only source of financing for the project work undertaken by the organisations in the intermediaries' survey sample. Research organisations, such as universities and public research institutes, were the largest single group of intermediaries' survey respondents. OECD data show that project funding and core operations (block) funding from national actors are the primary public financing mechanisms for universities/public research institutes (Borowiecki and Paunov, 2018[8]). For instance, in the United Kingdom, seven research councils fund project-based research in the higher education sector, while Research England provides block funding to English universities.

Traditional research projects (i.e. with a single funder, broad research topic and single recipient) are important for developing new knowledge and often include vital linear mobilisation activities (e.g. dissemination of outputs) (Oliver, 2023[26]). However, it has been recognised for many years that research projects are poorly suited to maintaining the relationships, infrastructure and processes needed for the systematic mobilisation of knowledge, since they do not recognise the costs involved before and after funded projects take place (Jackson-Bowers, Kalucy and McIntyre, 2006[27]). Currently, researchers find that the time, energy and money required to mobilise knowledge remains largely unacknowledged in research funding (Karcher et al., 2022[28]). This is important because quality use of research requires organisational structures – including funding mechanisms – that allocate time, space, facilities and budget to networking, learning and deliberation opportunities (Rickinson et al., 2022[29]). At the moment, traditional research projects are often constrained by short timelines, with little money allocated to relationship building or responding to windows of opportunity with additional activities once a project has begun (Taddese, 2021[30]). This makes it harder for policy makers and practitioners to become – and remain – engaged with the knowledge that is being generated.

Projects that explicitly allocate funding to relationship and capacity building may be seen as riskier by funding organisations, but are more likely to result in research impact

In an effort to move away from the limitations of funding traditional research projects, some OECD systems have now begun funding longer-term applied research projects in education, which generally aim to produce more usable outputs and build capacity within the system to use research (Box 5.4). Other OECD systems have incorporated collective approaches to designing funding schemes to ensure higher

engagement from beneficiaries (e.g. research institutes) with policy or practice needs (see Case Study 1 later on in this chapter). The ESRC Education Research Programme is another example of a research initiative where regular interactions between the project managers and the funder throughout the project's implementation provide an avenue for feedback regarding the time and resources required for impact generation (see the England case study in Chapter 3).

Box 5.4. Funding applied research projects in Germany

In Germany, the Federal Education Ministry (BMBF) has been implementing the Empirical Educational Research programme since 2007. When it was launched, it represented an unprecedented intervention in German research on education in financial, structural and substantive terms (Zapp and Powell, 2017[31]). It funds applied research projects to complement the funding mechanisms of the German Research Foundation, which funds basic research projects (BMBF, 2018[32]).

The current framework has been running since 2017 and a total of 260 projects have been funded with EUR 210 million (as of March 2024). The primary recipients are research institutes, and projects are usually implemented through a consortium and tend to last 2-6 years, depending on the scope. The objectives of the programme are to deepen knowledge and gain insights in new fields; strengthen the knowledge base for education practice and policy; promote co-operation between research, practice, policy and civil society to identify relevant problems; promote innovations to improve education in the long term; and expand excellent educational research (BMBF, 2018[32]).

The programme has four themes: digitalisation, equity, diversity and quality. Involving stakeholders is an explicit objective of the programme, and research institutes that focus on the mobilisation of knowledge in education practice are given greater consideration. Special emphasis is also given to collaborative research methods, regular monitoring and systematic reviews (BMBF, 2018[32]). The Federal Ministry commissioned an evaluation of the programme in 2021, however, the results are not publicly available (Prognos, 2021[33]).

Part of the challenge with moving away from funding focused on delivering traditional education research projects is to do with public funders' low tolerance for initiatives that are deemed risky, as they may create reputational or political damage (Vincent-Lancrin, 2023[34]). If a public funder awards a grant to a research institute for a traditional education research project, they can be quite confident that the project will deliver the lengthy written outputs (e.g. journal articles) or dissemination events (e.g. conferences) that were promised in the proposal. Research institutes in OECD countries have been performing these tasks for decades. By contrast, if a public funding organisation funds larger and more ambitious projects, such as long-term research-practice partnerships, it may take much longer to demonstrate outcomes and they may not be as tangible. In the worst case, the partnership may fail or run into organisational problems, and produce very little. For example, research-practice partnerships that do not manage to establish the necessary levels of trust or support from their senior leadership may struggle to produce and/or use research (Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[7]). But the reality is that practitioners and policy makers rarely consult journals and reports when they need help to solve their problems; more often, they consult trusted colleagues (Tseng in (Bangs et al., 2022[2])). Published written outputs remain important for recording and communicating research findings, but they are not the mechanism through which research achieves impact. Funding programmes must ensure a genuine rebalancing towards more complex but impactful work in education that focuses less on the number of publications and more on the quality of relationships, partnership infrastructure, and capacity support for interpreting and using findings. This requires devoting a larger share of funds to higher-risk but higher-reward project formats (like partnership work). This would also offer greater opportunity for research institutes and other education actors to gain valuable experience working in more diverse teams, which over time reduces the chance of failure for such projects.

> **Funding organisations may want to reconsider how they conceptualise "risk" when it comes to successfully funding research. Even if the funded work has a high chance of being completed and producing the agreed-upon outputs, if the research does not have an impact and is not used, that is a rather low return on investment.**
>
> *– Tracey Burns, Chief Research Officer, National Center on Education and the Economy (United States)*

There is already a dense infrastructure of teams and departments mobilising knowledge

Most organisations that responded to the intermediaries' survey pointed to established teams or departments within the organisation that had a responsibility to mobilise knowledge (see two examples in Box 5.5). Funding for such teams or departments tends to have only general provisions as to how it is spent (e.g. implementing a mission statement) and covers organisational overheads (e.g. rent, management/administrative salaries, utilities). Intermediaries reported that they receive a diverse range of organisations' funding from membership fees, event fees, donations from private individuals and companies, local and national government grants, interest and returns on financial endowments, tuition fees, student accommodation fees, and income from educational technology products.

Box 5.5. Public knowledge mobilisation teams and departments

Further Education and Skills Service (SOLAS), Ireland

SOLAS (*An tSeirbhís Oideachais Leanúnaigh agus Scileanna*) was established in 2013 as the state agency that oversees the Further Education and Training sector in Ireland. In 2022, it had an annual budget of EUR 1,087.2 million (88% of which was direct grants to education and training providers). Activities are either fully funded by the Irish Government or co-funded with the European Union. SOLAS has over 200 employees and three knowledge mobilisation units:

- Skills & Labour Market Research Unit, which publishes research and reports on the further and higher education sector as well as other related sectors;
- Data Analytics Unit, which supports evidence-based decisions through, for instance, annual statistical reports;
- Strategy & Evaluation Unit, which co-ordinates the implementation of the Further Education and Training Strategy 2020-2024, conducts the programme of research and manages an EU-wide network.

National Institute of Youth and Popular Education (INJEP), France

INJEP (*Institut national de la jeunesse et l'education populaire*) is a nation-wide service of the Ministry of National Education and Youth. It was created in 2015 and had an annual budget of EUR 2.3 million in 2023 and a team of around 50 people. The organisation:

- positions itself as a broker, situated at the crossroads of research, policy and practice;
- acts as both an observatory, producing knowledge directly, and a centre of expertise on youth issues, state education, community life and sport;
- aims to contribute to improving knowledge in these areas through the production of statistics and analyses, observation, experimentation and evaluation.

Source: SOLAS (2022[35]), *Annual Report and Accounts*, The Further Education and Training Authority, Dublin, https://www.solas.ie/f/70398/x/0ba8eca526/solas_annual_report.pdf (accessed on 17 July 2024); INJEP (2023[36]), *Annual Report*, Ministry of Education and Youth, Paris, https://injep.fr/linstitut/rapports-dactivite/ (accessed on 17 July 2024).

The reporting of more general funding sources, as opposed to concrete programmes or project grants, could simply be a limitation of the dataset. However, it could also indicate that, in addition to bigger knowledge mobilisation funding initiatives (see Hayter (2024[1])), there is a significant amount of funding (and hence activity) to support evidence use in education that is being allocated as part of core operational tasks and activities. For policy makers this is both encouraging, as it expands the overall funding directed towards mobilising knowledge, and challenging, as decisions on how to co-ordinate resources to optimise knowledge mobilisation (even in public institutions) mainly falls outside the direct influence of ministries.

Larger programmes can provide important stability for intermediary efforts

In contrast to project funding, which tends to be shorter-term with very fixed goals and outputs, programme funding often covers higher costs incurred directly from the pursuit of medium- to long-term thematic objectives. These objectives may also be adjusted depending on emerging needs and system requirements.

Perhaps because of their scale and objectives, publicly funded knowledge mobilisation programmes (see Box 5.6 and the US case study of the Regional Education Laboratories and Comprehensive Centers in Chapter 4) tended to be reported more often in the intermediaries' survey compared to private initiatives. Examples of such programmes often used various approaches, including impact evaluation and co-production, to generate and mobilise knowledge.

Box 5.6. J-PAL Europe: A large programme funding knowledge mobilisation

J-PAL Europe leads the Innovation, Data and Experiments in Education (IDEE) programme in France as part of a consortium of six other research institutions.

- The programme has been funded for a period of eight years by (2021-2029) by the government via the French National Research agency (*l'Agence Nationale de la Recherche* (ANR)) as part of the 2010 "Investments of the Future" (*Investissements d'avenir*) programme.
- It seeks to develop experimental research in education and support the use of evidence by supporting numerous projects. For example, "*Bien joué* !" (well-played) is a mathematics game programme launched by the French Ministry of Education, which was evaluated with IDEE's support via a randomised controlled trial to analyse its impact on student performance.

Source: J-PAL Europe (n.d.[37]), *Bien joué !*, https://www.idee-education.fr/projetssoutenus/bien-jou%C3%A9-! (accessed on 17 July 2024).

Programmes are often implemented through a group of smaller projects or discrete tasks. For instance, Latvia uses European Structural Funds (ESF) for a co-financing programme to support participation in international large-scale assessments, such as the OECD's Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) and the International Association for the Evaluation of Educational Achievement (IEA)'s Trends in Mathematics and Science Study (TIMSS). As part of this co-financing programme, the Ministry of Education and Science allocates funding to smaller projects to perform secondary analysis and mobilisation of results to educational policy makers and practitioners in schools. Other examples of the source of programme funding given in the intermediaries' survey included campaign donations from private individuals and companies, as well as local and national government grants for specific initiatives.

What is the relationship between resources and intermediaries' satisfaction with knowledge mobilisation?

For knowledge mobilisation to be impactful, it needs to have appropriate levels of financial and human resources, allow sufficient time for engaging with research and have enough soft infrastructure (access to journals, databases, networks, etc.) to ensure access to high-quality knowledge. The intermediaries' survey explored respondents' perceptions of the adequacy of these four types of resources for knowledge mobilisation in policy and practice.

Adequacy of resources and satisfaction with available education research

The intermediaries' survey also asked intermediaries how satisfied they are with the accessibility, relevance and quality of education research, as well as how satisfied they are with the extent to which policy makers and practitioners use research and the ways in which they use it. This section discusses the statistical correlations between the adequacy of resources perceived by intermediaries and their levels of satisfaction.

> *The more adequate knowledge mobilisation resources are, the more satisfied intermediaries are with the characteristics of education research and with research use*

The more adequate resources are perceived to be (on average) to develop and support effective knowledge mobilisation in policy and practice, the more satisfied intermediaries are with education research in terms of its quality, accessibility and relevance. Similarly, there is a moderate positive relationship between the perceived adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation and intermediaries' satisfaction with the use of research (including the extent of research use and the ways in which it is used). This is true for both policy and practice.

This suggests that the adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation is a factor for the quality, accessibility and relevance of education research itself, as well as its use, although there are likely many other factors that also influence these relationships, and causality cannot be established. Importantly, these correlations do not mean that more resources will automatically solve all of the challenges related to knowledge mobilisation in education.

> *Satisfaction with the characteristics of education research is positively related to satisfaction with its use in policy and practice*

The more positive intermediaries' perception of the quality, accessibility and relevance of education research is, the more satisfied they are with the use of research both in policy and in practice. Accessibility and relevance are two aspects of education research that are necessary conditions for knowledge mobilisation and thus, just like for resources, this relationship is not surprising.

Despite strong evidence that quality, accessible and relevant education research – and adequate resources for its mobilisation – are basic conditions for its use, these conditions are far from being met in most education systems. This is, of course, partly related to different perceptions of adequacy. As outlined in Chapter 4, the ministries of education that responded to the policy survey generally reported more resource challenges compared to the organisations responding to the intermediaries' survey. However, there are two exceptions to this – more intermediaries than ministries reported: a lack of time for policy makers to access and engage with research, and a lack of financial resources for mobilising research in policy.

To close this perception gap and ensure that intermediary actors feel they have sufficient resources to support knowledge mobilisation, funders could involve different actors already in the design of funding

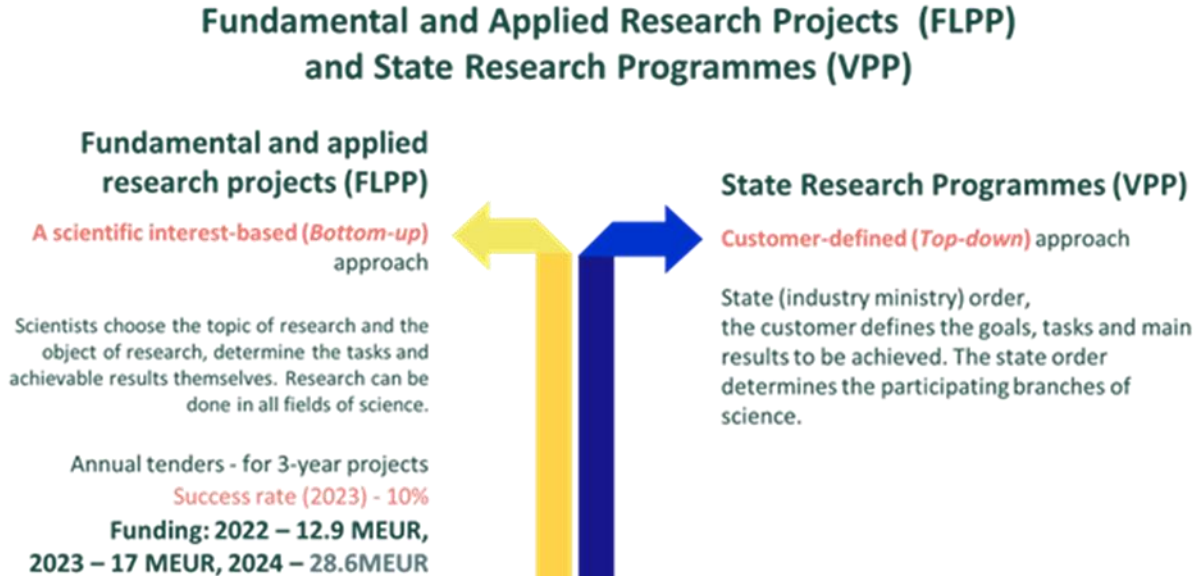
schemes, as showcased in the Latvia case study below. Intermediary actors can also work on ensuring diversified funding sources for their efforts, to generate a revenue stream with fewer administrative requirements for implementation compared to competitive public funds. As demonstrated in the Chile case study, this revenue stream is more easily reinvested in other areas of the organisation, such as staff training or public advocacy activities.

Case Study 1: A funding scheme for the co-creation of policy-relevant research in Latvia

There is a need for more policy-relevant research in many OECD countries (OECD, 2022[6]; OECD, 2023[20]). The Latvian Ministry of Education launched the State Research Programme in Education in 2023 to strengthen evidence-based decision making and to create new knowledge and practical solutions in education institutions, municipalities and at the national level. This funding programme, planned to run until 2026, aims to generate policy-relevant research.

Research project funding in Latvia consists of a bottom-up and a top-down funding mechanism (Figure 5.4). The former is a more traditional call for fundamental and applied research projects, and is based on scientific interest. The latter, the State Research Programme, is a funding scheme for policy-relevant research, in which the research themes are defined by the sectoral ministry in collaboration with the Ministry of Education and Science and relevant experts. State Research Programmes aim to support the Latvian government with research evidence on the most important issues for sustainability and development of the country.

Figure 5.4. Bottom-up and top-down funding schemes for education research in Latvia



Source: PowerPoint presentation by Latvian Ministry of Education during the qualitative interview of the OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education; see also Latvian Council of Science (2024[38]).

Collective programme design to build engagement and shared understanding

The framework for the programme was co-developed by several ministries, with the Ministry of Education playing a key role, alongside field experts (e.g. researchers, technology experts). They used insights from

international research, including OECD data and analyses, and had a series of dialogues about topical issues. This resulted in six themes for the programme: linguistically-diverse learning environments; building capacity of education actors to manage change and innovations; providing effective professional development for adults (including teachers); supporting the transition towards a new framework for academic careers in universities; civic participation of young people; and AI and technology-based teaching and learning.

The programme preparation involved ministry employees and researchers participating in the European Commission's Learning Lab training on policy impact evaluation. The dialogues and peer learning therein helped strengthen the relationship between the ministry and the research community.

Following the identification of relevant themes, the Council of Science published the calls for research proposals. The criteria for funding include: policy relevance, specification of the ways in which the research organisation will be collaborating with target groups (e.g. ministry, municipalities, schools) and a plan for piloting or testing the research results.

Evaluation of proposals and monitoring and appraisal of research

To ensure independent evaluation in a relatively small country with a small community of researchers and experts, the proposals are evaluated by international experts from the European Commission's database. Evaluation criteria include the relevance of proposals, research design and the research capacity of the team and the institution. The Ministry has set up a Monitoring Commission to review all research reports, involving both ministry employees and external experts specifically selected based on the research topic (typically the same who evaluated the proposal).

The mid-term (18 months) appraisal considers the procedural, administrative progress of the work, such as spending of funds, and the scientific quality of the research and its impact, including publications (both scientific and popular science publications) and public engagement events. Particular attention is given to policy relevance, the engagement of target groups and the applicability of findings in policy. Adjustments are proposed if necessary. Testing or piloting the results is also encouraged before reaching final conclusions. Importantly, this appraisal process is an occasion to discuss the findings with the target group (e.g. ministry employees) and serves to better integrate research results in the policy decisions.

Challenges and limitations

The planned three-year duration of the programme may be too short for collaborative research to bear fruit. Building trust among researchers and target users (e.g. policy makers in ministries, municipalities) and developing a shared understanding of the research and its goals takes time. This is necessary for the research to be truly collaborative and impactful (Schlicht-Schmälzle et al., 2024[7]).

While there have been examples of such programmes becoming long-term, stable mechanisms in Latvia, sustainability of funding for the State Research Programme beyond the three-year period has not yet been granted. Building long-term knowledge for policy and ensuring a permanent circulation of knowledge between researchers, policy makers and practitioners requires sustained funding.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

Despite the challenges, the funding schemes of Latvia have promising features for more effective knowledge mobilisation. The Ministry itself sees the following main benefits of the State Research Programme:

- The Ministry of Education receives policy recommendations on issues of their interest and policy priorities.

- Education co-designs programmes with other ministries and through this creates stronger linkages with economic and societal priorities. In addition, the Ministry of Education attracts funding for research from other ministries.
- Ministries become more aware of state-of-the-art scientific literature and build scientific literacy.
- The programme fosters larger interdisciplinary research projects.

In addition, the complementary bottom-up and top-down funding mechanisms ensure that policy-relevant research is generated, but at the same time, ensure that research does not become entirely policy-driven and there is still funding available for foundational research and science-driven investigations.

Some other countries have similar policy-driven research funding schemes, such as the Areas of Research Interest in both England and Ireland. Countries with similar schemes could learn from each other about how they strengthened policy-research partnerships through such schemes and how they overcome challenges. Countries that do not yet have such mechanisms can draw on these examples to create their own context-specific versions.

Case Study 2: Blended funding to increase impact in Chile

Fundación Educación 2020 (E2020) is a Chilean non-governmental organisation dedicated to improving education quality, equity and inclusiveness for children and young people in Chile. With a team of 27 employees, E2020 focuses on influencing public policies through data analysis and field projects while advocating for educational innovation. Central to its mission is knowledge mobilisation, with E2020 implementing research-based interventions in schools and collaborating with universities to support implementation and conduct evaluations.

The organisation's emphasis on monitoring ongoing public policies, and on systematising project experience and outcomes measurement through public data – in addition to its dedication to evidence-based interventions – makes it a key player in Chile's educational reform landscape. However, like many organisations engaging in knowledge mobilisation activities, E2020 faces significant challenges in securing funding, particularly for the evaluation of its work.

The TEP and TEPA projects: Leading programmes in the region

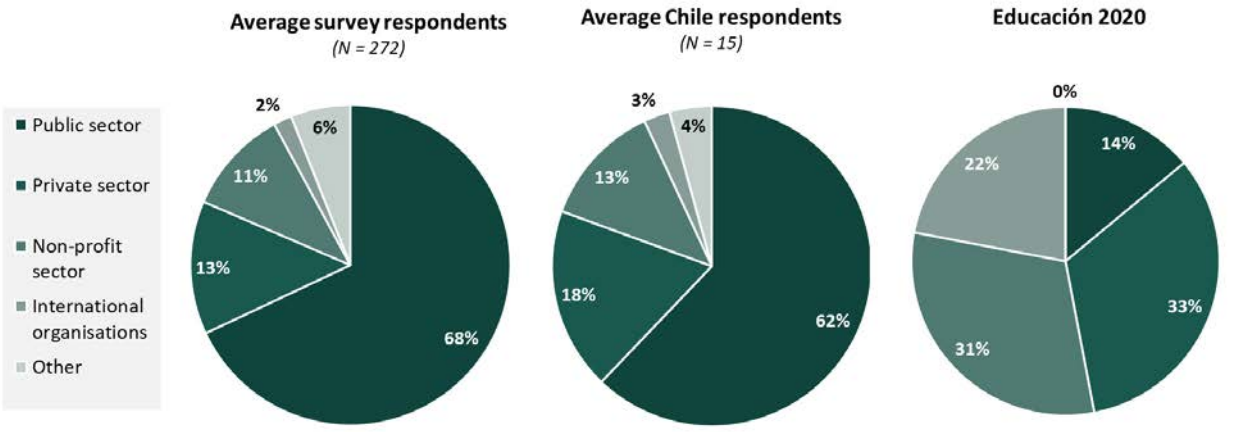
In recent years, a branch of E2020's national and international work has been centred on the peer-tutoring model. This involves a structured learning interaction between a tutor and a learner, fostering horizontal dialogue, respecting the learner's pace, and encouraging autonomy, expression/recognition of emotions and meta-cognition. Based on a 1990s Mexican policy model, the TEP (*Tutoría Entre Pares* in Spanish) project was piloted in Chile between 2016 and 2023, aiming to improve learning outcomes and reduce educational exclusion through peer tutoring. The project trained teachers and school leaders to change school culture by implementing peer-tutoring strategies, resulting in increased student attendance, decreased mistreatment, and improvements in student performance, especially among lower-performing students (Educación 2020, upcoming[39]; Educación 2020, 2022[40]).

Inspired by the success of TEP in Chile, and a similar experience in Colombia, E2020 launched the TEPA project (*Tutoría Entre Pares en América* in Spanish), which, to date, has focused on rural schools in Honduras, Nicaragua and Peru. TEPA integrates inclusive and intercultural approaches while promoting teacher professional development and increased student self-efficacy. While the TEP project had its focus in Chile, TEPA expanded this model regionally, proving its adaptability and scalability in diverse educational systems (Álvarez and Araneda, forthcoming[41]; Educación 2020, 2023[42]; Educación 2020, 2023[43]).

A unique funding model

According to the intermediaries' survey, E2020's funding landscape stands out as strikingly different from the average Chilean survey respondent (see Figure 5.5). While most organisations in Chile report receiving the majority of their funding from the public sector, E2020 relies heavily on the private and non-profit sectors. Despite the considerable challenges in securing adequate funding (see the Challenges and limitations subsection), this funding model offers several unique advantages.

Figure 5.5. Funding sources for E2020 and intermediary organisations in Chile



Notes: The survey asked respondents to indicate the percentage of their funding coming from the different sources. The "Other" category triggered a qualitative question and responses included fees for education associations and unions, interest on endowments and selling products or services.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/ituq0k

A funding model that includes significant funding from private sources comes with both opportunities and challenges. On the one hand, the variability of funds can undermine the organisation's financial sustainability, as its operational model depends on income generated through the provision of services – a revenue stream that may not always be predictable or financially feasible. On the other hand, while variable funds have notable drawbacks in terms of providing a reliable and consistent flow of income, when combined with multiple funding sources, they may also offer a flexibility to organisations that can help them to adapt to the changing needs of education actors.

Commercial activities, such as providing services to schools, school communities, and school administrators, can generate a revenue stream with fewer administrative requirements for implementation compared to competitive public funds. These resources can originate from public or private sources and often require applying through a public bidding process. However, once awarded, they can be used without seeking funders' permission to cover short-term funding gaps, which helps reduce dependence on public grant cycles. Additionally, any profits generated from commercial activities can be reinvested in other areas of the organisation, such as staff training or public advocacy activities.

Challenges and limitations

These external funds tend to operate on shorter-term financial cycles (e.g. yearly grants) and often show high variability (e.g. school communities purchasing the organisation's services). The reliance on short-

term funding cycles often leads to short-term projects, leaving E2020 with insufficient resources to evaluate long-term impact, which is essential for scaling up and improving the reach of its projects. The lack of appropriate funding for evaluating impact is a challenge noted by other intermediaries and researchers reliant on public funds as well. It appears the issue may lie more in the structure of the funding mechanisms, rather than in their source.

Typically, funding is allocated for either implementation or evaluation – rarely for both, and predominantly for the former. Impact evaluations, such as randomised controlled trials (RCTs), require large sample sizes and significant financial support, both of which are challenging to secure. Short-term funding cycles often force E2020 and similar organisations to rely on qualitative data, even though quantitative evidence is critical for demonstrating project efficacy and securing further support.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

E2020's story is not just one of innovation and impact but also of financial challenge and adaptation. Its experiences demonstrate the importance of sustainable and multi-source funding and the critical need for evaluation in education projects, offering valuable insights for organisations operating in similar contexts.

The diversification of funding sources has allowed E2020 to sustain its operations and projects – and even expand them to other contexts – but it also underscores the challenges of relying on short-term and variable funds in a system where public sector funding remains limited for certain actors. Other organisations may look to E2020's model of combining private, non-profit and international funding sources to ensure long-term viability.

E2020’s difficulties in securing adequate funding for both implementation and evaluation highlight the importance of designing more flexible and holistic funding mechanisms. Governments and international and private donors alike could play a more active role in providing longer-term funding that covers the full project cycle, ensuring that both implementation and rigorous evaluations are adequately resourced.

E2020’s success with its Peer Tutoring model suggests that international collaboration, tailored to local contexts, can lead to scalable solutions. Countries seeking to improve education quality through evidence-based interventions could consider adapting this model while ensuring that adequate funding is in place to evaluate and refine these initiatives.

Conclusion

This chapter explored the nature of funding and other resources for knowledge mobilisation. Although simply adding short-term dissemination tasks to the workload of staff with other long-term responsibilities may be more attractive financially, quality knowledge mobilisation costs money. Funding intended to produce relevant and accessible research is important but not sufficient by itself.

The intermediaries’ survey analysis showed that most funding is currently allocated to research institutes. Despite much rhetoric from policy makers, funders and researchers on collaborative and needs-led approaches to evidence use in education, the data indicate that this does not yet equate to money for other education actors (such as schools) to generate and use research. When it comes to funding organisations, an important question is how public and private funders might co-ordinate more proactively in terms of their needs, goals and funding programmes to try and maximise the impact of their funding.

There also needs to be serious consideration of funding more systematic innovation support services for researchers, schools and policy makers. There are evidence-based and long-standing examples for ambitious innovation schemes in STI policy that have lessons for the education sector. Some of the independent foundations that responded to the intermediaries’ survey fund knowledge mobilisation across a diverse array of actors, providing wrap-around support alongside funding and implementing a wide range

of education projects. More extensive schemes, including mobility schemes, are needed. These would combine financial support incentives for more diverse teams, as well as localised, targeted training, networking and innovation expertise, using local networks and offering specific lines of support to those trying to mobilise research at different stages. Reflecting on this also means thinking about how these programmes might need to be adapted for an education context.

Having dedicated departments and teams within research organisations, public bodies and education practice, who are trained and confident in building capacity and maintaining connections between actors, is also crucial. Encouragingly, respondents to the intermediaries' survey reported a dense infrastructure of teams, departments and programmes that aim to build capacity, relationships and improve evidence use. This is a solid foundation on which to build. When it comes to strengthening the impact of resources, involving various actors, including intermediaries, in the design of funding and incentive schemes would increase both their awareness of existing resources and the alignment of these to actual needs This might further increase the satisfaction of intermediaries with both the quality of education research and how policy makers and practitioners engage with it. A significant proportion of funding for knowledge mobilisation is likely directed through operational costs and human resources into teams and departments who may not even consider themselves as intermediaries. It is important to combine any additional resources with formal recognition of knowledge mobilisation as an integral part of educational improvement for all education organisations.

Reflection questions and activities

Identify the main funding sources (governmental, philanthropic, private or international) that support knowledge mobilisation in education within your system. Examine the key resourcing components – financial resources, human resources and soft infrastructure – that characterise these sources. Create a funding flowchart that maps out how resources move from funders to various organisations or initiatives, identifying key recipients and the types of knowledge mobilisation activities in which they engage.

Consider the following factors:

- the level of financial investment and the conditions tied to funding (e.g. flexibility, time constraints);
- the human resources available: their expertise, capacity for knowledge sharing, leadership roles, and development opportunities;
- how financial and human resources help or hinder the use of soft infrastructure;
- the alignment between funder priorities and recipient needs in terms of resources provided (e.g. financial, staff, infrastructure);
- mechanisms for ensuring the effective use of resources, including accountability structures and feedback loops between funders and recipients.

Discuss strengths and weaknesses in the map you drew up. What works well? What could be improved and how?

Improving the funding of knowledge mobilisation in education

- Where are there imbalances in resource distribution (e.g. underfunding in certain areas or over-reliance on certain types of funding for knowledge mobilisation)?
- How can funders and recipients work together to align financial, human and infrastructure resources more effectively?
- What long-term strategies could be put in place to ensure sustainable resourcing for knowledge mobilisation?
- Are there opportunities for funders to invest not only in projects but also in partnerships and building capacity (human and infrastructural) across recipient organisations?

How can partnerships between funders and recipients be strengthened to enhance the collective impact of knowledge mobilisation activities?

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Annex 5.A. Statistical correlations

The numbers in the table below indicate the Spearman correlation coefficient for a given variable

	Adequacy of resources for k.mob. in policy	Adequacy of resources for k.mob. in practice	Satisfaction with research use in policy	Satisfaction with research use in practice	Satisfaction with research
Adequacy of resources for k.mob. in policy					
Adequacy of resources for k.mob. in practice	0.67				
Satisfaction with research use in policy	0.39	0.38			
Satisfaction with research use in practice	0.29	0.37	0.50		
Satisfaction with research	0.45	0.45	0.43	0.46	

Note: All correlations are significant with a p value less than 0.001.

Adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation in policy: Average of four 5-point Likert scale variables that measure the extent to which respondents agreed with the statements: There are adequate 1. human resources; 2. financial resources; 3. time; 4. soft infrastructure to develop and support effective knowledge mobilisation activities in policy.

Adequacy of resources for knowledge mobilisation in practice: Average of four 5-point Likert scale variables that measure the extent to which respondents agreed with the statements: There are adequate 1. human resources; 2. financial resources; 3. time; 4. soft infrastructure to develop and support effective knowledge mobilisation activities in practice.

Satisfaction with research use in policy: Average of two 5-point Likert scale variables that measure the extent to which respondents are satisfied with 1. the extent to which policy makers use research in their work (how much); 2. the ways in which policy makers use research (how well).

Satisfaction with research use in practice: Average of two 5-point Likert scale variables that measure the extent to which respondents are satisfied with 1. the extent to which practitioners use research in their work (how much); 2. the ways in which practitioners use research (how well).

Satisfaction with research: Average of three 5-point Likert scale variables that measure the extent to which respondents are satisfied with the following characteristics of education research in their system overall: 1. the quality of education research (in terms of rigour, validity and reliability of the methods, data and findings); 2. the accessibility of education research (in terms of language, format and price) for practitioners, policy makers and other actors; 3. the relevance of education research for policy and practice (in terms of significance and practical value of research findings in addressing policy/practice questions).

6 Deep impact: Evaluating knowledge mobilisation activities

Melissa Mouthaan, OECD

Jordan Hill, OECD

Critical reflection is crucial for improving and learning from any initiative. This chapter assesses the extent to which knowledge mobilisation activities are monitored and evaluated by intermediaries, and how. It examines why intermediaries evaluate their work, as well as the barriers to monitoring and evaluation. It also enquires as to how intermediaries perceive the impact of their own activities. Finally, the chapter draws on two case studies in Germany and the United Kingdom (England) to explore what lessons there may be for other organisations that wish to implement or improve monitoring and evaluation methods to strengthen their efforts to mobilise research knowledge in education.

Key messages

Monitoring and evaluating knowledge mobilisation initiatives helps to ensure their quality and to build the knowledge base on what is effective in different contexts. Analysis of responses to the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education highlights the need for building a better understanding of the evaluation of knowledge mobilisation practices among intermediaries, and for promoting it as a more systematic and thoughtful practice.

- Currently, intermediaries tend to monitor or evaluate their knowledge mobilisation initiatives only sporadically. When they do, they often favour simple indicators, such as number of citations of a study or number of participants in an event, which do not give a full picture of impact.
- A substantial number of intermediaries are transparent about their lack of monitoring or evaluation practices. Lack of funding and lack of time were most often cited as the biggest barriers. Only a minority of respondents cited a lack of skills or knowledge in evaluation as a barrier.
- Among the activities in which they engage, organisations perceive linear mechanisms, such as conducting research and disseminating research, as being the most effective. This view is poorly aligned with the research literature on knowledge mobilisation that posits that linear mechanisms are necessary but not effective on their own.
- Supportive leadership, at the organisational level but also crucially at the system level, can help decide how much time and resources to allocate to monitoring or evaluation activities, and ensuring this is proportionate to the time and resources invested in the initiative itself.
- A focus on developing evaluative thinking is needed. This is a mindset of professional collective reflection on tasks and initiatives across intermediaries and the system, in addition to conducting and publishing more and better-quality evaluations where needed.
- It seems unlikely that the conceptual and empirical experimentation required to develop measurements for the complex social indicators of impact reported in the survey has been implemented at scale.

Introduction

Evaluation – i.e. the structured and objective assessment of an ongoing or completed initiative to determine the relevance and fulfilment of its objectives (OECD, 2020[1]) – is crucial for ensuring high-quality implementation because it allows organisations to learn and improve through critical reflection. In education, low levels of systematic policy and programme evaluation were noted almost three decades ago (OECD, 1997[2]), and many education systems continue to lack the regulation, funding and guidance required to support a system-wide culture of evaluation (Golden, 2020[3]). Gathering monitoring indicators is an important first step, which becomes evaluation when there is critical reflection on the data collected.

Despite a core aim of intermediary initiatives often being to close the gap between research and practice, a lack of evaluations is thought to be inhibiting the development of an international knowledge base on research use, perpetuating rather than closing this gap (Kislov et al., 2018[4]). In their review of almost two thousand initiatives worldwide, Oliver et al. (2022[5]) found that only 6% of these were evaluated. Most of these evaluations were conducted by researchers involved in the delivery of the initiatives, as opposed to independent evaluations, and were reports for funders, which lacked detail of activities and broader lessons that support knowledge mobilisation and transfer.

This situation is described by Oliver et al. (2022, p. 704[5]) as an “increasing mass of rudderless activity”, which can lead to wasted resources and fails to provide useful lessons for improving evidence use.

Although increasing evaluation activity in education could help resolve tensions between research and practice, which tend to arise when trying to scale up successful local pilot innovations (Golden, 2020[3]), such evaluation activity needs to be high-quality, independent where possible, and to try and distil actionable information for policy or practice.

This chapter analyses the results of the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (henceforth, the "intermediaries' survey"), which collected data about the knowledge mobilisation activities of 288 intermediary organisations in 34 countries to better understand how they are supporting research engagement (see Chapter 1, Box 1.1). Where appropriate, it compares these findings with data collected by the 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey (henceforth, the "policy survey"). This earlier survey collected data from 37 Ministries of Education in 29 countries to map knowledge mobilisation mechanisms, actors and challenges across education systems (see (OECD, 2022[6])).

This chapter seeks to answer the following three questions:

- To what extent and how do intermediaries monitor or evaluate their knowledge mobilisation activities?
- What are the main barriers to monitoring and evaluation among knowledge intermediaries?
- Which knowledge mobilisation activities do intermediaries perceive as the most and least impactful?

To what extent and how do intermediaries evaluate their knowledge mobilisation activities?

In the intermediaries' survey, respondents were asked about the extent to which they evaluate their knowledge mobilisation activities. At first glance, the results appear quite encouraging (Figure 6.1).

Monitoring and evaluation of knowledge mobilisation among intermediaries

Almost half of intermediaries report monitoring or evaluating their knowledge mobilisation activities

On average, 44% of respondents reported that they monitor or evaluate their work at least occasionally. Just under one-quarter reported that they monitor or evaluate most, or all, of their activities. At the same time, that still leaves a substantial number of intermediaries that are transparent about their lack of monitoring or evaluation practices, as shown in the expert quote below.

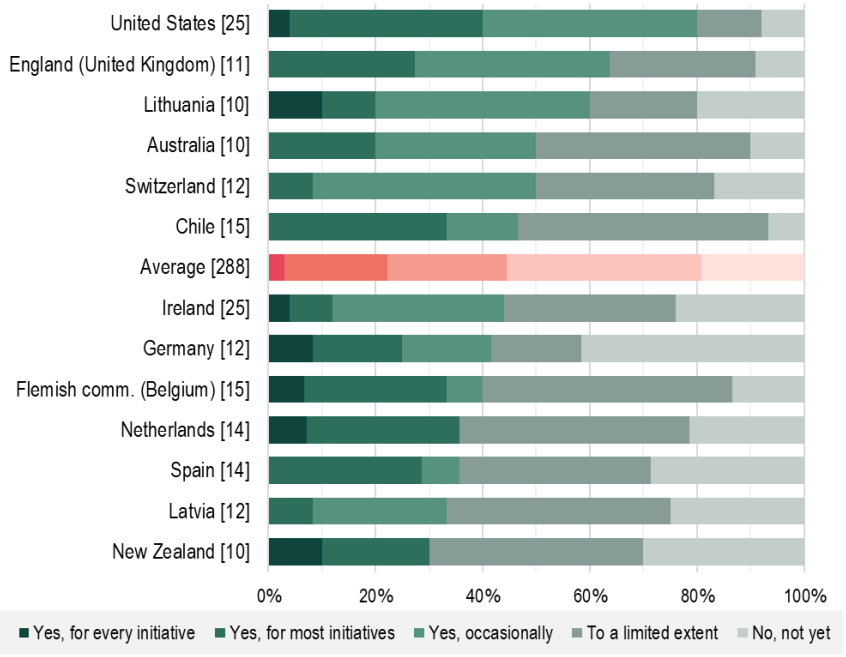
> **I would have expected the “no, not yet” responses to be a larger percentage. Having said this, the fact that around one-fifth said they don’t do anything, as opposed to “a limited extent” means we can be fairly confident that a significant minority are really doing zero monitoring and evaluation of their activities.**
>
> *– Tracey Burns, Chief Research Officer, National Center on Education and the Economy (United States)*

The position of knowledge intermediaries at what Kislov et al. call “the conflict-laden interface of policy making, management, science and professional practice” can politicise any evaluation attempts, as well as the outcomes (Kislov et al., 2018, p. 14[4]). A lack of motivation for evaluation can also stem from a fear of highlighting inadequacies (Golden, 2020[3]). Even if an evaluation is carried out, the findings are often not published, particularly if the results are considered negative (see Newman and Gough (2019[7])). One

analysis found the number of publicly available evaluations of knowledge mobilisation interventions in education to be just 3.5% (Boaz, Oliver and Hopkins, 2022[8]). Routinely publishing evaluations is important for building an international knowledge base to inform the wider knowledge mobilisation community (see case studies in this chapter). Publishing more evaluation results for external audiences may also encourage intermediaries to undertake more robust and rigorous evaluations, and to engage with peers regarding their findings. At the same time, publishing more evaluations could magnify publication biases, which are already a significant problem in education research evidence syntheses (see, for example (Ropovik, Adamkovic and Greger, 2021[9])) or could encourage performative evaluation exercises that do not give an accurate picture (see expert quote below).

> **Publishing results from evaluations that are not sufficiently independent bears a risk of being mere window dressing, rather than a true accountability mechanism.**
>
> *– Tia Loukkola, Head of Innovation & Measuring Progress Division, Directorate for Education and Skills, OECD*

Figure 6.1. Percentage of respondent organisations that report monitoring or evaluating the reach or impact of their knowledge mobilisation activities



Note: Responses were given on a five-point Likert scale. The number in parentheses after the country name is the number of respondents per country. Countries are listed in descending order in terms of the total percentage reporting a "yes, for every initiative", "yes, for most initiatives" and "yes, occasionally". Systems included here were selected because the sample size was 10 or more respondents. The average was calculated using all 288 respondents, regardless of country.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/j5zeym

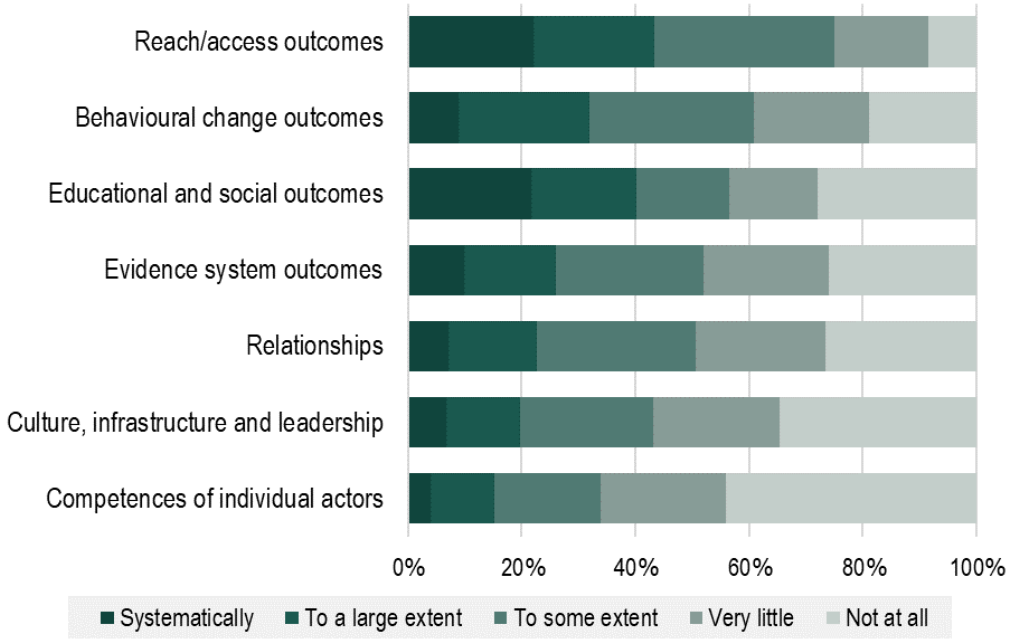
Respondents in different education systems reported different levels of monitoring and evaluation of knowledge mobilisation

When looking at the country-level data presented in Figure 6.1, there are important differences in the frequency with which respondents report that they evaluate their initiatives. For instance, only 8% of

respondents in the United States reported that they do not currently monitor or evaluate their knowledge mobilisation efforts at least occasionally. This figure was over 40% for respondents in Germany. This could be due to cross-cultural response biases (although cultural differences are not always discernible (He et al., 2014[10])). Another explanation might be that these differences are linked to the long-standing practice of public policy evaluation and the strong accountability culture in certain countries as opposed to others. For instance, in many European countries, the institutionalisation of evaluation culture came later than in Anglo-Saxon countries (OECD, 2020[1]). Differences in the data likely reflect a combination of factors around evaluation, linked to system- and organisation-level culture, capacity and resources. The small sample sizes of the intermediaries' survey do not allow for country-specific explanations in this case, and these factors warrant further research with larger sample sizes for each system.

Low levels of quality evaluations found in the research literature (e.g. (Boaz, Oliver and Hopkins, 2022[8]; Golden, 2020[3]; Gough, Sharples and Maidment, 2022[11])), suggest that the robustness of evaluations and the meaningfulness of the measurements may be a significant issue. Understanding how – and why – intermediaries evaluate their knowledge mobilisation initiatives can help to assess the culture of evaluation and identify ways to improve it. Respondent organisations that reported monitoring or evaluating their knowledge mobilisation activities occasionally or more often were asked which indicators they use (Figure 6.2).

Figure 6.2. Indicators used by intermediaries to measure the outcomes of their knowledge mobilisation activities



Note: Responses organised by total percentage of respondents reporting "systematically", "to a large extent" and "to some extent" to the question "To what extent does your organisation use the following indicators to measure the outcomes of its knowledge mobilisation activities?" Likert scale question. N = 227. Question conditional on having responded "Yes, occasionally", "Yes, in most initiatives" or "Yes, in every initiative" to the preceding question: "Does your organisation monitor or evaluate the reach or impact of its knowledge mobilisation activities?".
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/4tgvd7

Easy-to-measure indicators, such as reach and access, are widespread, while measurement of the impact of knowledge mobilisation on relationships and competencies is less common

The most commonly used indicators were reach and access indicators, such as the number of citations of a study or number of participants in an event. This is unsurprising given the relative ease with which this kind of data can be systematically and automatically gathered. Such types of data are required to measure the engagement of stakeholders with knowledge mobilisation activities and research outputs.

However, the use of these indicators to measure the outcomes of knowledge mobilisation activities does not provide any information on the nature and extent of this engagement, nor its impact, as noted by one expert (see below).

> **Respondents should be asked to clarify what measures they are using for some of these indicators. The indicators by themselves don't tell us much about what respondents understand for these categories, or why they responded in the way that they did.**
>
> *– Makito Yurita, Professor, National Institute for School Teachers and Staff Development (NITS), Japan*

It is notable that relatively few organisations reported using *indicators to monitor or evaluate relationships*, such as an enhanced number of relationships generated between actors, or the quality of relationships having improved. Among the organisations that reported being active at least to some extent in fostering relationships, most reported evaluating these activities at least to some extent (68%). Yet a significant percentage (42%) reported that they evaluated very little of these activities or not at all. There are a few possible reasons for this. First, relationship building may be seen not as a primary activity, but as a side effect of other activities. Secondly, indicators of impact such as increased quality of relationships among actors can be difficult to measure. Some methods of evaluating relationship building include gathering data from users of resources, network participants or seminar participants (see the German Institute for Adult Education case study in this chapter). It is also possible that the responses given in this category reflect the limitations of the intermediaries' survey (such as that examples of indicators given in the survey were insufficiently clear or concrete, or did not resonate with respondents).

In addition, the data show that *competency indicators* (for example policy makers' and practitioners' research literacy, or their attitudes towards research) are among the least commonly reported. Again, this is perhaps unsurprising if we consider that few intermediaries report conducting training or capacity building among their knowledge mobilisation activities (see Chapters 2 and 3). It may also reflect methodological challenges (see following quote).

> **Although measuring impact on competencies could be partially done through straightforward mechanisms, such as post-training surveys that seek to measure the knowledge gained, it may well be that intermediaries still perceive a lack of robust, simple and locally relevant instruments to measure competencies like research literacy and attitudes to research use.**
>
> *– Mark Rickinson, Associate Professor in the Faculty of Education at Monash University*

Behavioural change and educational and social outcomes are surprisingly highly-reported measures of impact, although this may be the result of conceptual unclarity

Some of the responses suggest there might not be a common understanding of what measures can be counted under the behavioural change and educational and social outcome indicators. As the quote below highlights, increased research use was moderately reported as a *behavioural change indicator*, but respondents may consider increased access to research (or, accessing of research) to be the equivalent of increased research use. Intermediary initiatives often target complex social outcomes such as student

learning, or behavioural outcomes such as research use. Gough, Sharples and Maidment (2022[11]) found, however, that the impact of intermediary activities is rarely measured in these areas.

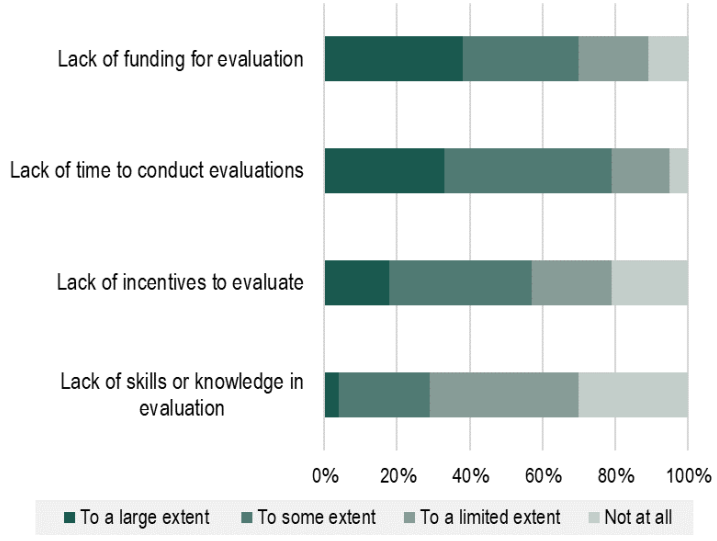
> **The fact that increased research use is frequently reported is surprising and respondents may have been biased in their response, equating research access with research use. But we know these are not the same thing.**
>
> *– Annika Wilmers, Senior Researcher, DPIF | Leibniz Institute for Research and Information in Education*

Overall, it is considered highly challenging to measure impact at the level of wider educational and social outcomes (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[12]; Lavis et al., 2003[13]). Yet, 40% of respondents indicated measuring *educational and social outcomes*, such as students' academic achievement, to a large extent or systematically as measures of the impact of their knowledge mobilisation activities. It might be that respondents were reporting measuring student achievement more generally, not as a result of knowledge mobilisation activities. Overall, it is possible that the development of the field of knowledge mobilisation (and evaluating its impact) is stymied by the lack of a common language or common principles about what "should" be measured among those working in the field. A possible future avenue for research would be to use the responses to further explore why organisations answered in the way that they did for some of these indicators.

What are the main barriers to monitoring and evaluation among knowledge intermediaries?

Systematic evaluation requires sufficient regulation, funding and guidance (Golden, 2020[3]). The intermediaries' survey asked respondents which barriers they faced in evaluating their knowledge mobilisation activities. The results can be seen in Figure 6.3 below.

Figure 6.3. Barriers to monitoring and evaluation of knowledge mobilisation activities reported by intermediaries



Note: Barriers are listed in descending order by percentage of respondents selecting "to a large extent" plus "to some extent".
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/vrtzam

Barriers and challenges

Lack of money and time are major barriers to evaluation, but not the only ones

Lack of funding and lack of time were more often seen as the biggest barriers. Only a minority of respondents saw a lack of skills or knowledge in evaluation as a barrier. This is worth remarking on, since there is relative consensus in the research literature that measuring the impact of knowledge mobilisation initiatives is methodologically very challenging (see (Davies, Powell and Nutley, 2015[14]; Ziam et al., 2024[15])). Either this is not the case for the respondents, or respondents did not have complex or long-term social impact measures in mind when considering this question. Incentives to evaluate do not seem to be a problem for around half of respondents, but for many others they were a challenge. Those who do not carry out any evaluation (n = 57) and those who evaluate a lot/systematically (n = 64) do not report markedly different barriers. The one exception relates to skills and knowledge: those who do not carry out evaluations tend to report that low levels of skills and knowledge are more of a barrier.

The open-ended responses of the intermediaries' survey provided some further insights into barriers to evaluation. For instance, in Japan, one respondent remarked that systematic evaluation beyond what is required by the monitoring authority is not part of the organisational culture. Another respondent from Norway noted that rigorous or systematic evaluation of research use is simply not part of their mandate. For some initiatives, it was simply seen as too soon to evaluate – either the organisation itself was newly established, or the project or programme was at an early stage of its work. This suggests that the picture on evaluating knowledge mobilisation could change rapidly within a few years, as these organisations and programmes progress in their activities.

Beyond evaluation, evaluative thinking is important for knowledge mobilisation

Evaluation is not just about performing resource-intensive methodologies, which might not be needed for every single initiative. It also means encouraging an organisational culture of evaluative thinking, which means having an organisational culture of continuous reflection and evidence-gathering, to foster a mindset of experimentation and calculated risk-taking (Earl and Timperley, 2015[16]). The open-ended responses of the intermediaries' survey pointed to challenges around evaluation culture that are commonly reflected in the research literature. For instance, a lack of organisational awareness, leadership and prioritisation around evaluation was identified as a challenge by some intermediaries. While specific evaluation methodologies are often performed by experts (see for example the Education Endowment Foundation case study in this chapter), evaluative thinking more generally is something that everyone can be involved in. The OECD Handbook for Innovative Learning Environments (2017[17]) outlines several ways that evaluative thinking may be engaged. For instance:

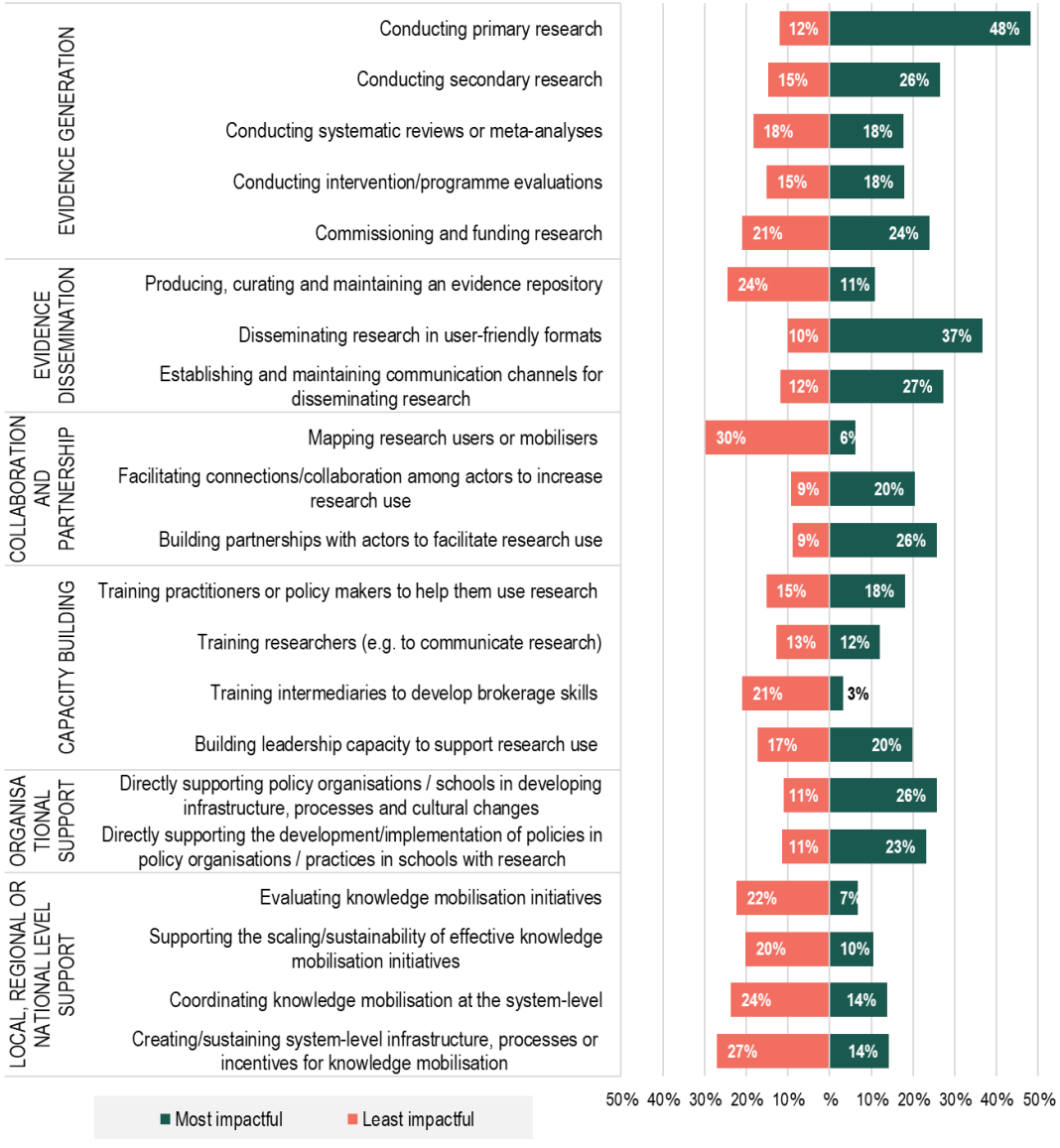
- by explicitly considering and/or revisiting the intention, roots, philosophy and expected impact of core activities;
- by involving stakeholders in the process of critical thinking about their activities;
- by developing a clear vision of the benefits of different evaluation questions and processes;
- by collaboratively planning evidence-gathering methods in advance to emphasise factors beyond simply the feasibility of its collection.

Considering the above points can help apply evaluative thinking across an organisation to develop a shared understanding of whether the planned monitoring data is fit-for-purpose and how it might be to be interpreted.

Which knowledge mobilisation activities are considered the most and least impactful?

Lacking comprehensive and robust evaluations, the next best information about the effectiveness of knowledge mobilisation activities is actors' perceptions of their effectiveness. The intermediaries' survey examined respondents' perceptions of most and least impactful or effective knowledge mobilisation activities (see Figure 6.4 and Figure 6.5).

Figure 6.4. Intermediaries' perception of which knowledge mobilisation initiatives they engage in are the most and least effective



Note: Responses to intermediaries' survey question: "From your perspective, which of the following types of activities have been the most effective/impactful in increasing policy makers'/practitioners' research engagement? Please respond with respect to your organisation's knowledge mobilisation activities." Respondents were able to select three "top 3" and three "bottom 3" activities.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

StatLink https://stat.link/ky0rju

Respondents were able to select three “top 3” and three “bottom 3” activities they deemed to be effective or not. The options proposed were the activities that the respondent reported to carry out at least “to some extent”, when reporting about its knowledge mobilisation activities (see Chapter 3 for full list). These activities pertain to generating, synthesising and communicating research products; fostering relationships between actors; and supporting other organisations in reinforcing research use. This section uses the conceptual framework for knowledge mobilisation introduced in Chapter 1, and further elaborated in Chapter 3, to discuss different types of intermediary activities.

Intermediaries' perceptions

Evidence generation and dissemination are perceived as the most impactful forms of knowledge mobilisation

Overall, among the knowledge mobilisation activities that they engage in, respondent organisations perceive conducting research and disseminating research as being the most effective. This is true also when disaggregating the data and comparing responses between: (1) groups of intermediaries that reported evaluating their knowledge mobilisation activities systematically with those that identified as evaluating these only “to some extent”; and (2) different types of organisations (see Figure 6.5 below). This may reflect their current portfolio of knowledge mobilisation activities, which for many actors consists of predominantly linear activities. It is possible that some respondents perceive other activities as effective but do not engage in these due to cost or practicalities. The view of many respondent intermediaries that linear mechanisms are the most effective (see Figure 6.4) is poorly aligned with the research literature on knowledge mobilisation that posits that linear mechanisms are required but not effective on their own (Campbell et al., 2017[18]; Gough, Thomas and Oliver, 2019[19]). It can also be that in many organisations, relational or systems mechanisms are rarely implemented alone, but are implemented in combination with, or as a follow-up to, linear ones. For example, a relational activity such as a workshop may be organised to disseminate research findings, where respondents may consider the main knowledge mobilisation activity to be the research produced and the workshop to be a complementary activity.

Partnership building is seen as impactful, but training researchers and intermediaries is not

Building partnerships to facilitate research use was considered impactful by many respondents. This suggests that relationship building is considered important, but still comparatively less impactful than evidence generation and dissemination. The literature nonetheless places emphasis on the importance of relational knowledge mobilisation activities (Best and Holmes, 2010[20]; Langer, Tripney and Gough, 2016[21]). Overall, this perhaps similarly suggests that intermediaries acknowledge the importance of relationship building but may still often view it as a secondary rather than a primary knowledge mobilisation activity.

Partnerships are also only effective if partners have the necessary competencies to engage in high-quality interactions about research and its use. However, training researchers and intermediaries (to develop these skills) was not seen as impactful. Analysis of the intermediaries' survey in Chapter 3 also showed that few intermediaries are engaged in offering such learning opportunities to other actors in their systems. However, in the policy survey, over half of respondent systems perceived policy makers and practitioners to lack the skills needed to use research well (Hill and Torres, 2023[22]). This suggests that there is a discrepancy between perceived needs for capacity building and effective offers to address these. Yet, there is robust research evidence about effective forms of teachers' continuous professional learning. One-off training sessions for individuals tend to be less effective, as opposed to needs-based, long term, collective professional development (Darling-Hammond, Hyler and Gardner, 2017[23]). It is possible that this evidence has not yet been transferred to knowledge mobilisation. The policy survey also showed that teachers lack learning opportunities to develop their research literacy and research use skills; the same

might be true for policy makers. Capacity building can be embedded in long term organisational support (e.g. directly supporting schools/policy organisations to use research).

To ensure that partnership building is strategic, mapping research users and mobilisers would be a natural first step. This activity, however, was not seen as impactful. It might be that such a mapping activity is seen as a component of knowledge mobilisation, but is not in itself what respondents see as making an initiative impactful (see United Kingdom case study in Chapter 3).

Intermediaries do not see the impact of supporting knowledge mobilisation in organisations and the system

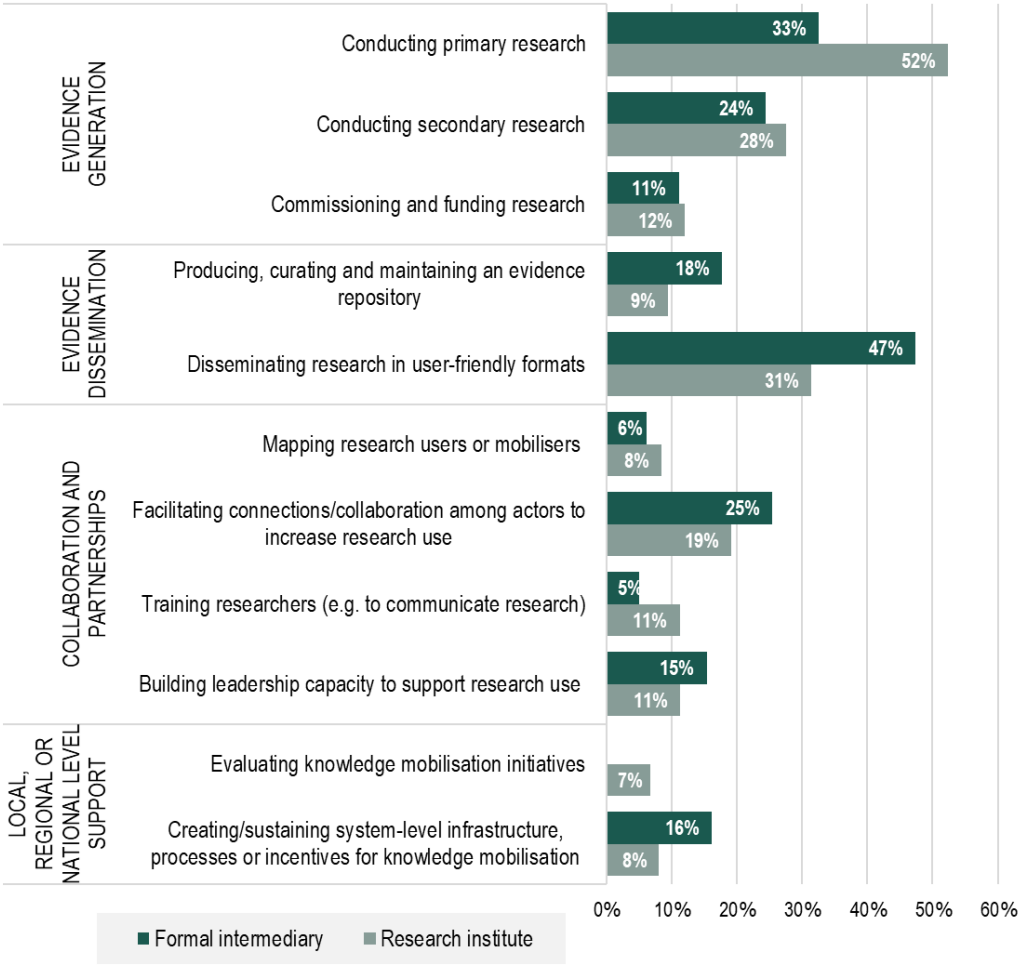
Mechanisms such as evaluating and co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level were frequently selected as low-impact knowledge mobilisation activities. In some cases, respondents might consider that certain activities are poorly matched to their organisation's mission, profile and skillset. Even among organisations that evaluate their knowledge mobilisation at least to some extent, evaluation was not frequently selected as a high-impact activity. Evaluating initiatives in terms of their effectiveness was selected as a "top 3" effective activity by 10 respondent organisations, and a "bottom 3" effective activity by 33 respondents. Overall, respondents may be indicating that evaluation of knowledge mobilisation is less effective than other knowledge mobilisation activities – its effectiveness might be indirect by increasing the effectiveness of other activities. Inevitably, many intermediaries work in contexts of finite resources and have to make decisions on how to spend resources effectively. This may lead them to spend on knowledge mobilisation activities that they perceive to have direct impact, versus evaluation, which has longer-term gains.

What matters to research institutions is evidence generation

Research institutions (RIs) were one of the types of organisations most represented among respondents. Both RIs and other types of actors considered conducting primary research and research dissemination to be the most effective knowledge mobilisation activities (Figure 6.5). Among *linear mechanisms*, respondents from RIs considered maintaining an evidence repository, and conducting systematic reviews (19% of respondent RIs) to be among the lowest-impact activities. One possible interpretation is that organisations perceive the activities they most often conduct as being the most effective, and areas where they are less active as being less effective. They may undertake certain activities because they have a prior expectation that these activities are particularly effective, or consider that certain activities are more (or less) well-suited to them given their organisational profile. Activities that are resource-intensive, such as synthesising evidence in a systematic review, may also lead intermediaries to more critically assess whether such activities are impactful enough given the resources invested.

Respondents from RIs may also consider impact on their professional careers. Research has shown that there are insufficient career-related incentives for academic researchers to undertake impact-related activities such as user engagement and co-design of research agendas (Upton, Vallance and Goddard, 2014[24]), instead incentivising them to prioritise primary research and traditional dissemination in academic journals. Systematic reviews are also not always considered by academic researchers to be a "valid piece of research" when compared to primary research (Smith and Stewart, 2017[25]), while some models of policy impact have been criticised for inadvertently encouraging an individualistic approach wherein researchers primarily link impact to their own underpinning research rather than to a wider body of research knowledge or research syntheses (Boswell, Smith and Davies, 2022[26]). Yet, systematic reviews published in journals are often among the most highly-cited studies (Aksnes and Aagaard, 2021[27]; Chaignon, Docampo and Egret, 2023[28]). This implies that synthesis – while resource-intensive – has potential to be a high-impact activity in several ways if done well.

Figure 6.5. Perceptions of high-impact knowledge mobilisation activities, by organisational profile



Note: The data show select knowledge mobilisation activities perceived by the respondents as being high impact, with data disaggregated for two organisation types. Responses to the intermediaries' survey question: "From your perspective, which of the following types of activities have been the most effective/impactful in increasing policy makers'/practitioners' research engagement? Please respond with respect to your organisation's knowledge mobilisation activities." Respondents were able to select three "top 3" activities.
Source: OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education data, 2023.

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Impact is based on a combination of knowledge mobilisation activities

Overall, the activities intermediaries view as the most impactful are often primarily linear. The data presented also prompt the question of whether there is an ideal balance between linear, relational and systems mechanisms in a system, and whether the balance between these types of knowledge mobilisation activities needs to be perfectly equal. It may indeed be effective for the majority of intermediaries in a system to be performing linear knowledge mobilisation mechanisms, with a smaller number undertaking relational activities, and an even smaller number undertaking systems activities. For example, it may be only one intermediary (or a small number of intermediaries) co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at the system level across different actors. In addition, it appears that effective initiatives are often not focused on single activities, but are complementary to each other (for example, relationship building is combined with capacity building). An important limitation of the survey question explored in this section is that it is not able to capture the joint effectiveness of some activities.

How can evaluation of knowledge mobilisation be strengthened?

High-quality, in-depth evaluation activities are conceptually and methodologically challenging. This is particularly true for measuring impact at the level of wider social outcomes, both in education and other fields. Oliver et al. (2022[5]) were unable to find a single robust evaluation which convincingly demonstrated evidence use or the impacts of evidence use on social outcomes. A big reason for this is simply that measuring these outcomes is difficult. For example, in education practice, whether or not research use has increased could be a measure of success, but such "natural experiments" would provide correlational, rather than causal, data (Gough, Sharples and Maidment, 2022[11]). When it comes to policy, it is also difficult to disentangle the impacts of a specific policy from other policies which operate in parallel, or which would have occurred as a natural consequence of the contextual situation (Golden, 2020[3]). Although there are limits to what can be expected by applying current evaluation methods to monitoring data in terms of causal links, this does not mean they are not useful. Reflecting on how impact might be achieved in an intervention by developing a theory of change[1] can still be an instructive exercise. Such an approach could rely on realist evaluation methods (e.g. (Pawson and Tilley, 1997[29])) to construct a theory-based approach to understanding and investigating impact. The ESRC Education Research Programme described in Chapter 3 is an example of how deep engagement with an initiative's theory of change to plan impact supports the success of the initiative. In that sense, these long-term complex impact indicators can offer formative rather than summative insights.

Strengthening evaluation of knowledge mobilisation is about more than just increasing measurement and quantification of impacts using resource-intensive methods (although this is essential for some initiatives), it is about building an evaluation mindset within education organisations. This requires training for intermediaries and clarifying key evaluation terms and enhancing shared understanding of what is meant by evaluation, so that a culture of evaluative thinking can become better established across organisations. It also involves learning about the processes of continuous reflection and evidence-gathering, which can foster a mindset of experimentation and calculated risk-taking. Eventually, this kind of knowledge will help organisations who have to make difficult decisions about which approach to take for a given activity, for instance choosing between self-evaluation and external evaluation. Such structured and reflective approaches could be more commonplace, and the training needed for intermediaries appears to be lacking across OECD systems generally (see Chapter 3) although there are isolated examples. One such example is the European Commission's Learning Lab on Investing in Quality Education and Training (European Commission, n.d.[30]). This lab offers capacity building on policy evaluation, primarily to public intermediaries, such as departments within ministries of education. The literature offers insights into other aspects that intermediaries might consider to promote a mindset of evaluative thinking in their organisations and work towards achieving a better shared understanding among themselves of purposes, methods and measures of evaluation. Table 6.1 outlines a few potential considerations.

Table 6.1. Pillars and considerations to design and improve intermediary efforts

Pillars	Considerations	Guiding questions
Aims and needs analysis	Analysis of the evidence ecosystem Specific aims Users and beneficiaries	What is the relationship between research use and production? Which parts of the current evidence ecosystem does the intermediary wish to change? What does it wish to change? Who will use and/or benefit from the intermediary's work?
Awareness of the wider system	Analysis of the wider system System-level co-ordination Relationships	What is the relationship between the intermediary and the infrastructure for its work? Who co-ordinates the evidence ecosystem and the wider systems? What relationships exist between different actors? Where are the feedback loops, information channels and points of influence in the system?

Pillars	Considerations	Guiding questions
Methods and Theory of Change (ToC)	Theory of Change Fitness for purpose and effectiveness	What methods are used? What is the causal chain by which these achieve the interim and ultimate aims of the intermediary? Why are the methods and ToC appropriate and effective?
Evidence standards and evaluation	Using credible evidence Rigorous evaluation and evidence of effect Strategic development	Is the intermediary transparent, consistent and clear about the methods and criteria for making evidence claims? How does it meet its aims in terms of the planned outcomes? How does it use evaluations to develop work overtime?
Evidence use standards	Use of research-based frameworks Organisational culture, relationships, resources and infrastructure	What is appropriate research evidence in different contexts? What does thoughtful engagement and implementation look like? What might quality research use result in?

Note: A Theory of Change is an evidence-based rationale that builds a causal analysis to explain how a set of activities and outputs are expected to lead to a specific change.
Source: Adapted from Gough, Sharples and Maidment (2022[11]), "Evidence on evidence-informed policy and practice", in *Who Cares about Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?: Strengthening Research Engagement*, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/5ee7de7c-en; Rickinson et al. (2022[31]), Rickinson, M. et al. (2022), "Using research well in educational practice", in *Who Cares about Using Education Research in Policy and Practice?: Strengthening Research Engagement*, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/65aac033-en; Golden (2020[3]), "Education policy evaluation: Surveying the OECD landscape", *OECD Education Working Papers*, No. 236, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/9f127490-en.

Focusing on the incentives for conducting evaluation is crucial when trying to strengthen approaches. For some intermediaries, evaluation may simply be seen as an accountability mechanism, such as when it is required by a funder (as found by (Oliver et al., 2022[5])). Evaluation done for accountability purposes risks becoming a tick-box exercise, where monitoring data is not used for critical reflection and findings are not integrated into organisational thinking to improve knowledge mobilisation practices. This highlights that it is crucial to capture what people understand by evaluation; what they do it for; and who they do it for. In particular, understanding if and how evaluation outcomes are subsequently used by the intermediary would help to illustrate these motivations. In many cases, lack of funding may prevent organisations from undertaking evaluation of their activities, even when evaluation is otherwise recognised and acknowledged to be valuable. In which case, increasing the percentage of funding earmarked specifically for evaluation may ease some of these perceived pressures, as long as it does not draw too many resources away from the implementation of a given activity. To date, little research has been done on how evaluation data and evidence is used to inform education policy, if it is at all (see Chapter 2). Similar research focused on intermediaries is likely to be equally, if not more, rare.

A further important consideration is whether these activities can be implemented in a way that goes beyond increasing the effectiveness of intermediaries' knowledge mobilisation activities and could also help to build a cumulative evidence base on knowledge mobilisation. This chapter now turns to two case studies of such implementation to understand how this has been done.

Case Study 1: An organisation-wide approach to the monitoring and evaluation of knowledge mobilisation in adult education in Germany

The German Institute for Adult Education (*Deutsches Institut für Erwachsenenbildung* (DIE)) is a research institution of the Leibniz Association located in Bonn, Germany. The Leibniz Association is a union of German non-university research institutes from various disciplines. The institute is funded by the Federal Government and German States to conduct research in the field of adult teaching and learning, continuing education programmes and institutions, as well as on the political and institutional contexts of lifelong learning. This case study is informed by a group interview carried out by the OECD on 20 June 2024 and

analyses the role of evaluation in the knowledge mobilisation activities of the DIE and, in particular, evaluation of the EULE (*Entwicklung einer webbasierten Lernumgebung für Weiterbildung, Kompetenzerwerb und Professionalisierung von Lehrenden der Erwachsenenbildung* – Open web-based learning space for continuing professional development of adult educators*)* learning platform.

Evaluation of transfer activities at the DIE

As seen in Figure 6.1, German respondents often reported that they did not evaluate their knowledge mobilisation initiatives. The DIE, however, did report that it occasionally carries out evaluations of its work. Unlike many similar institutes in Germany, the DIE has a dedicated knowledge transfer department, which co-ordinates monitoring, reflection and conceptual work on knowledge mobilisation through a transfer strategy (Table 6.2). The strategy itself contains a logic model,[2] commonly applied in monitoring and evaluation. This model allows the strategy to differentiate between outputs (performance), outcomes (completed transfer) and impact (successful transfer) indicators. In doing so, the strategy acknowledges that access to DIE materials by policy makers and practitioners does not necessarily equal use of these materials.

As outlined in the strategy, the DIE systematically collects quantitative data on performance and use of resources. When it comes to impact data, this is mainly qualitative and collected through examples from users. For instance, different departments in the DIE maintain contact with practitioners and collect data and good practices of how knowledge learned through DIE activities is applied in practitioners' contexts. For the most part, the Knowledge Transfer department conducts internal monitoring and evaluation of DIE activities and does not publish this information. However, some departments do publish studies on knowledge mobilisation topics that have evaluative value for DIE. For example, the System & Politics department has carried out a peer-reviewed study analysing perception and use of data from continuing education statistics, including DIE statistics, by political actors (Widany and Gerhards, 2022[32]). The published studies are not evaluations of the specific impact of the DIE per se, rather they tackle knowledge mobilisation from the broader perspective, drawing on the experiences of the DIE.

Table 6.2. Monitoring indicators of the DIE Transfer Strategy

Activity	Output (Performance)	Outcome (Completed transfer)	Impact (Successful transfer)
DIE research	Lectures and articles in non-academic discourse	Use frequency and scope as measured by the number of downloads and participants in events	Use of data, models, arguments, agenda setting, consultancy requests/reviews
Information infrastructures (book series, magazines, information portals)	Number of new publications or portal content elements	Use frequency and scope as measured by the number of downloads, page views, visitors, subscriptions	Proven learning success and/or skills increases
Innovations and implementations (e.g., toolkits, competency frameworks, learning platforms)	Number of sign-ups/consultations/users. Lectures, seminars, new developments.	Number of active partners, number of applications for validations and certifications. Number of active users and frequency of use. Number of downloads.	Training activities triggered by validation and certification. Inclusion of outputs in quality standards for adult educators.
Social media	Number of posts	Number of follows and fans	Number of likes and retweets
Monitoring and evaluation	**Systematic**	**Systematic**	**Exemplary**

Note: The DIE uses the term "knowledge transfer" to refer to its activities, although their transfer concept goes beyond linear dissemination of research and more closely resembles the concept of knowledge mobilisation as outlined in the research literature.
Source: Adapted from DIE (2024[33]), DIE (2024), *Knowledge Transfer at the DIE*, Deutsches Institut für Erwachsenenbildung (German Institute for Adult Education), Bonn, https://www.die-bonn.de/docs/Knowledge%20Transfer_2024_07.pdf (accessed on 25 October 2024).

Evaluation and impact through the EULE platform

The EULE is a resource of DIE. It is an open, free self-study platform funded by the German Federal Ministry of Education and Research (BMBF) to support the professionalisation of adult educators through 75 learning pathways. The learning pathways are constructed using research literature, and cover topics such as student feedback and motivation, digital education, time management and lesson design. Practitioners can use the EULE platform to gain relevant and research-based knowledge for their professional development.

The EULE learning area was developed using an iterative, design-based approach. This was done with the aim of continuously monitoring the quality of the content and technical implementation along three research strands:

- Formative evaluation through regular surveys and usability studies: Emphasis was placed on achieving satisfaction among the target group (adult education teachers) with regards to the topics, presentation of content and relevance of the guidance provided.
- Impact-testing: Through three intervention studies, after completion of the learning paths, the knowledge, skills and use of competencies in everyday teaching was examined.
- Transfer-securing implementation studies: Surveys and user tests draw in constant feedback from continuing education providers, to monitor how they integrate the learning pathways into the portfolio of training they provide to teachers of adult education. This allows needs-based support to supplement and enrich the courses provided by the continuing education providers.

These three strands were complemented with an independent evaluation of the EULE, which was carried out in 2018-2019 by a researcher in the adult education/further education department of the Institute for Educational Science at the Eberhard Karls University of Tübingen, and published in the professional publication *Adult Education* (*Erwachsenenbildung*) (Schöb, 2020[34]). The evaluation had a small but approximately representative sample of 34 German adult educators who used the platform, and combined data with qualitative expert interviews with six individuals (Box 6.1).

Box 6.1. Independent evaluation of the EULE

The evaluation focused on one EULE learning pathway, “Enabling self-directed learning”, and took the form of a before-and-after study, which examined the effect of the EULE on the teaching practices of the participants in terms of their ability to use the knowledge contained in the platform learning pathway.

To measure change in teaching practice:

- Participants were video-recorded during their teaching time.
- Teaching actions were analysed using an observation sheet that helped estimate the situational appropriateness of the actions (on a four-stage scale from 1 = appropriate to 4 = not appropriate).

The evaluation concluded that the course had brought about a change in everyday teaching. Study participants succeeded in linking the training content directly with their teaching practice and integrating what they had learned into their actions. The programme was found to be suitable to the learning requirements of teachers.

Weaker areas included a lack of socially shared learning in the EULE learning area, which was focused on individual study. Furthermore, the evaluation provided only a limited understanding of how the effects

on the participating teachers are related to their educational backgrounds and the length of their teaching career.

Source: Schöb (2020[34]), "Transfer effect as a quality feature of digital learning opportunities for adult educators: A study on measurability and relevance [Transferwirkung als Qualitätsmerkmal digitaler Lernangebote für ErwachsenenbildnerInnen]. Eine Untersuchung zur Messbarkeit", *Magazine erwachsenenbildung.at. The specialist medium for research, practice and discourse [Das Fachmedium für Forschung, Praxis und Diskurs]* 40, https://erwachsenenbildung.at/magazin/20-40/meb20-40.pdf.

Challenges and limitations

Through their approach, the DIE has been able to identify several challenges and limitations to knowledge mobilisation and its evaluation. A key challenge involves the difficulty of acquiring new, relevant target groups of potential research users beyond those that are already well-known. For example, there are many companies providing vocational and continuing education resources and materials, but they are for the most part not involved in DIEs network. This makes it difficult to gather information on how and why these companies may be engaging with DIE outputs.

Furthermore, problems relating to the low levels of generalisability of much education research makes designing a knowledge mobilisation platform such as EULE more challenging. The learning materials and resources need to be very tailored, which makes it resource-intensive to produce content for different parts of adult education. Part of the solution may be to plan in a way that avoids an artificial distinction between research and knowledge mobilisation. The DIE calls this planning approach "application orientated basic research" (DIE, 2024[33]). Over time, this may help orientate the DIE towards carrying out more high-quality control studies that aim to understand how the materials are used by different types of groups in different settings.

At the level of the academic system, a major challenge to the work of the DIE is the emphasis placed by the academic career model on peer-reviewed articles and highly ranked academic journals, to the detriment of other forms of research impact. This academic career model produces a very high volume of research content from a large number of actors, making it difficult to know how to focus potential research users' attention on any specific output. To overcome this challenge, the DIE has begun to use review methods such as meta-analyses, critical reviews, systematic reviews and rapid reviews, although the resources required to conduct these are significant. Additionally, legal structures in German academia place a time limit on how long an academic is permitted to conduct research without a long-term contract. Those with short-term contracts are mostly part-time and once their contracts finish it is very difficult to get a long-term contract. This not only means that accumulating and sustaining research knowledge is difficult but also that training researchers in evaluative thinking regarding their knowledge mobilisation requires significant resources, as there is often much staff turnover.

Although the DIE collects qualitative evaluation data through selected examples of impact, these are self-reported and not compared with any counterfactual. In the aforementioned evaluation of EULE, the methodology did not rely on self-reported data, but the method used was time-consuming and resource-intensive to develop. For example, designing the evaluation protocol and watching all the videos of the practitioners who participated in the external evaluation (Schöb, 2020[34]) to see how they were implementing the content. To streamline this process, it would be useful if there was a more developed evidence base on evaluating knowledge mobilisation.

The indicators systematically collected by the DIE are mainly in line with what is reported in the chapter (i.e. they focus on reach and access). Although the positive independent evaluation captured behavioural and skills indicators, these were specific to one learning pathway in the EULE evaluation and are not systematically collected at the organisational level. Behavioural indicators are receiving increasing attention, but still require significant methodological development.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

A lack of time and funding for monitoring and evaluation can be overcome by ensuring that responsibility for the task is spread evenly across departments. While the DIE has a dedicated knowledge mobilisation unit, which serves as a focal point for strategic evaluation planning to maximise the use of resources, the responsibility remains shared across the organisation. Having such dedicated knowledge mobilisation units can be hugely beneficial for research institutes, but needs to be combined with a transversal approach where all knowledge-producing departments are aware of and strategically use their mobilisation functions.

When it comes to evaluating impact, this DIE case study shows that, although it may not be feasible for intermediary organisations to gather behavioural indicators on the same scale as reach and access indicators, there is still value in using more experimental and quasi-experimental control studies to understand how knowledge mobilisation materials are used from different types of groups in different settings.

Case Study 2: Impact evaluation of a regional campaign to scale up evidence use in the United Kingdom (England)

The Education Endowment Foundation (EEF) is a UK charity established in 2011 that aims to improve the educational attainment of disadvantaged pupils. Its activities include reviewing and summarising the best available evidence on teaching and learning, and presenting this in accessible formats; funding independent evaluations of programmes; and supporting policy and practice communities to make use of research evidence.

In 2015, the EEF launched a national campaign of presentations; social, print and broadcast media; direct communications to schools; and meetings with policy stakeholders to scale up the use of the guidance report: “Making best use of Teaching Assistants”. This report gave seven actionable recommendations for schools (Education Endowment Foundation, 2018[35]) concerning the deployment of Teaching Assistants (TAs). TAs comprise over one-quarter of the workforce in mainstream schools in England. They are often used as an informal instructional resource for pupils most in need of additional support, but this kind of deployment is not associated with improvement in student learning and can even be harmful. Some of the EEF’s early trials showed positive impacts when TAs delivered structured interventions. This suggested that changing the teaching practices of TAs could go a long way to improving outcomes with limited additional cost. The study found that decisions made by school leaders and teachers regarding the deployment and preparation of TAs had significant influence over the impact of TA support. Ultimately, these findings led to the decision to produce the aforementioned guidance report.

In addition to the nation-wide campaign, the EEF ran two regional scale-up pilot campaigns in England (South & West Yorkshire and Lincolnshire), which aimed to support the development of evidence-informed TA practices at a regional level. The South & West Yorkshire campaign involved commissioning advocacy providers to deliver training and support for schools during the 2015/16 academic year, and was the subject of an impact evaluation. An impact evaluation is a study that provides information about the observed changes or “impacts” produced by an intervention and aims to identify the cause(s) of those changes. Overall, the cumulative cost for the South & West Yorkshire campaign evaluation was just under GBP 100 000. This included set up and planning; piloting of incentivising guidance materials take-up; implementation and reporting costs.

Impact evaluation of the South & West Yorkshire pilot programme

Although the preparatory and follow-up work took around three years, the bulk of the South & West Yorkshire pilot programme ran for around one year. The scale-up pilots took a co-ordinated approach with

the EEF working as a system-level broker whose role was to identify, fund and train a diverse group of influential local education advocacy providers (e.g. universities, schools, teacher trainers). These advocacy providers acted as local intermediaries to support schools to embed the TA evidence synthesis into their teaching practices. The campaign worked with around 480 schools and recruited advocacy providers in seven local authorities.

Box 6.2. Synthetic control method

Given that the treatment group was non-random, the effects of the intervention could not be analysed using a randomised controlled trial. Instead, the EEF used "synthetic control" methods, which were pioneered to examine the effects of interventions affecting large geographic areas. The synthetic control method was used to construct a control group by weighting other aggregate units (different local authorities) for the treated group (South & West Yorkshire) over the pre-treatment phase (all years up to 2014/15). The difference between the synthetic control and the treatment group in the post-treatment phase represents the estimated impact of the intervention.

The impact evaluation in South & West Yorkshire found that the pilot had a positive impact on educational attainment in English at primary level (ISCED 1). No impact was found on attainment in mathematics. There is some limited evidence from the implementation and process evaluations that the schools participating in both pilots changed their practices to align more closely with the EEF recommendations. The implications of these findings have now been adopted as part of the EEF's regional strategy.

The evaluation revealed several important components for effectiveness:

- As a known and trusted actor in the field, the EEF's teaching assistant guidance and recommendations were perceived to be credible and convincing. The implication for new intermediaries entering the field is that it is necessary to spend time building trust among stakeholders, and to consistently apply rigorous methods in order to produce work that is recognised as being of a high standard.
- If evidence is synthesised in an accessible and user-friendly way, it is much easier for training organisations to package it into training activities. This suggests that training institutes need to be considered as a major audience for intermediary work.
- System-level brokerage activities that are perceived to be effective include: providing hands-on steering to ensure fidelity to the evidence and advice on scale-up approaches; a balance of responsive support and challenge; facilitating linkages to professionals and academics; and building a bank of resources. Intermediaries should reflect on what the most impactful division of labour would be when it comes to system-level brokers, who might be in a better co-ordinating position, and local brokers, who may better understand actors' needs.
- Regarding regional/local brokerage, a wide range of activities were perceived to be effective, including: developing and delivering training and resources that have a clear purpose and focus on the research object (in this case, the guidance and recommendations); taking account of participants' prior knowledge and changes already implemented in their schools; enabling schools to contextualise the guidance, share ideas, consider issues, reflect, plan for implementation, and evaluate practice in discussion with other schools. Intermediaries should be open to experimenting with various approaches based on local feedback.
- The evidence of promise in engaging local and regional actors in supporting the contextual application of rigorous evidence led to the EEF funding a network of research schools to build more long-standing local capacity for brokering knowledge in a contextually appropriate way.

Challenges and limitations

Although a synthetic control group is an innovative indicator (see Box 6.2), the method is still relatively under-researched and does not have the same level of robustness compared to a true randomised control trial. Any regional evaluation work risks additional confounders through other regional initiatives or approaches, which explains the variation in results over and above the campaign approach that was tested. Another limitation is spill-over effects of the campaign. The recommendations from the campaign were available nationally through EEF guidance reports, so many of the comparison schools may also have made changes to their practices. The evaluation is only able to measure the additional benefit of advocates disseminating the findings of the work on TA deployment in the region.

Finally, the limited time period of the evaluation may inhibit measuring long-term impacts, such as those on students' educational attainment, and may underestimate some behavioural changes (e.g. in teaching practices) that may also take more time to occur.

Expanding the approach: Lessons for others

This EEF case study carries lessons for others and is noteworthy for three key reasons. First, it takes an approach of methodological rigour and transparency of results and applies this to a knowledge mobilisation intervention. In doing so, it illustrates the benefits of "practising what you preach", which can be brought to the work of intermediaries. For instance, undertaking the pilot evaluations has shown that linear methods (i.e. producing a guidance report) are effective when coupled with relational and systematic capacity building.

Secondly, it reveals a number of important insights that can help build a cumulative knowledge base upon which intermediaries can draw for their knowledge mobilisation work. Namely, implementation in schools appears to be more effective when there is senior leader understanding; a commitment to change; change agents that are capable, enthusiastic and enabled to effect change; and a clear process for implementation with time allocated for each activity. School leadership needs to be involved at key points.

Finally, the EEF case pioneers the use of synthetic control groups to estimate impact over large geographical areas in natural experiments, explicitly targeting one of the biggest methodological difficulties of evaluating knowledge mobilisation interventions. This synthetic control group method could be applied in other knowledge mobilisation evaluation contexts.

Conclusion

Developing a common understanding of what constitutes evaluation, and how to measure impact in some areas, is required for new knowledge mobilisation initiatives to build on knowledge gained from existing ones. This is especially important in the context of rapid expansion of intermediaries active in systems and a proliferation of knowledge mobilisation activities in education. An OECD review of the knowledge mobilisation literature found that a lack of evaluation continues to hamper the effectiveness of knowledge intermediary practices in education (Torres and Steponavičius, 2022[12]). The gap is especially worrisome for the perceived legitimacy of the work of formal intermediaries, since these organisations are often positioned as standard setters within an education system when it comes to evidence-informed policy and practice. It is therefore necessary for their credibility that they systematically and routinely investigate if the knowledge mobilisation activities they undertake are indeed effective (Gough, Sharples and Maidment, 2022[11]).

At present, there is a tendency among intermediaries to focus on self-reported indicators and easily available data. Although this is a necessary starting point, the inherent limitations of these indicators may negatively affect the development, support and perception of their work in the longer term (Torres and

Steponavičius, 2022[12]). Furthermore, gathering monitoring indicators, although an important first step, only becomes evaluation when there is critical reflection on what is measured. This is where engagement with key methodologies, such as impact evaluation and realist evaluation, is required. Further research investigating the use and respective value of these methods would be illuminating.

Developing effective evaluation of knowledge mobilisation initiatives is not just about carrying out more and better evaluations (although, this is also needed). It also involves developing the capacity for evaluative thinking (i.e. a mindset of professional collective reflection on tasks and initiatives) across intermediaries and the system. Supportive leadership and training for intermediaries, at the organisational level but also at the system level, can help build awareness about the importance of both evaluation and evaluative thinking in contributing to wider, system-level improvements. Leadership can help to ensure there are more resources for evaluation (time and funding), and that there is better awareness of principles of evaluation by allocating staff time to training and capacity building. Leadership is also important from the perspective of deciding how much time and resources to dedicate to a given evaluation activity, and ensuring this is proportionate to the time and resources invested in the initiative itself.

In terms of a future research agenda, it would be helpful to dig deeper into what intermediaries understand by “evaluation” in different categories, and what would motivate them to conduct evaluations. A mandate to conduct systematic or rigorous evaluation is a good baseline – but is still missing in many organisations and systems. Beyond this, good quality evaluation is arguably more likely to arise from motivation that goes beyond accountability mechanisms (e.g. evaluation because it is required by a funder). There is also scope for much more conceptual and empirical experimentation when it comes to developing measurements for complex social indicators that show the impact of intermediary activities. The work that has been done suggests measuring these indicators may never be systematic in the same way that measuring simpler indicators can be. However, such work is still needed to improve existing practice and build the evidence base on which new or emerging intermediaries can draw.

Reflection questions

For intermediary organisations

- How does your organisation currently define and approach the evaluation of its knowledge mobilisation activities? What are the key challenges in your existing evaluation processes?
- What are the primary barriers your organisation faces in evaluating knowledge mobilisation activities (e.g. lack of funding, time, skills)? What strategies could be employed to overcome these barriers?
- What is the mindset and skillset in your organisation regarding conducting diverse types of evaluations? (If unknown, how might you address potential training needs?)
- How does your organisation use evaluation findings? How does it disseminate them (e.g. to external audiences)?
- What role could external partnerships play in the process of building capacity and knowledge of evaluation processes in your organisation?

For policy makers

- What types of evaluation are commonly undertaken to evaluate knowledge mobilisation in your system? How are these co-ordinated (who selects initiatives to evaluate, who funds them, how is evaluation incentivised)?
- How is evaluation data and evidence used in policy-making processes?
- What steps could be taken to cultivate a stronger culture of evaluative thinking across the system? How can leadership support the integration of systematic evaluation practices?
- What measures can be implemented to support both the quantity and quality of evaluations that are undertaken by intermediaries in your system (beyond accountability)?
- How does your ministry/department of education evaluate its use of research evidence?
- How can your ministry/department of education allocate funding to evaluation in a way that promotes a cumulative research base for knowledge mobilisation?

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Notes

[1] A Theory of Change is an evidence-based rationale that builds a causal analysis to explain how a set of activities and outputs are expected to lead to a specific change.

[2] For further reading, see: https://www.betterevaluation.org/tools-resources/logic-models-tool-for-effective-program-planning-collaboration-monitoring

7 Knowledge mobilisation as an engine for education research to fly

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This chapter brings together the lessons learned from this report. It begins by elaborating on the state of knowledge mobilisation in education, according to the research literature and analysis of the OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education, including the developments and challenges reported in OECD countries. The chapter then plots several possible courses of action for policy and intermediary actors to improve their knowledge mobilisation efforts. Finally, it offers short- and long-term options for future international efforts, ranging from modest to bold.

Introduction

Using data from the 2023 OECD Survey of Knowledge Mobilisation in Education (henceforth, the intermediaries' survey), this report has explored the experiences, perspectives and activities of a diverse range of educational organisations that foster the use of evidence in policy and practice. As a first international effort that moves beyond merely formal knowledge intermediaries, the intermediaries' survey aimed to **characterise knowledge mobilisation activities and their effectiveness and impact across different organisations**. It collected data from 288 intermediary organisations in 34 countries, which included formal knowledge intermediaries, public intermediaries (embedded in public administration), research institutes, initial teacher education institutes, inspectorates and quality assurance agencies, teacher unions and consulting firms.

As emphasised throughout this report, the analysis provided has some limitations originating from the survey design and the data sources. Despite these limitations, this analysis provides the most comprehensive overview of self-reported data focused exclusively on knowledge mobilisation in education to date. To complement survey data, this report also presented eight case studies from seven countries showcasing knowledge mobilisation practices at different levels of the education system by different types of organisations. The combined quantitative and qualitative data helped to paint a comprehensive picture of the state of knowledge mobilisation today in OECD education systems, allowed for some cautious implications and, more importantly, provided food for thought for improving this field.

This final chapter summarises the key developments in the field of knowledge mobilisation and the gaps and challenges that remain to be addressed. It then provides a set of pointers for different actors on how they might contribute to addressing these. Finally, it outlines ways forward for further research efforts and for international actors' work on knowledge mobilisation itself.

While this synthesis draws primarily on the chapters of this report, it also incorporates conclusions that have emerged from the OECD's previous analyses on knowledge mobilisation (OECD, 2022[1]; OECD, 2023[2]). These include analyses of the 2021 OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education Research policy survey, which collected data from 37 ministries of education in 29 countries, as well as analyses of the follow-up interviews of the two surveys, and in-depth conversations with several intermediary and policy actors.

The state of knowledge mobilisation: Developments and challenges

The findings of this report help identify the major developments in making the thoughtful and systematic use of evidence a reality, as well as the major gaps that remain.

Developments in the field

There is an increasing body of education research, which includes a range of research methodologies, such as experimental designs, cross-sectional quantitative studies and qualitative research; all of which are potentially valuable sources to inform and improve policy and practice across the world (Van Damme, 2024[3]). While some actors call for a more concerted effort to further improve the quality of education research (see e.g. Van Damme's and Schneider's opinion pieces in (OECD, 2022[1])), there is also a need to systematically mobilise the knowledge already available.

Education research is increasingly synthesised and made accessible to policy makers and practitioners

Many organisations reported that they disseminate research evidence in user-friendly formats, such as briefs. Evidence repositories are increasing in number; the most well-known national repositories are the

Education Endowment Foundation's (EEF) Teaching and Learning Toolkit in the United Kingdom and the What Works Clearinghouse's (WWC) repository in the United States. A well-known international example is the repository of impact evaluations of the Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL). However, the intermediaries' survey results suggest that there are many more repositories beyond these well-known examples. Among survey respondents, 99 organisations claimed to curate and maintain an evidence repository. The types of evidence that repositories gather range from a collection of individual studies of various methodologies – through repositories specialised on intervention studies (experimental and quasi-experimental designs) – to systematic reviews. Examples of recent efforts of this latter type of evidence include the reviews produced by the Norwegian Knowledge Centre (NKC) and the German DIPF | Leibniz Institute for Research and Information in Education. Repositories can serve as key access points of evidence syntheses for policy makers and practitioners, and can greatly facilitate research mobilisation, especially if they are presented in accessible formats.

Numerous educational actors engage in knowledge mobilisation activities, and some have accumulated substantive experience

The intermediaries' survey revealed that almost all respondent organisations engage in some form of knowledge mobilisation, at least sometimes (hence the title of this report). There are more and more formal intermediaries, and they cover an increasingly wide geographical area. In the survey, 56 organisations from 23 countries identified themselves as a formal intermediary. Several of these have been established (or have extended their scope) recently. For example, Leerpunt in Flanders was set up in 2023, while the Netherlands Initiative for Education Research (NRO) is shifting its scope from a funding organisation to a full-fledged knowledge mobilisation agency (see the Netherlands case study in Chapter 3). However, it is not just formal intermediaries that play a role in knowledge mobilisation. Research institutions and consulting firms are particularly active, but initial teacher education providers, inspectorates and teacher unions also care about mobilising evidence.

A few organisations, such as the EEF in the United Kingdom, have accumulated substantial experience in how to mobilise knowledge well (or at least better) and also some hard evidence on how to do this effectively. More recent players have also applied innovative approaches to knowledge mobilisation. The knowledge mobilisation practices presented in the eight case studies of this report all demonstrated some unique or promising features that are worth attention (see Table 7.1 for a brief summary of these).

Table 7.1. Features of the case studies included in this report

Country (system)	Type of organisation(s)	Unique features of the knowledge mobilisation initiatives
Netherlands	Formal intermediaries (embedded in public administration and independent)	• Two system-wide and complementary knowledge mobilisation efforts with substantive funding from government; their activities include linear, relational and systems approaches: needs-based research production and transfer, co-creation and capacity building • Co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation in a small, decentralised system
United Kingdom (England)	Research institution and funding organisation	• Systemic mapping of knowledge mobilisation actors and the policy context to maximise the impact of research projects
Japan	Teacher training institution	• Dialogues to build shared understanding of evidence across actors (researchers, policy makers and practitioners) in a hierarchical system
United States	Formal intermediaries, research institutions, consulting firms, etc.	• Government-funded groups of actors supporting knowledge mobilisation at the state and local levels in a federal, highly decentralised system • Connecting national-level (top-down) and local (bottom-up) knowledge mobilisation efforts • Evaluation of programme impact and dissemination of impact stories

Country (system)	Type of organisation(s)	Unique features of the knowledge mobilisation initiatives
Latvia	Public intermediary (ministry of education)	• Government funding schemes that generate policy-relevant research through involving the research community • Cross-sectoral funding approach and balance of foundational and applied research
Chile	Formal intermediary (NGO)	• Support of the uptake of evidence-based practices in several countries and evaluation of their impact • A diverse funding model with advantages and limitations
United Kingdom (England)	Formal intermediary (charity)	• Rigorous impact evaluation of a knowledge mobilisation effort, with sophisticated impact measures
Germany	Research institution	• Combination of a knowledge mobilisation unit with transversal responsibilities of other units in an organisation to support evaluation • Both external, formal evaluation of knowledge mobilisation efforts and internal, formative evaluation to foster evaluative thinking

Overall, the substantial growth in knowledge mobilisation activity and the much-needed efforts at synthesising knowledge are reassuring. The fact that this activity has been taking place across many systems, organisations and individual actors suggests that the agenda of evidence-informed policy and practice has been increasingly embraced.

Gaps and challenges

The rapidly accumulating experience of intermediaries and the growing body of research on knowledge mobilisation can provide systems and organisations with guidance on improving intermediary functions. However, there are still important obstacles that the field is facing.

> *Knowledge mobilisation activities are not sufficiently co-ordinated within and across systems, nor are the increasing number of evidence repositories*

Within the rich and diverse landscape of knowledge mobilisation activities illustrated in this report, a key challenge is to ensure that these are effective, but also that they meaningfully complement each other. This requires an awareness across the actors of who does what in the system and an understanding of the needs, interests and capacity of different organisations to make sure that "the right actors play the right roles".

The OECD's numerous interactions with a range of major formal and public intermediaries suggest that there is very little effort to co-ordinate across the different evidence repositories. The lack of co-ordination across intermediaries, and in particular, evidence repositories, has two major implications. First, policy makers and practitioners often do not have any guidance on what kind of evidence they can find and where. There is a lot of research out there, but it can be very difficult and time-consuming to find synthesised evidence on a given topic of interest. It is equally difficult to judge the quality of that research, as evidence repositories use different quality standards and some of them are not transparent about their criteria. The transferability of the evidence across contexts can also be hard to assess for users. Second, the un-co-ordinated efforts of evidence syntheses may result in duplication of work and gaps in evidence, reflecting inefficient use of resources. In addition, most evidence repositories are practice-focused (e.g. EEF, WWC, NKC, DIPF mentioned above), while much less evidence is tailored for policy purposes.

> *Research on knowledge mobilisation itself has not been synthesised, and evaluations are still lacking*

The growing body of knowledge and experience on knowledge mobilisation itself has not been synthesised and made widely and easily accessible to intermediaries. In addition, there are still knowledge gaps,

notably on the effectiveness of various knowledge mobilisation activities. This likely originates from low levels of evaluation of current knowledge mobilisation initiatives. Evaluation practices are often sporadic and limited to simple metrics, such as counting the number of citations or event participants. A lack of causal evidence of "what works" in knowledge mobilisation and a lack of synthesis of existing knowledge makes it difficult for new intermediaries to easily develop robust strategies and work plans, and for existing intermediaries to improve their strategies and activities.

Intermediary actors lack learning opportunities to build capacity and share their experiences

The intermediaries' survey data showed that very few organisations develop the skills and capacity of intermediaries to effectively broker knowledge. An important form of building the knowledge base on knowledge mobilisation would be to generate self- and peer-reflection on knowledge mobilisation initiatives across intermediaries. However, while some of these actors have substantive experience and engage in innovative practices, knowledge exchange to facilitate deep forms of peer learning across intermediaries might still be limited, as suggested by the lack of capacity building for intermediary actors reported in the intermediaries' survey. Some notable efforts include the Global Partnership for Education Knowledge and Innovation Exchange (GPE-KIX) initiative and Jacobs Foundation's education policy labs (IDRC, 2024[4]; Jacobs Foundation, 2024[5]) – both supporting countries primarily in the Global South in evidence use, the Transforming Evidence Network (Transforming Evidence, 2024[6])– a cross-sectoral forum for evidence experts to share knowledge, and the more recent Evidence for Education Network (EEF, 2024[7]) – a network of EEF's partners that supports evidence generation and the adaption of their Toolkit. But more effort is needed to provide structured capacity building and peer learning on knowledge mobilisation for intermediaries, tailored to their needs.

Lessons for different actors

To effectively build on the aforementioned developments and address remaining challenges, action is required from all parts of the system to strengthen the impact of education research. The following suggestions are targeted at policy and intermediary actors – the respondents of the two OECD surveys.

Policy actors

Policy organisations could play a role in co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation activities, building on relevant evidence

Policy organisations need to draw on evidence on knowledge mobilisation to build effective mechanisms. This involves reflecting on evidence use in policy and understanding how this can be improved in their own organisations. In addition to rethinking evidence use in their own area, policy organisations can also reflect on the actions they can take to support other actors. Notably, linear, relational and systems approaches should be applied to the field of knowledge mobilisation.

Both ministries of education and local authorities would benefit from mapping intermediary actors in their country or region, and reflecting on the roles they are playing or should/could be playing in knowledge mobilisation. While there is no one across-the-board approach in terms of which organisations should do what, some roles can be more clearly attributed to certain types of organisations (e.g. initial teacher education institutes could develop teachers' research literacy and use skills). An optimal distribution of roles may require an assessment of intermediaries' capacity, needs and interests.

Such a mapping, capacity assessment and reflection on roles could be the basis for co-ordinating knowledge mobilisation at different levels. This involves creating appropriate incentives for different types of intermediaries so that they can carry out their work effectively. Diverging perspectives between policy

makers and intermediaries demonstrate the need for improved communication about knowledge mobilisation mechanisms and available resources. Co-ordination could be mandated to major formal intermediaries, or central agencies (ministries, local authorities) could provide grants for intermediary networks to facilitate co-ordination and collaboration. Terms of reference of grants should align with the evidence: allocating sufficient resources for long-term collaboration, capacity building of diverse actors and evaluation mechanisms.

To generate further evidence on knowledge mobilisation, central leadership in ministries and local agencies needs to support more systematic and thoughtful evaluation. While evaluating everything all the time may be not possible, regular and rigorous evaluations of major knowledge mobilisation programmes are important. This should be accompanied by encouraging a culture of evaluative thinking, where self- and peer-reflection is integrated into intermediary actors' standard practice.

Intermediary actors

Formal intermediaries could support co-ordination and capacity building, and be role models in evaluative thinking

Just like policy organisations, formal intermediaries need to use knowledge mobilisation research and effectively combine linear, relational and systems approaches. They can support all the systemic efforts of policy organisations, such as the systematic mapping of actors and their activities, and the co-ordination of knowledge mobilisation activities (locally or more broadly). Formal intermediary organisations could play an important role in designing and implementing capacity building for their own staff and other intermediary actors to develop brokerage skills. These organisations should be role models in developing evaluative thinking around knowledge mobilisation. This can involve systematically reflecting on and, to the extent possible, evaluating and measuring the impact of their own activities, as well as supporting or conducting rigorous evaluations of other actors' activities.

Research organisations could strengthen policy- and practice-engagement and fill research gaps on knowledge mobilisation

Currently, research institutions' focus is primarily concentrated on evidence generation and dissemination. In an effort to build a robust knowledge base in education, research institutions can pay greater attention to generating research that responds to practice and policy needs. To do so, they need to assess and build the capacity of the research community to engage with policy makers and practitioners, to develop a greater understanding of their contexts and to build effective partnerships. When research is generated through research-practice or research-policy partnerships, research institutions can also play a role in building the research literacy and engagement skills of practitioners and policy makers.

Research institutions can also invest in conducting research on knowledge mobilisation itself to extend this body of evidence beyond Anglo-Saxon countries. Diverse, international research collaborations can ensure that knowledge mobilisation practices are explored in various contexts and that their transferability is examined. Research should also move beyond descriptive studies of interventions and contribute to rigorous evaluations of knowledge mobilisation activities. Importantly, there is a need to apply more complex indicators of impact, as well as methodologies for measuring these.

Practice-focused organisations could focus more on developing practitioners' research engagement skills, and generate and mobilise evidence in their context

Despite the prevalence of evidence dissemination and partnership-building efforts, there is still a lack of support for building practitioners' capacity in research engagement. Initial teacher education institutions and professional development providers should collaboratively build these skills to enable teachers and

school leaders to access relevant evidence and thoughtfully engage with it to improve teaching and school practices.

Inspectorates and quality assurance agencies generate valuable data and evidence on school and teaching quality. Some of these institutions have a pure accountability mandate, while others also provide support for schools or school boards – depending on the context. The former type can support the use of their evidence in policy making not just through publishing reports (which many of them do) but also more varied knowledge mobilisation activities, such as directly supporting ministries in policy design and implementation. The latter type can do the same not just for policy organisations, but also schools.

Teacher and school leader unions in some countries are engaged in generating evidence (e.g. through teacher surveys) and supporting its mobilisation, primarily in policy. For unions that generate evidence, it is important to have sufficient research capacity to ensure that this evidence is rigorous. Unions can work with other intermediary actors to support the mobilisation of this evidence.

Funders need to provide more comprehensive funding structures and target a broader set of actors and actions

The way knowledge mobilisation is currently funded often does not align well with the needs of policy makers, practitioners or even the rhetoric of funding organisations regarding co-created solutions. Funding for both research generation and mobilisation needs to extend to a broader array of education actors, rather than being concentrated among research institutions and formal intermediaries. To optimise knowledge mobilisation, funders must take a more inclusive approach, rebalancing funding towards schools and practitioners who are at the forefront of classroom and school innovation. Researchers and practitioners alike require targeted wrap-around schemes that combine financial support with training, networking and tailored support services to provide a more comprehensive development of the capacity of local actors to mobilise knowledge effectively.

Funding structures also need to appropriately reflect the time, effort and money needed to actually use research. More flexibility in funding schemes would support planning for impact as the context of research use becomes known. Importantly, funding needs to be allocated for evaluating research mobilisation efforts.

Ways forward: Short- and long-term pathways to improve knowledge mobilisation in policy and practice

The analyses emanating from the OECD Strengthening the Impact of Education research project (OECD, 2022[1]; OECD, 2023[2]), including this report and the applied work conducted with countries through meetings and learning seminars (OECD, 2024[8]), have helped countries to think about ways to improve knowledge mobilisation in their education systems. In 2024, during the Belgian presidency of the European Union, the European Commission accepted Council Conclusions on promoting evidence-informed policy and practice in education and training (Council of the European Union, 2024[9]) that draw heavily on OECD work. This work has also contributed to many other intermediary efforts (see e.g. Hayter and Morales (2023[10]), UNESCO (2024[11]), Ward and Mouthaan in Baek and Steiner-Khamsi (2024[12])). While such impact is important, more work is needed to ensure the systematic and high-quality use of education research in policy and practice.

The developments outlined in this chapter can act as levers to drive further change. Three desired long-term **outcomes** can be envisaged **for the future of evidence-informed policy and practice**:

- Countries (policy makers) have data and evidence on effective knowledge mobilisation, and tools to improve it in their system.

- Organisations and actors with knowledge intermediary roles know and apply effective mechanisms of knowledge mobilisation.
- Actors learn from each other and collaborate constructively in the production, mobilisation and use of quality and relevant research.

Achieving these outcomes requires concerted effort; this chapter has described ways in which different actors can contribute to such effort. In addition, international organisations can play a role in generating peer learning and co-ordinating certain efforts at the international level. The OECD is itself a knowledge intermediary and, as such, it needs to reflect on how it can improve its knowledge mobilisation activities.

Short-term modest and not-so-modest pathways forward

The next step for international work on promoting knowledge mobilisation and for international actors such as the OECD could be more practical co-ordination work to support achieving the above-mentioned outcomes through the following pillars:

Supporting intermediaries in driving the generation of policy- and practice-relevant evidence in education (quite bold)

Addressing the challenge of misalignment and lack of co-ordination across evidence repositories involves co-ordinating evidence syntheses and databases across key intermediaries. This would require technical explorations, such as the alignment of the underlying data structures of repositories (individual studies behind evidence syntheses), and testing how stronger connections can be made between them. It could extend to conceiving a platform that gathers and connects existing evidence syntheses and repositories in collaboration with the organisations hosting these.

Synthesising knowledge mobilisation research and making it accessible (somewhat modest)

Supporting the effective mobilisation of knowledge mobilisation research could involve creating a resource bank of evidence-informed practical tools that support designing knowledge mobilisation strategies, mapping actors and mechanisms, assessing capacity for knowledge mobilisation, developing policy-research and research-practice partnerships, etc. Such tools could take the form of thematic research briefs, frameworks and vignettes with use cases, and in-depth case studies showcasing effective knowledge mobilisation initiatives. To support more sophisticated evaluations, a framework of the impact of knowledge mobilisation initiatives could also be developed.

Capacity building and peer-learning for intermediaries (modest)

Filling the gap of developing intermediary actors' capacity could involve needs-based thematic peer-learning events on knowledge mobilisation to support intermediaries in developing and improving their strategies and activities. Focusing on formal intermediaries in a first stage could make these organisations multipliers who could then build the capacity of other actors in their national contexts. Public intermediaries, i.e. knowledge and analytical units within ministries of education, could also be a key target group to get support in improving knowledge mobilisation in policy and practice.

Long term modest and bold pathways forward

In the long term, the OECD could play a role in maintaining and extending the aforementioned short-term plans. However, to ensure long-term impact, diverse national and international actors need to work together.

Create a robust knowledge base on knowledge mobilisation: Extend research of intermediaries (modest) and regularly update and synthesise this (bold)

In addition to the various directions for future research on knowledge mobilisation outlined in this and the two previous reports (e.g. beyond Anglo-Saxon countries, more evaluations of interventions and initiatives) (OECD, 2022[1]; OECD, 2023[2]), the mapping of the knowledge mobilisation landscape could also be further extended. The intermediaries' survey did not include several actors who might play important knowledge mobilisation roles. Future efforts could map professional development providers and umbrella organisations, such as professional associations, policy and research networks. Importantly, the intermediaries' survey focused on actors within national education systems, while it did not include international organisations, such as the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank, nor think tanks and consulting firms of international scope, many of which provide public consultancy services.

As research on knowledge mobilisation extends, including more evaluations that provide information on what works, it will be necessary to regularly synthesise this research, e.g. through systematic reviews and meta-analyses. In addition, more cross-sectoral research synthesis can strengthen learning from knowledge mobilisation in other fields. An important condition of improving the use of evidence is to support all types of intermediary actors in producing, accessing and using this body of knowledge.

Create and sustain a self-improving intermediary ecosystem (bold)

The goal should be for the intermediary field to become an organic, self-developing ecosystem maintained and supported by adequate resources and incentive structures. This ecosystem should be able to systematically identify research gaps, thereby providing input for countries, research funding organisations and research institutions to drive a more robust knowledge building in education through relevant research grants and projects. It should also synthesise evidence in a cost-effective and co-ordinated way and provide policy makers and practitioners with adequate support to mobilise this evidence in their decisions.

To achieve this goal, it will be necessary to systematically map evidence repositories and systematise their content in an accessible and easy-to-navigate way over time. In turn, this necessitates supporting continuous collaboration of a range of intermediaries, towards a collective development of evidence syntheses with structured information about their quality and transferability across contexts. Maintaining the network of intermediaries is also necessary to ensure sustained peer learning and continuous development of the knowledge base on effective knowledge mobilisation.

Both short- and long-term pathways envisaged above are obviously resource-intensive – but is it not worth investing in the engine of education research to make it fly and help build efficient and equitable education systems across the world?

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Educational Research and Innovation

Everybody Cares About Using Education Research Sometimes

Perspectives of Knowledge Intermediaries

Building on the insights of the first two publications in the Strengthening the Impact of Education Research series, this third and final report shifts the focus from policy makers to the field, exploring the pivotal role of knowledge intermediaries. These organisations facilitate engagement with research among policy makers and practitioners, supporting evidence-informed decision making and practices in education. Drawing on new data from 288 such organisations across 34 countries, the report delves into the ways these intermediaries bridge the gap between education research, policy and practice. It highlights their efforts to disseminate evidence, foster collaboration, and build capacity for research use, while also identifying gaps in skills and infrastructure that demonstrate the need for further professionalisation of knowledge mobilisation.

By offering actionable insights for policy makers, practitioners, researchers and intermediaries, this report emphasises the importance of co-ordination, evaluative thinking, and system-level strategies to maximise the impact of education research. It serves as a valuable resource for those seeking to understand and enhance the landscape of knowledge mobilisation, ensuring that education systems are better equipped to integrate evidence into policy and practice.

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